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Paper 1 of 1 — Eng 112 past question 2026/2027

Level 100 • First Semester • Handout

FILM THEORY & CRITICISM

COMPREHENSIVE LECTURE & REFERENCE GUIDE

Definition: Film theory refers to the systemic framework of ideas, models, and principles used to study, analyze, interpret, and understand cinema. Rather than just reviewing a plot, film theory unpacks how motion pictures construct meaning, manipulate audience psychology, propagate structural ideology, and visually reflect or refract societal values.

Why Film Theory Matters

Developing a robust theoretical toolkit enables students, scholars, and critics to:

- Analyze motion pictures critically beyond surface-level plot lines.
- Deconstruct media influence and recognize covert ideological agendas.
- Decode complex visual semantics, symbolism, and systemic subtexts.
- Evaluate structural relationships between texts, industries, and audiences.

THE SEVEN CORE FRAMEWORKS

1. APPARATUS THEORY

Conceptual Overview

Apparatus theory analyzes how the physical technology, material mechanics, and institutional architecture of cinema influence and actively position the spectator. Derived from Marxist, psychoanalytic, and semiotic schools, this theory argues that cinema is fundamentally an ideological

medium that masks its own construction to maintain authority over the observer.

The Cinematic "Apparatus"

The term apparatus refers to the entire integrated framework of production and consumption, which

includes:

- The Capturing Mechanics: Cameras, lensing, and specific capture settings.
- The Post-Production Infrastructure: Editing systems, chemical/digital processing, and sound mixing.
- The Exhibition Environment: The physical dark room, seating placement, project alignment, and the monolithic projection screen.

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Core Tenets

- The Construction of Illusion: Cinema tricks the brain into seeing a sequence of static cells as living, flowing reality. By rendering fictional narratives completely immersive, it naturally neutralizes structural critique.
- Visual Domination & Perspective: The audience does not see choice-free reality; they occupy the exact optical perspective dictated by the camera lens. Low angles mechanically enforce power;

extreme close-ups manufacture visceral psychological proximity.

- Ideological Subjugation: The spectator sits immobile in a dark room, silent and isolated, looking up at a vast glowing screen. This exact physical environment strips viewers of active agency, encouraging uncritical internalizations of the values displayed on screen.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

Action Blockbusters: Use hyper-frequent cuts and explosive low-angle tracking shots to generate artificial physical stress, ensuring viewers are too sensory-stimulated to analyze geopolitical or militaristic subtexts.

Melodramas: Rely on forced, slow close-ups paired with heavy orchestral music to force specific, predetermined tears from an uncritical audience.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Opposing media theorists argue that apparatus theory assumes a completely passive, defenseless viewer. It discounts the viewer's cognitive intelligence, individual lived experiences, and capacity for selective, critical, or subversive reading.

2. AUTEUR THEORY

Conceptual Overview

Originating in the pages of the French journal *Cahiers du Cinéma*, Auteur Theory argues that the director is the singular, true authorial voice of a film. Despite film creation being a massive collaborative machine involving hundreds of technicians, this framework asserts that an authentic creative artist overrides industrial structures to leave an undeniable personal stamp on their body of work.

Defining Characteristics of an Auteur

- Technical Mastery & Visual Style: Consistent use of specific frame arrangements, colors, lens choices, lighting patterns, and camera movements across an entire career.
- Thematic Signature: A recurring, deeply personal exploration of particular philosophical concepts, moral conflicts, or social anxieties.
- Structural Hegemony: The director exercises extreme command over all auxiliary departments, from casting choices and screenwriting edits to final negative cuts.

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ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

- Alfred Hitchcock: Defined by themes of voyeurism, innocent men wrongfully accused, intense suspense, and meticulous storyboarding.
- Quentin Tarantino: Instantly recognizable through sharp non-linear storytelling, pop-culture dialogue, saturated color palettes, and stylized violence.
- Christopher Nolan: Marked by obsessive examinations of structural memory, temporal distortion, intellectual cross-cutting, and practical visual mastery.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Critics argue that Auteur theory heavily romanticizes individual genius. It systematically ignores the immense creative contributions of screenwriters, cinematographers, film editors, sound designers, and talented actors who frequently shape a film's identity.

3. COGNITIVE FILM THEORY

Conceptual Overview

In direct opposition to frameworks that view audiences as passive or governed by unconscious desires, Cognitive Film Theory focuses on how viewers employ conscious mental faculties to process,

interpret, and unpack cinematic text. It bridges the arts with empirical psychology, focusing on memory systems, active hypothesis testing, and neural perception.

Primary Areas of Inquiry

- **Visual Perception:** The physical and mental mechanisms through which the brain converts rapid visual edits and sound bytes into a cohesive, spatial reality.
- **Narrative Comprehension:** The active intellectual processes used by viewers to collect narrative clues, track character motivations, project future plot points, and map out complicated timelines.
- **Emotional Logic:** How stylistic film choices (like music cues or pacing changes) interface with natural cognitive triggers to create genuine, conscious states of fear, suspense, empathy, or joy.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

The Cinematic Mystery (e.g., Whodunits): The film operates as an intellectual playground. The director feeds the viewer specific visual clues, and the audience processes information, references memory logs, and continuously updates their internal theories to solve the mystery in real time.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

By treating the brain like an isolated computer processor, cognitive theory often downplays the deep impact of cultural conditioning, local politics, gender perspectives, and broader socioeconomic ideologies.

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4. FEMINIST FILM THEORY

Conceptual Overview

Feminist Film Theory investigates how cinema produces and replicates patriarchal power structures,

gender hierarchies, and sexual stereotypes. Emerging during the Second-Wave Feminist movement, it

aims to deconstruct how female characters are represented on screen and analyze the political realities of women working behind the scenes.

The Concept of "The Male Gaze"

Coined by scholar Laura Mulvey in her seminal essay *Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema*, the concept explains

that classic Hollywood cinema is structured around three distinct viewpoints: the camera, the male

characters within the narrative, and the male spectator in the audience. Together, these viewpoints position women primarily as passive objects of visual and sexual desire.

Key Focus Areas

- **The Politics of Representation:** Analyzing whether female characters are fleshed out with complex psychological agency, or reduced to flat, decorative tropes designed to support a male protagonist's arc.
- **Structural Exclusions:** Highlighting the historic underrepresentation of women in leadership positions like directing, screenwriting, and studio management.
- **Deconstructing Stereotypes:** Dissecting reductive cinematic types such as the helpless damsel, the dangerous femme fatale, or the overly emotional housewife.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

Traditional Action Cinema: The camera often sweeps across a female character's body with slow, fragmented close-ups before she says a single line of dialogue. Her primary role is to be rescued by the male protagonist, reinforcing systemic ideas of male agency and female dependence.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Early iterations of feminist theory were criticized for being overly focused on white, heterosexual frameworks. Modern intersectional feminist theory has expanded to address how gender, race, sexuality, and socioeconomic class interact with representation.

5. LINGUISTIC FILM THEORY (SEMIOTICS)

Conceptual Overview

Linguistic Film Theory, heavily rooted in Semiotics, treats cinema as an intricate system of language

and signs. Rather than looking at a movie as a mirror of reality, this theory argues that films use specific structural grammar rules, symbolic signs, and visual codes to communicate complex meanings to an audience.

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The Structural Elements of Film Grammar

- **The Vocabulary of Shots:** Distinct framing choices carry inherent semantic meaning. Close-ups denote deep psychological intimacy; wide shots signal isolation or grand scope.
- **Syntactical Editing:** The careful arrangement and sequencing of shots alter how text is understood. Joining disparate images creates new conceptual thoughts in the viewer's mind.
- **Auditory Codes:** Diegetic or non-diegetic sounds and musical scores act as modifiers that change the meaning of visual elements.
- **Iconography & Symbolism:** Mundane items, color palettes, or set decorations that carry deeper cultural meanings.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

Weather & Lighting Symbolism: Sudden heavy rain falling during a pivotal scene is rarely just a weather event; it acts as a visual symbol for deep sadness, internal purification, or incoming tragedy.

Dark shadows cutting across a character's face visually communicate a divided moral nature or hidden secrets.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Some critics argue that linguistic theory over-intellectualizes cinema. By trying to fit movies into strict

linguistic rules, it can lose sight of the fluid, emotional, and visceral pleasures that make film unique

as an art form.

6. MARXIST FILM THEORY

Conceptual Overview

Based on the socioeconomic philosophies of Karl Marx, Marxist Film Theory analyzes cinema as an economic product that reflects class conflict, capital dominance, and institutional power. It investigates how movies serve the financial interests of the wealthy elite and function as tools to reinforce capitalist ideologies and maintain societal control.

Core Frameworks

- **Ideological State Apparatus:** Cinema often functions as a subtle tool that convinces working-class audiences to accept their economic position without resistance. It accomplishes this by framing capitalist values as normal, permanent, and natural.
- **Reification of Class Dynamics:** Dissecting how films portray wealth, industrial labor, and class differences. Movies often spread the idea that financial success stems entirely from personal effort, while poverty is framed as an individual moral failure.
- **Industrial Commodification:** Analyzing how major media monopolies control production and distribution channels to prioritize profit over artistic expression and genuine political critique.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

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Slick Materialist Films: Studio films that celebrate extreme luxury lifestyles often send a subtle message: happiness is tied directly to consumerism and wealth, which helps distract audiences from

real issues of economic exploitation.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Critics argue that Marxist theory can be overly dogmatic, reducing complex artistic expressions and personal human relationships down to simple economic equations and class conflict.

7. PSYCHOANALYTIC FILM THEORY

Conceptual Overview

Influenced by Sigmund Freud and Jacques Lacan, Psychoanalytic Film Theory argues that cinema interacts directly with our unconscious minds, hidden anxieties, repressed desires, and psychological

fantasies. The theory treats the dark theater experience as a collective dream state where our deepest

psychological urges can be safely explored on screen.

Key Psychoanalytic Concepts

- **Psychological Identification:** The process through which a spectator projects their own ego onto a character, experiencing their triumphs, traumas, and desires as their own.
- **Voyeurism and Scopophilia:** The deep, instinctual pleasure that comes from looking. Sitting unseen in a dark theater allows viewers to satisfy voyeuristic desires by peeking into the private lives of others.
- **The Manifestation of the Unconscious:** Film genres can act as a stage for collective social anxieties, giving form to hidden fears like the terror of death, abandonment, or loss of identity.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLES

The Horror Genre: Monsters, ghosts, and killers are rarely just physical threats; they often serve as visual representations of repressed psychological traumas, deep guilt, or fears of bodily vulnerability.

SCHOLARLY CRITIQUES

Many contemporary scholars view psychoanalytic film theory as overly speculative and abstract, noting that its foundational ideas lack rigorous, empirical scientific proof.

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FILM THEORY MATRIX SUMMARY

THEORETICAL CORE CONCEPTUAL FOCUS KEY ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK TARGET

Apparatus Theory How the physical technology, material The theater space, mechanics, and layout of cinema work to screen layout, and unconsciously control and influence the viewer. camera mechanics.

Auteur Theory How a director's unique vision, personal style, The director's and recurring themes make them the true author complete body of of a film. work and creative choices.

Cognitive Film Theory How audiences use active mental faculties, The viewer's mental memory systems, and conscious perception to comprehension and understand films. conscious reasoning.

Feminist Film Theory How cinema portrays women, reinforces Gender representation patriarchal power, and uses "the male gaze" to and power balances objectify female characters. on screen.

Linguistic Film Theory Analyzing cinema as a structured language Visual codes, Theory system that uses signs, symbols, and visual semiotics, editing grammar to communicate. syntax, and motifs.

Marxist Film Theory How films serve capitalist economic interests, Economic subtexts, portray class struggles, and distribute ruling- class dynamics, and class ideologies. institutional power.

Psychoanalytic Film How cinema interacts with the spectator's Audience psychology, Theory unconscious mind, repressed desires, voyeurism, dream logic, and fear and dream states. responses.

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ACADEMIC EXAMINATION ASSESSMENT

Part A: Objective Multiple-Choice Questions

1. Which theoretical framework treats the entire viewing environment—such as the dark room and projector mechanics—as an active force that influences audience ideology?

- A. Auteur Theory
- B. Apparatus Theory
- C. Cognitive Film Theory
- D. Linguistic Film Theory

Correct Answer: B

2. Film scholar Laura Mulvey introduced the concept of "the male gaze" within which theoretical tradition?

- A. Marxist Film Theory
- B. Psychoanalytic Film Theory
- C. Feminist Film Theory
- D. Auteur Theory

Correct Answer: C

3. A critic analyzing a director's entire career to trace recurring visual motifs, specific camera choices, and personal themes is using:

- A. Linguistic Film Theory
- B. Marxist Film Theory
- C. Cognitive Film Theory
- D. Auteur Theory

Correct Answer: D

4. Marxist film critics focus primarily on analyzing which of the following elements within a movie?

- A. Sound design and music choices
- B. Repressed childhood memories
- C. Economic class struggles and power dynamics
- D. Conscious problem-solving and memory logs

Correct Answer: C

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5. Semiotics, or the study of signs, symbols, and visual communication codes, forms the foundation of:

- A. Linguistic Film Theory
- B. Apparatus Theory

C. Psychoanalytic Film Theory

D. Feminist Film Theory

Correct Answer: A

Part B: Short Answer & Essay Prompts

1. Outline the main arguments of Auteur Theory. Be sure to highlight the tension between a director's personal vision and the highly collaborative nature of filmmaking.

2. Deconstruct the core concept of Laura Mulvey's "The Male Gaze" in Feminist Film Theory. Explain how classic Hollywood cinematography can position female characters as objects for visual pleasure.

3. Compare and contrast Cognitive Film Theory and Psychoanalytic Film Theory. In your answer, contrast how each framework views the spectator's mental activity and conscious awareness.

4. Using Marxist Film Theory, analyze how a mainstream Hollywood movie might subtly promote capitalist values, manage economic anxieties, or normalize wealth inequality.

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MAC225 NEWS WRITING AND REPORTING

MODULE 1 GENERAL INTRODUCTION

Unit 1 What is News?/Elements of News Values and News Virtues

Unit 2 Qualities of a News Reporter

Unit 3 What Motivates a News Reporter?

Unit 4 General Rules for News Writing

UNIT 1 WHAT IS NEWS?/ELEMENTS OF NEWS

VALUES AND NEWS VIRTUES

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1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 What is News?

3.2 Elements of News Values

3.2.1 Determinants

3.2.2 Components

3.3 News Virtues

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

At this level of your academic life and studies, it is obvious one of the words you have accustomed to is NEWS. Each day, the Federal Radio Corporation of Nigeria (FRCN) gives you the Network News at 7am, updated again at 4pm and 10pm. The same goes for the Nigerian Television Authority (NTA) News at Dawn, Network News at 9pm, and so on. And with the era of private broadcast stations, the airwaves are now replete with all kinds of news. The same is not left out in the print media where the primary content is news. Therefore, it is common to hear “Here is the News at 7 read by Funmi Makanna.” “This is CNN with the News on the Hour”. On and on like that you are bombarded with news bulletins for upward of 18 hours a day. In addition, every morning you hear vendors hawking and distributing their newspapers with all kinds of techniques. In fact, before you stepped into the Department of Mass Communication, NOUN, for this course on News Writing and Reporting, you were already familiar with the pillars (or some of them at least) on which newspaper work is based. Therefore, for this course, before we delve into the rudiments of News Writing and

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Reporting, we must first and foremost understand what is news and the nature of news.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- define news
- identify and describe elements of news values
- identify and describe news virtues
- identify and explain the determinants and the components of news.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 What is News?

News is one of the most difficult issues to define in mass communication. There are almost as many definitions of news as there are journalists. Even laymen in the streets can readily come up with acceptable definitions of news. In general terms, news is very relative and depends on what one thinks is news. At any given moment, millions of events happen simultaneously throughout the world. “Obasanjo sacks Education Minister”, “FRA Williams dies,” “Super Eagles thrashes Gabon,” “Obama wins Re-election, Clinton in Sex Scandal, and so on are potentially news. However, they do not become news until some reporters give an account of them. In other words, news is the account of

an event, not the event itself.

We can now consider some definitions given by scholars and media professionals thus:

William S. Maulsby defined news thus:

- News is an accurate, unbiased account of the significant facts of a timely happening that is of interest to the readers of the newspaper that prints the account.

William G. Bleyer defines it like this:

- News is anything timely that interests a number of people; and the best news is that which has the greatest interest for the greatest number.

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Mitchel Chainley defined news as:

- The timely report of facts or opinions that hold interest of importance, or both for a considerable number of people.

Prof. Charles Coates defined it thus:

- News is what interests the reader, the viewer, the reporter, the editor, the producer, their spouses and their neighbours. News is what affects their diets and their lives.

Sam Zelman of CNN says:

- News is what is important because of its impact on society; it is what people need to know and what they want to know.

There have been other numerous definitions of news but interwoven in all of this is the fact that news must be something of interest to a significant number of people. In this regard, the nature of news is always changing because community interests and standards are always changing. For instance, the Western definition of news emphasises an event that is out of the ordinary, exciting, sensational, and of the “man-biting dog” variety. According to Lord Northcliffe, who revolutionised journalism in England between 1890 and 1920 (incidentally he died a raving lunatic but very wealthy), “if a dog bites a man, it is NOT news, but when a man bites a dog, it is News.”

This definition has since influenced Western journalists and media in the reportorial duties. To them, news is made in the developing countries only when there are scandals, coups, civil wars, uprisings, natural disasters, and so on. Western norms and values maintain that “bad” news is better than “good” news. That is why when 100 planes take off from a base to a destination and 99 of them arrive safely and one

crashes, the 99 that arrived safely will not be mentioned or reported but much noise will be made about the only one that crashed. That is news for the Western mass media and audience.

However, for this course, I will define news as an accurate, unbiased account of a current, timely event, which is reported in the mass media and is significant to a large number of people in a locality. Furthermore, in contemporary thinking, today's news is about real life, real people, real events, real places or real issues in a real world reported in real time using any available means of communication. Agbese (2008) also sees news as finding out and publishing the things people do not want others to know and second, anything that will make people talk.

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3.2 Elements of News Values

While definitions of news vary, the main determinant of what can be considered as news is "INTEREST." To be news, an account of an event must be of interest to the readers, listeners or viewers. Interest in a story is determined by the news values. The elements that determine news values may be subdivided into two groups.

- a. Determinants
- b. Components

3.2.1 Determinants

A determinant is a factor that sets the character of something, in this case, news. The determinants of news are as follow.

- a. Timeliness
- b. Proximity/geographic location
- c. Prominence/personality involved
- d. Consequence/impact/significance
- e. Human interest
- f. Novelty
- g. Conflict
- h. Necessity

Timeliness

Today's news may be stale tomorrow. Therefore, to attain that reader - viewer or listener interest or appeal, facts must be fresh. However, some issues of great impact are timeliness. Therefore, the best time to tell an important story is as soon as it happens or as soon as possible.

Proximity/Geographic Location

Distance between the news item's place of origin and its place of

publication determines its degree of reader – appeal, and the limits of reader – interest. Usually, the nearer an individual is to the location of a news event, the more relevant it becomes for him/her. This is referred to as geographic proximity.

There are two types of proximity:

- Geographical Proximity - This has been described above.
- Proximity of Interest

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An account of students' unrest in Kano will definitely interest students in Owerri than a businessman in Kano.

This is referred to as proximity of interest.

Prominence/Personality Involved

All men may be created equal, but some are more equal and more newsworthy than others. In fact, "names make news" goes a cliché. However, names do not always make news. Still, happenings that involve well-known people or institutions are likely to be interesting even if not very important.

Consequence/Impact/Significance/Magnitude

How many people an event or idea affects and how seriously it affects them determine its importance as news, as well as the extent to which the information may be useful. Again, an item or event may give rise to thought not because of itself but because of its probable consequences – its significance.

Human Interest

Interest in human beings and events because they concern men and women in situations that might confront anyone else, is called human interest. In a general way, human-interest stories might be defined as those stories that arouse an emotion in the reader/ listener/ viewer and evoke emotional response.

Novelty

This sounds like human interest but shows some differences. The unusual makes news. The bizarre makes news too. Remember the-man-bite-dog principle. The principle applies here. The first flight to the moon was big news, so was Sandra Day O' Connor's appointment as the first woman Justice of the United States Supreme Court. The day a female becomes the Vice President of the US it will be the biggest news around the globe. "Firsts," "Lasts," and "Only" have always been newsworthy. So also are stories of freak occurrences and scientific or

pseudoscientific phenomena.

Conflict

Nearly every story on each of our front pages is a report of conflict. Conflict is a central feature of most news. Sometimes it is physical, as in wars or sports. Sometimes it is more subtle and sophisticated like political conflicts.

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Necessity

The seven earlier discussed news values involve people, events and situations that call out for coverage. The value of necessity is, however, the journalist's making (Mencher, 2010). According to the Mencher (2010), the journalist has discovered something he or she feels it is necessary to disclose. The essential element here is that the journalist considers a situation to be something everyone should know about and usually it is a situation that needs to be exposed and remedied.

3.2.2 The Components of News

So far, we have been discussing the determinants of news. In this section, we shall be examining the components or the contents of news. A component is a constituent part of something. They tend to have more news values or higher news values than stories that lack them. The more of news components you find in a story, the higher the news worthiness of such a story.

Many items could easily fall into the components of news. However, we shall discuss eight that always sell a story anytime it is a content of such story. The eight components of news are:

1. Age
2. Animal
3. Sex
4. Conflict
5. Money
6. Children
7. Beauty
8. Human interest

News Virtues

Now that what news is and what determines readers' interest in a story have been discussed, reporters should strive to make the news they publish or broadcast win the credibility and confidence of their readers and listeners by adhering firmly to the triple news virtues.

These triple news virtues are:

Truth

All news stories must represent factual events and personalities. The reporter should also ensure that the facts of the News are truthful to the best of his/her knowledge before publishing or broadcasting such story.

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Objectivity

Objectivity presupposes that the reporter presents the reader with all sides of an issue, presents all the facts and allows the reader to decide what these facts mean. For a story to be objective, it must be devoid of a reporter's biases and prejudice. It must not also be slanted or editorialised.

Accuracy

This is the last news virtue. Accuracy is a pillar on which every story rests. A news story can be regarded as accurate if all names, ages, addresses and direct quotations in the story are accurate or correct. The only way to meet this requirement is for the reporter to check, double-check or even triple-check his facts before going to the press.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss the elements of news values and why you think they are important in determining a story's relevance.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Definitions of news change with time, place and who is defining it. Many media organisations and individual journalists also define news differently partially influenced by their varying backgrounds. However, what constitutes news values remains constant-interest. This interest comes in form of values. In conclusion, Thomas Griffith famous quote [cited in Mencher (2010)] becomes relevant here: "Journalism is in fact history on the run. It is history written in time to be acted upon; thereby not only recording events but also at times influencing them. Journalism is also the recording of history while the facts are not all in."

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on news and what constitutes news values and virtues. In this unit, you were specifically taught about the various definitions of news, bringing up different perspectives; the eight elements of news values and the triple news virtues, which must be present for news stories to have credibility, relevance and wide acceptance.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Why do we have many and different definitions of news?
2. Discuss the major reasons why necessity made the list of news values.
3. Which among the news values must be present for a news story to have credibility? Justify your selection.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 QUALITIES OF A NEWS REPORTER

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 Qualities of the News Reporter
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Reporters write stories, report events and happenings in and around the society. They provide the core of news stories that are published daily in our commercial newspapers or broadcast in the electronic media. As there is no substitute for good reporting, so also there is no substitute for good reporters. A good reporter is a great asset for his/her media organisation. He/she is the ear and the eye of his/her medium.

It is what he/she reports that the audience will know about. The reporter touches lives with his report.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- identify who a reporter is and what differentiates him/her from other media practitioner
- identify qualities a good reporters
- differentiate between a good reporter and a bad one.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Qualities of the News Reporter

Some of the major qualities that make a good reporter are discussed below.

S/he must have a mastery of the written or spoken language of the medium of expression: This will enable him/her to interact easily with news sources, eyewitnesses or even the victims of events.

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S/he must have a nose for news: This means the reporter or journalist must be curious about getting news from newsy or stale situations. A good reporter must have a natural instinct for news and should be able to identify news from seemingly events that may not be considered newsworthy by everyone else.

S/he must be current and keep abreast of events and happenings: In the media industry, yesterday's news is stale and no more needed. To remain relevant in the industry, therefore, the reporter must keep abreast of happenings in and around him/her.

A good reporter must be fair, accurate and objective in his news writing and reporting job. Fairness, accuracy and objectivity are news virtues, which the profession thrives on. Any attempt to compromise any of these values makes a mess of the reputation and credibility of the industry. These qualities of a reporter must be jealously guarded.

A good reporter must be creative: Creativity makes the reporter see another unique story from an already published report. Without creativity, the reporter will remain dry, uninspiring and boring to his readers and even his sources.

S/he must also have the ability to dress well: A common idiom says how you dress is how you are addressed and I add that it also betrays your address. A good reporter must know how to dress for the occasion otherwise he/she will be lost in the crowd or misrepresented. Dressing well is not necessarily dressing expensively. It only means having the right kind of dress for each occasion or situation.

A good reporter must have perseverance: Perseverance is having the

staying power and refusing to give up even when the situation calls for giving up. A good reporter must have the ability to stay longer and under stress or pressure.

A good reporter must be a “good mixer”: There is no room for the reserved kind of reporter who cannot easily get into a discussion with a potential news source. A good reporter should be able to blend easily with all kinds of persons especially when such persons are primary to getting the news he/she is pursuing at that moment. The good reporter should be able to make contacts, grow and maintain them.

S/he must have a high level of comportsment: The good reporter must have self-control and high level of comportsment no matter the situation or circumstances. He/she is not expected to be carried away easily by any surrounded situation.

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A good reporter must have the ability to embark on creative risk and courage especially in reporting coups, wars, conflicts, crime, disaster etc.

S/he must have the ability to ferret out news through the process of monitoring people and events.

S/he must also possess good observatory skills and have an eye for details: Poorly trained reporters look without seeing. The good reporter is able to see leads and news worthy situations by merely observing people and situations. Whenever the good reporter looks, he/she sees. He/she is also able to taken in a lot of details by mere observation.

S/he must be a good listener and must have an unusual patience: The poorly trained reporters are only interested in hearing their voices in an interview situation. However, a good reporter is only interested in hearing the news source talk. Therefore, listening becomes a vital quality a reporter must possess in order to succeed.

S/he should also possess enough idealism to inspire indignant prose but not too much as to obstruct detached professionalism (Ragged Right cited in Agbese, 2008).

A good and modern reporter must be multi-skilled: S/he should be equipped with an array of skills to meet the demands of diverse media users (Mencher, 2010).

A good and modern reporter must also have the unique quality called enterprise: He/she should be able to work through tougher assignments or situation by instantaneously assessing the situation and

taking decisions and steps that will give him/her what the media organisation wants.

A good reporter must also have the strength of character to lead a disrupted personal life without going absolutely haywire (Ragged Right cited in Agbese, 2008).

4.0 CONCLUSION

Good reporters are great assets to their media organisations. Not everyone who went to a journalism school usually turns out to become a good reporter. This is the primary reason they are always sought after anywhere they could be found. According to Sid Bedingfield, President, Fault Line Productions (cited in Mencher, 2010), "Reporting is the essential ingredient in good journalism. Everything else is

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dressing....The reporter is the engine that drives the newspaper, the contributor who makes the newscast worthwhile.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit specifically dealt with the qualities a good reporter who wants to work in a reputable media organisation must have. Fifteen of such qualities were discussed in this unit. Further readings may bring up some more.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. As an aspiring reporter identify and discuss five solid qualities you think you must possess to be able to assume a reportorial role in a Newspaper organisation.
2. The Nigerian media industry is a unique media terrain. Discuss 10 relevant and time-tested qualities that will help you survive as an upcoming reporter.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 3 WHAT MOTIVATES A NEWS REPORTER?

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
- 3.1 What Motivates a News Reporter?
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Reporters populate most media organisations but not all of them win the Pulitzer Prize. Those who do are usually motivated by something to do the extra, which results in awards and peer-recognition. This unit therefore focuses on the seven motivating factors identified by Byron Calame, the Public Editor of New York Times (cited in Mencher, 2010).

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the motivating factor for news reporter.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 What Motivates a News Reporter?

Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010) identified seven motivating factors while working and competing with more than a 100 reporters in his successful career as a reporter and editor.

Being first with new facts or fresh insights

Every reporter really desires to be the first to get the news out. The so-called old fashioned scoops are still fashionable even in today's media industry. Being the first gives them a sense of fulfillment and originality.

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Pursuing stories that can have impact

Successful reporters are usually motivated by the desire that their outputs changed the course history. Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein of the famed Watergate Scandal are examples of reporters in this class.

Winning prizes

This is a little controversial because most journalists argue that their stories were not motivated by prize and awards. But a careful look at

the work of journalists suggests this is one of the motivating factors.

Impressing sources

According to Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010), most of the journalists remain highly motivated to impress their sources with the accuracy, fairness and depth of their work.

Finding out what's really happening

According to Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010), "A fundamental motivation of reporters is the curiosity that drives them to get to the bottom of a confusing or complicated situation and to find patterns that help explain it to readers. Making sense out of chaos-especially when you can do it first-is something many reporters find rewarding."

Telling stories in a compelling way

Most reporters who aim to the top are usually moved to tell their stories in a way that their listeners or audiences are compelled to see to the end of the story.

Getting on the front page

Any reporter who spends five months in a media organisation, say newspaper, and does not get on the front page of the paper, may be regarded as not doing well. Front page stories are big stories in the judgment of editors. So, reporters strive to have a sense of fulfillment that their story was considered big and good to make a front page. The feeling is always rewarding and unexplainable.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

In your own words, discuss five factors that drive reporters to success.

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4.0 CONCLUSION

In life, there must be something that drives you to fulfillment. The same is applicable to careers especially in the media industry. Reporters are not amongst the richest in the society and the profession is not very financially rewarding especially in Nigeria. There must be something then that drives reporters in this part of the world to be courageous and take creative risks. These factors are what we attempted to discuss in this unit.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, we considered the various factors motivating reporters and journalists alike to career growth and fulfillment. These factors were from the work of Byron Calame, the Public Editor or Ombudsman of

The New York Times. Seven of such motivating factors were identified and discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. In your own assessment, suggest two other factors that you think motivate reporters that were not discussed in this unit.
2. Defend the argument that winning prizes does not motivate reporters.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

Agbese, D. (2008). *The Reporters' Companion*. Lagos Nigeria: Newswatch Books Limited.

Mencher, M. (2010). *Mencher's News Writing and Reporting*. (11th ed.). Boston: McGraw-Hill Higher Education.

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UNIT 4 GENERAL RULES FOR NEWS WRITING

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 1.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
- 3.1 General Rules for News Writing and Reporting
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The success of any profession depends on the quality of rules and regulations guiding such a profession and concerted efforts to ensure such regulations are not tampered with. In this unit, we shall be considering the general and basic rules that guide news writing and reporting.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify not less than 20 rules that guide news writing and reporting.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 General Rules for News Writing and Reporting

- Do not pass a verdict or make a judgment: It is not your duty as a reporter or writer to pass a verdict or make judgment. Just

gather the facts of the story, present them to your audience and let them decide on whose side they will want to go.

- Do not editorialise: Leave editorialising to the editorial writers.

News reports must be as straightforward and objective as possible.

- Avoid the use of unfamiliar jargon: Do not assume that your audience understands the meanings of the unfamiliar jargons you are using. Always use familiar words.

- Keep yourself and other reporters out of the story: Keep yourself and other colleagues out of the story unless you and them are an essential part of the news.

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- Avoid the use of “told me,” “told this writer” or “told our reporter: The phrase “in an interview will serve your purpose.
- There must be perfect accuracy in writing and reporting: When in doubt, leave it out.
- There must be no willful distortion of facts in either news or headlines: Never tamper with the facts of a story no matter the benefits that may accrue to you as a result. This is an unforgivable offence in journalism. Any reporter who tampers or fabricates the so-called facts of a story is “finished” in the industry. You become leprous, untouchable and unemployable.
- Guard against publication of libelous statement: The good reporter is the one who lives to write another report and see the fame of the previous reports come to him. Avoid writing your way into jail. Libelous statements should be avoided because of its capacity to keep you in jail and close down your media organisation because of insolvency resulting from the inability to pay court fines.
- Always use simple words: News writing and reporting are not the platforms to impress anybody with long sounding and big words. Always use the nearest simple word. A good news report is the one the average reader reads and understands.
- All news copies must be typewritten and double-spaced: The era of hand-written copies is gone. Therefore, a reporter must know how to type his story using the computer. It must also be typed in double space so that sub-editors and editors will be able to edit the copy.
- The first page must carry the reporter’s surname, a slug line and date in the top left hand corner: Slug lines must be short-

preferably one word.

- Start your story halfway down the first page: You must give enough space for your superior editorial staff to work on your copy.
- Leave at least one-inch margin at left, right, top and bottom of each page: Do not overcrowd the pages. Leave appropriate margins as required.
- Each page must be numbered or lettered: The correct letter or numeral is in the form of "B copy next" or "page 2 next." This type of numbering must appear at the bottom right hand corner of each page except the last.

The end of a story must be marked by a centred "30" or "***" or "#."

- Always make your lead interesting: Guard against misleading leads. Leads sell a story. Therefore, to get and keep the attention of your audience, the lead must be interesting.

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- Use the inverted pyramid format when writing your news story: This is the generally accepted format for writing news reports because it presents the most important elements of a story in the first few paragraphs. The format also makes it easy to cut stories from the bottom without losing any substance of the story.
- You must quote accurately: Use quotes only where necessary to brighten up your story. Please, do not overdo this in your copy.
- Use "said" if you want to write in the present tense and "said that" if it is reported speech: This style helps the copy retain currency and life.
- Always read your copy carefully and connect all typographical spelling and grammatical mistakes before turning it in: This is a primary rule even in ordinary or everyday writing. No amount of haste could justify a badly written copy.
- Your copy must be submitted in duplicate and both copies must be properly edited
- Never underline words or phrases or titles of books in your copy
- A seasoned reporter and publisher, do not exaggerate, do not over-dramatise, beware of adjectives, use the active voice and be natural and conversational when you write

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Identify at least 10 rules guiding writing a good copy of news and report.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The media industry is an organised industry and so there must rules and regulations guiding how copies are written and filled for publication.

Some of these rules may differ from country to country but the underlying fact is that they make for good writing. Any report that lacks these rules or some of them will definitely turn out rejected by a reputable editor or media organisation.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the rules that make for a good copy. It is believed that you are now familiar with these rules after going through this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify 10 rules of news writing and argue that they should be retained even beyond this century.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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MODULE 2 THE BASICS

Unit 1 Elements of Good Writing/What Makes for Poor Writing?

Unit 2 Conducting Interviews

Unit 3 News Gathering and Sources

Unit 4 Journalese

UNIT 1 ELEMENTS OF GOOD WRITING/WHAT MAKES FOR POOR WRITING?

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Elements of Good Writing

3.1.1 Precision

3.1.2 Clarity

3.1.3 Pace

3.1.4 Transitions

3.1.5 Sensory Appeal

3.1.6 Analogies

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

A good reporter must first and foremost be a good writer. This is because his writing skills are needed in his news writing and reporting job as a journalist. A poor writer can never make a good news writer or reporter. Good news writing begins first from understanding the elements of good writing and applying them in our writing assignments. This is the focus of this unit. Good writing has six characteristics, which are called elements of good writing.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the rules or elements of good writing and demonstrate a reasonable skill in the use of such element
- identify and discuss the elements that could constitute poor writing.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Elements of Good Writing

3.1.1 Precision

A good writer must always obey the rule of precision. Words should be used and they should mean exactly what you intend them to mean. You should never use for example “uninterested” when you mean “disinterested”, nor should you use “farther” for “further”. For instance, if you report that fire has destroyed a house, you mean it must be rebuilt, not repaired. If you say fire fighters donned oxygen masks to enter a burning building, you are impugning either their intelligence or yours. Oxygen is dangerous around fire; fire fighters use their tanks.

Words are the tools of your trade and the writer can use only certain words in certain situations. In addition, the writer can choose from many words. That freedom can be both exhilarating and dangerous.

3.1.2 Clarity

All news reports and stories must be clearly written. Every reporter should be aware of the following when attempting to write clear stories.

- Use simple sentences and familiar words.
- Use correct grammar and punctuation.
- Structure the story to have a beginning (lead), middle (body) and end (conclusion).
- Make use of the active voice.
- Avoid adjectives and exaggeration.

3.1.3 Pace

Good writing must have a pace appropriate to the content. Sentences and words give a story mood. Short sentences convey action, tension and movement. A series of long sentences conveys a more relaxed mood; long sentences slow down the reader. Between these two extremes are sentences of varying lengths, and good writers use them all. Not all sentences should be long or short. Nor should they all be of medium length. An abrupt change in sentence length draws attention to the sentence. Try it sometimes.

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3.1.4 Transitions

Good writing uses transitional devices that lead the reader from one thought to the next. A transition is a bridge, which assures the reader that the writer has a sense of direction. A transition can be a word, a phrase, a sentence or a paragraph. Common transitions are “and,” “but” and “however.”

3.1.5 Sensory Appeal

Good writing must appeal to the reader’s senses. Good writing appeals to one or more of our five senses: sight, hearing, smell, taste and touch.

3.1.6 Analogies

Good writing uses analogies. Analogies permit writers to show similarities and contrasts. Similes and metaphors are often used to achieve this purpose. Where the simile compares one thing to another, a metaphor says one thing is another. With similes and metaphors, writers draw word pictures.

What Makes For Poor Writing?

If the story shows dull writing: Dull writing never makes good copy. To avoid this always use active voice and make your write up conversational and lively.

If the story is not interesting: Interest is a constant variable in selecting a

story as good. Any uninteresting story will sure pass off as a clear evidence of poor writing.

If the story is too vague, abstract or unclear: Vague and abstract stories will always be rejected on the platform of poor writing. To make your stories interesting, it must be clear and unambiguous.

If there are too many stories already on the subject: Your story could be rejected as poor if you are writing on what every other person has written on. This is even worsened by the fact that you did not bring in any new or fresh facts to your writing. Therefore, avoid writing on what every other person has written on if you do not want your report to be considered poor.

If the story is a piece of propaganda or resembles one: Any attempt to pass off a piece of propaganda for a news report or story will definitely be rejected as poor writing.

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If the story is trivial: Trivial and unimportant stories are likely to be rejected as poor writing or evidence of it. Write on important issues that will interest majority of your audience.

If the story is not in good taste: Any writing that offends public morality or shows evidence of bad taste in the choice of words and phrases will be rejected as poor writing.

If the story runs against the policy of the newspaper or its style guide: Every media organisation has a style guide- a body of rules that guides how a particular media establishment intends to present its reports and stories. Any violation of the style guide will send your paper to the editor's wastebasket.

If the story has too many figures and statistics: People naturally hate stories with too many figures and statistics. If your story is, for instance, about a budget proposal, find a creative way of presenting.

If the story is free publicity stunt: A story that is free publicity stunt usually tries to trick readers with an advertising matter in a form of a news story. Readers and editors normally abandon such stories.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

1. Discuss five elements that must be available before you could consider writing as good.
2. Why will an editor or writer regard a story as poor writing?

4.0 CONCLUSION

Knowing how to write generally is the first practical step to knowing

how to write for media organisations. The elements of good writing therefore serve as fundamental pillars upon which good writing rests.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the elements of good writing. Six of such elements were discussed. Also discussed in this unit are the elements that could make one's writing turn out poor. About 10 of such were also discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Defend the argument that the presence of the elements of good writing will definitely return a copy as good.
2. Discuss the major reasons why a copy may turn out as poor writing.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 CONDUCTING INTERVIEWS

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 4.0 Main Content
- 3.1 Types of Interviews
- 3.2 Preparing and Conducting the Interview
- 3.3 Phrasing the Questions
- 3.4 Establishing Rapport with a Source
- 3.5 How to Ensure Accuracy in an Interview
 - 3.5.1 Techniques to Ensuring Accuracy
 - 3.5.2 Other Techniques to Achieving Accuracy
- 3.6 Quotes and Attributions
 - 3.6.1 What to Quote Directly
 - 3.6.2 Problems in Direct Quotation
 - 3.6.3 Correcting Quotes
 - 3.6.4 Attributing Direct and Indirect Quotes
 - 3.6.5 Guidelines on How to Attribute Information
- 3.7 Handling On and Off-the-Record Information
 - 3.7.1 Guidelines for Citing Sources
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The interview is the art of meeting people and asking them questions with a view to eliciting information on specific issues or happenings. Generally, a reporter conducts interviews when he needs information about events or issues of public significance. The interview is a journalist's tool for digging out facts and its importance in the news gathering process cannot be over-emphasised.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- prepare and carry out a successful interview
- identify the different types of interviews and how to organise them
- establish rapport with an interviewee
- quote and attribute correctly
- handle on- and off-the-record information more professionally.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Types of Interviews

Exclusive Interview

This refers to an interview exclusively conducted by a reporter without any other reporter participating in it.

Panel Interview

In this interview, more than one reporter from a particular media establishment participates in the interview.

Telephone Interview

This is conducted through the telephone especially now that telecommunication industry in Nigeria has improved greatly.

Personality Interview

This is conducted with the view to gathering information concerning a person whose life's activities the reporter wants to write about. Most personality interviews are usually done on an exclusive basis.

On-the-Spot Interviews

This refers to situations when reporters ask other persons impromptu questions, usually people who are important in government, visiting dignitaries, social celebrities, top military officers, academics, big business persons etc. The interview is usually transit in nature and takes place during stop over at the Airport, venue of events, and so on.

Group Interviews

Many reporters from different media organisations participate in this type of interview. It is usually a question-and-answer session during press conferences, press briefings, and so on.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 1

Identify and discuss five types of interviews usually conducted in the Nigerian media industry today.

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3.2 Preparing and Conducting the Interview (Interview Skills)

1. The reporter who wants to conduct an interview must "Be Prepared." The first step is to identify the subject of the interview and the personality to be interviewed. As a reporter, you must establish the need for the interview. You must also have a good idea of the kind of information you seek, so that everything that is

given to you will not seem like what you are looking for. Having identified the subject and the person to be interviewed, you go ahead and book an appointment with the interviewee. You can book appointment through the telephone, you can go to his/her office or visit him/her at home as a last resort. Make sure you book an appointment first.

2. If the interviewee wants to know why you want to interview him/her, you could give him/her a general idea and nothing more.

It is unprofessional to give out your entire questions to the interviewer ahead of time. You will end up with canned answers.

3. You then prepare your questions and arrange them in order of importance. You are not expected to forward the questions to the interview before the interview date.

4. Do a thorough background research on the subject matter and familiarise yourself with the historical background, social and economic activities of the interviewee. His political leanings and hobbies must not be overlooked.

5. On the day of the interview, arrive at the venue of the interview on time at least 15 minutes before the interview. This gives you a cool start.

6. Listen and listen well. Let the interviewee do the talking and encourage him by nodding your head, but do not overdo this. Do not interrupt to offer your opinion, but you can ask necessary follow-up questions when the need arises.

7. You should watch out for the interviewee's emotional tone level (ETL) as the interview progresses. The ETL may fluctuate from time to time due to the intensity of the interview. If the ETL is too high, you should try to bring it low by asking trivial questions. If it is too low, you should try to raise it by asking sensitive and breath-taking questions.

8. If you are conducting the interview with a microphone or tape recorder, always hold it yourself. Never allow your interviewees to hold the microphone otherwise they will take over the control of the interview.

9. When the interview reaches the central theme, the question should be short and delivered at a time. Try to make the interviewee answer the central questions.

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10. Never feel intimidated about the personality you are to interview. Do not forget you are not there in your own capacity, you are

representing majority of the audience who read or watch your media organisation. Therefore, be confident. It gives you a cool and calculated head.

11. The first question is very vital. Settle for a simple, non-committal question. This will help to reduce any tension already in the atmosphere.

12. Do not ask dead-end questions. Dead end questions do not require detailed answers. They may end up with YES or NO kind of responses.

13. Do not be prosecutorial in your approach. Remember the interviewee is not on trial and you are not a lawyer or judge.

14. Do not lecture the interviewee; ask your questions as straightforward as possible.

15. Take note of the tape recorder, midget or any other electronic device you are using as anything they can easily develop fault.

16. At the end of the interview, you should not hesitate to thank the interviewee and assure him that you may call again if the need arises for further clarification about issues raised in the interview.

17. Finally, when writing your story, never forget the off-the-record rule as some information might have been given to you off record. Never abuse privileges and confidences. Such abuses hinder the growth of the industry.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 2

Discuss 10 vital skills a budding reporter needs to have in conducting interviews.

3.3 Phrasing the Questions

The way an accomplished lawyer asks questions determines whether the lawyer will win his case or not. The journalist faces the same challenge. Reporters have missed many stories because they did not know how to ask questions. By the phrasing of the question, many reporters signal the response they expect or prejudices they have. There are basically two ways a reporter could phrase his/her questions to get the desired results. The first is through the open-ended questions and the second is through the close-ended question.

Open-Ended Questions

Open-ended questions allow the respondent some flexibility. In response to an open-ended question, the source often reveals more than he or she realises or intends to. Open-ended questions are less direct and less

threatening. They are more exploratory and more flexible. However, if you want a person's biographical data, do not say "Tell me about yourself".

Close-ended Questions

Close-ended questions are designed to elicit specific responses. Instead of asking a previous employee to appraise a Minister-designates' managerial competence, you may ask, "How well does Chief Ekeanyanwu listen to the people who work for him?" "Does he explain his decisions?" When you ask vague questions, you may likely get vague answers. By asking a specific question, you are more likely to get a specific answer.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 3

Discuss four benefits close-ended questions have over open-ended questions.

3.4 Establishing Rapport with a Source

The right chemistry produces an interview that is fun for both parties. When John Lindsay was the mayor of New York, the AP's Pett opened an interview with the question, "Would you want your daughter to marry a mayor of New York?" Lindsay roared in laughter and Pett had a great interview.

Rapport is the relationship between the reporter and the source and is very crucial to the source of the interview. The relationship is sometimes relaxed, sometimes strained. Often it is somewhere in between. The type of relationship you try to establish with your source is determined by the kind of story you are writing.

There are several approaches to establishing rapport with a source (These approaches also serve as interview approaches). They include:

1. You can start off with small talk and allow the familiarity to graduate to the level you could take advantage of and then bring up the major issues of the interview.
2. Bring up something humorous about the interviewee you have found out during your research and which you think can interest the interviewee in your opening statements. This may be the small talk that will create the needed rapport for you.
3. Ask about something you know the source will want to talk about. If he is a premiership fan and ready to bet his life over Chelsea, take advantage and talk about the Chelsea versus Man U

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penultimate game that may decide who wins the EPL 2011

Season. Once he identifies he has same addictions and hobbies like you, he creates the rapport for you to talk to him.

4. Show sources what you have in common. This will support the Number 3 point made above.

5. Empathise with your sources or subjects. Do not be judgemental. Sometimes, it may help to put yourself in their shoe and feel their pains. This may draw you closer during the interview process.

6. Conduct the interview where the source feels most comfortable. When you create such a relaxed mood for him, he comes out as if he has known you for a long time. The ultimate outcome may a great interview for you.

7. Where you sit in relation to the person you are interviewing could also be important in determining the kind of rapport you develop. Unless you are deliberately trying to make the interviewee feel uncomfortable, do not sit directly in front of him/her. Permit your sources to establish eye contact if and when they wish.

8. Tape recorders ensure accuracy of quotes, but they make many speakers self-conscious or nervous. Try to place it in an inconspicuous spot and ignore it.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 4

Discuss four practical things you need to do to establish a rapport with a source you are about to interview.

3.5 How to Ensure Accuracy in an Interview

Accuracy is a major problem in all interviews. Both the question and the answer may be ambiguous. You may not understand what is said and you may record it incorrectly too. You may not know the context of the remarks and your biases may interfere with the message.

3.5.1 Techniques to Ensuring Accuracy

To ensure accuracy, the following techniques could be adopted.

a. Observing: Some reporters look but do not see. As a reporter, when you look, please, observe.

b. Understanding: Understanding what you see is crucial to the news gathering process, so also is the understanding of what you hear. Never assume you understand. Make sure you do.

Ignorance is never an excuse in law.

c. Asking Follow-up Questions: If you understand what the source is saying, you should show this by asking meaningful follow-up questions.

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3.5.2 Other Techniques to Achieving Accuracy

1. Encourage the speaker to add more details.
2. Another device to making the source talk is not a question at all; it is a pause.
3. Before you leave, ask if there is anything you forgot to ask. Put the burden on the source. You are also doing him a favour by giving him the chance to contribute to direction of the interview.
4. Quickly review your note and check facts, especially dates, numbers, quotes, spellings and titles.
5. As a matter of courtesy, tell the source when the story might appear.
6. Remember that the interview may be over, but your relationship with the source still stays.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 5

Discuss the primary techniques adopted by reporters to achieve accuracy.

3.6 Quotes and Attributions

Introduction: Direct quotes add colour and credibility. By using direct quotes, you are putting your audience directly in touch with the speaker. Like a letter, direct quotes are personal. Not everything people say should be put into direct quotes. You need to learn what to quote directly, when to use partial quotes and when to paraphrase. You must also learn how and how often to attribute a remark because some information may not excuse you from a possible libel suit. Therefore, you must also learn to deal with off-the-record quotes and background information.

3.6.1 What to Quote Directly

Brief, precise and relevant quotes spice up any story. However, you can overdo a good thing. You need direct quotes in your story, no doubt but you also need to develop your skill in recognising what is worth quoting. Make use of the following guidelines:

- Use direct quotes when someone says something unique.
- Use direct quotes when someone says something uniquely.
- Use direct quotes when someone important says something important.

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3.6.2 Problems in Direct Quotation

a. Paraphrasing quotes: Some quotations need verifications while others need clarification. Do not quote someone unless you are sure of what that person means. The best way to avoid confusing and unclear quotes or needlessly long wordy quotes is to paraphrase.

b. Partial quotes: It is also much better to paraphrase or to use full quotes than to use fragmentary or partial quotes. Example:

- The Vice-Chancellor said lecturers should “turn off” unnecessary lights and “lock up” before closing for the day.

This sentence will be better off without quotation marks. Again, partial quotes often contain an ellipsis inside them to tell the reader that some of the words of the quotes are missing. Example:

- “I have come here tonight ... and I have crossed state lines ... to conspire against the government”.

This practice at times may be justifiable, but you should not keep the reader guessing and wondering what is missing.

3.6.3 Correcting Quotes

None of us regularly speaks in perfect, grammatical sentences. The same persons when writing down his remarks presumably would write grammatically and correctly.

Therefore, it is accepted practice on many newspapers to correct grammar and to put a person’s remark into complete sentences. This has, however, brought some controversy. The question is “Would you fix a quote to make the person you are quoting sound grammatical?” Here are some opinions and answers from renowned reporters.

- Columnist James Kilpatrick: Sure. It is elementary courtesy, and every one does it. You don’t change the substance of your subject’s thought, of course. You could make anyone in politics look ridiculous if you quoted him verbatim all the time with all the ands, ifs, buts, and ors.
- Jack Newfield, former Senior Editor for Village Voice: No, I don’t. New York political leader Meade Esposito’s colorfulness comes from his lack of grammar.
- The AP Style Book: According to this style, quotations normally should be corrected to avoid the errors in grammar and word

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usage that often occur unnoticed when someone is speaking but are embarrassing in print.

- Use of Obscenity: On most newspapers, some things people say are never permitted in print, even if they are said uniquely. Newspapers rarely print obscenities, profanities or vulgarities unless they are essential to the story. For instance, obscenities are not used in the Washington Post except with the approval of a top editor. However, if it is a “Hardcore” obscenity referring to the body and sexual or excretory functions, The Washington Post’s Style Book calls for the first letter followed by dashes. E.g. He called the President a “f--king fool”

3.6.4 Attributing Direct and Indirect Quotes

In composition and creative writing classes, you may have been told to avoid repeating the same words. This is not so in news writing and reporting especially for the word “said”. Reporters and editors prefer forms of the verb “to say” in most instances, even if they are repeated throughout a story. There are reasons for doing so:

- ‘Said’ is Unobtrusive – Not easily noticeable and hides in the news columns and calls no attention to itself.
- ‘Said’ is Neutral - It has no connotations.
- ‘Said’ is Objective – It does not depict the reporter’s biases.

3.6.5 Guidelines on How to Attribute Information

1. If a direct quote is more than one sentence long, place the attribution at the end of the first sentence. Example:

- The bus overturned at least three times,” the policeman said. “None of the twenty passengers was hurt. Luckily, the car did not explode to flames.

2. Do not follow a fragment of a quote with a continuing complete sentence of quotation. For example:

- WRONG: - The Vice-Chancellor said the time had come “to turn off some lights. We all must do something to conserve electricity.”
- RIGHT: - “The time has come to turn off some lights,” the Vice Chancellor said. “We must all do something to conserve electricity.”

Always separate partial quotes and complete quotes.

3. The First time you attribute a direct or indirect quote, identify the speaker fully. Example:

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- The Vice-Chancellor of Covenant University, Prof Aize

Immonokhome Obayan, said students will no longer be allowed to wear jean trousers to lectures.

4. Do not attribute direct quotes to more than one person, as in the following:

- “The bullets came out from everywhere,” witnesses said. “The protesters had guns, even the children amongst them.”

You can however eliminate the quotation marks, if indeed any witness made the statement. Never make up a source and never invent a quote for anonymous witnesses. It is dishonest, inaccurate and inexcusable.

5. In stories covering past news events, use the past tense in attributing, and use it throughout the story. However, stories that do not report on news events, such as features, may be effective if the attributions are consistently in present tense. Example:

- “‘I like being the mayor,’ she says”

You are indicating that she still enjoys it.

6. Ordinarily, place the noun or pronoun before the verb in attributions. Example:

- “Everything is under control,” the Inspector General of Police said.

7. If you must identify a person by indicating a long title, it is better to begin the attribution with the verb. Example:

- “I enjoy the new position,” says Prof. Prince Izedonmi, Dean of Post Graduate Studies, Covenant University.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 6

1. How would you handle errors in direct quotation?
2. Discuss the guidelines in attributing information.

3.7 Handling On and Off – the – Record Information

Introduction: Sometimes a speaker or source may not want to be quoted at all – directly or indirectly. Therefore, you must learn to use sound professional judgement in handling them. If you agree to accept their information, you must honour their request to remain off the record. Breaching that confidence destroys trust and credibility.

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3.7.1 Guidelines for Citing Sources

Not naming sources is dangerous for two important reasons:

- Such information will lack credibility and make the reporter and

the newspaper suspect.

- The source may be lying.

The following distinctions are made regarding sources and attributions:

1. Off-the-Record: This means you cannot use the information given to you no matter the situation or pressure of breaking out with a scoop.
2. On Record: This means you can use the information as well as attribute it to the source. This is the ideal situation you must get your sources to give you information. Anything outside this is a risk.
3. Not for Attribution: This means you may use the information but may not attribute it to the source. You must take responsibility for the use of the information.
4. On Background: This means you may use the information but with a general title for a source. Example: "A Presidential Aide", "A Senior Official". The real source's name must be mentioned.
5. On Deep Background: This means you may use the information, but you must say it on your own and take responsibility.

Please note that there is currently no universal agreement on these terms as different practitioners in different circumstances interpret them differently. Therefore, your obligation is to make sure you and your sources understand each other. Set the ground rules ahead of time. Clarify your terms and make sure you know the policy of your paper on such matters.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 7

Discuss the guidelines for citing sources.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The interview remains one of practical ways a reporter uses to gather news and information in the course of his/her assignment. It is necessary therefore for every reporter to learn the skills of interviewing and apply them where and when necessary.

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5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt:

- the meaning of interviewing
- the art of interviewing
- different types of interviews
- the techniques and skills required to carry out an interview and

the various ways to quote and attribute information that comes from interviews.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Is interviewing and art or a science? Please, justify your answer with valid argument.
2. Discuss five primary types of interviews a news reporter could carry out in the course of his/her assignment.
3. Discuss 10 effective approaches to carrying out a successful interview.

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UNIT 3 NEWS GATHERING AND SOURCES

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3.0 Main Content

3.1 News Gathering and Sources

- 3.1.1 Predictable Sources
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- 3.1.3 Anticipated Sources
- 3.2 How to Find Story Idea
- 3.3 Checking the Facts of a Story
- 3.4 How to Handle Sources
- 3.5 Developing Your Sources
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
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1.0 INTRODUCTION

To define news is one thing to get it is another. To gather news the reporter must know where and when to look for it, what and whom to see, why and how to verify the facts he assembled and when and how to use the information he has gotten to write a story. News gathering is the major occupation of both cub and experienced reporters. This is the major reason greater attention will be paid to it in this unit.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- explain the meaning of news gathering and its vital role in the daily reportorial duty of a journalist
- differentiate the types of sources available to the reporter and how to deal with them
- discuss how to find the story idea, especially during periods of news “scarcity”
- discuss how to cross-check the facts of your story
- discuss how to develop and grow your sources.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 News Gathering and Sources

Every story begins as a stream does “from a source”. You cannot find a great story today that does not have a source. This reminds me what one of my great Professors told me “every PhD has a story!” Such stories also have a beginning. This is the major reason most persons who are unfamiliar with the news gathering process often wonder how reporters gather and assemble their information, how do they get access to information and information sources, and how do they sustain the daily

publication of news in their media organisations. This shall be our concern in this section. There are three broad categories of sources of news stories thus:

1. Predictable Sources
2. Unpredictable Sources
3. Anticipated Sources

3.1.1 Predictable Sources

These are sources that regularly service the news industry either because of their function that make their activities of public interest or by their nature that help generate events that attract a large number of people. Predictable sources include diary of news, published reports in form of newspapers, magazines, journals, and handouts, broadcast on Radio/TV and prepared speeches. It also includes active or dramatic newsbreaks, which include news from the police, hospitals, fire service, hotels, schools, religious organisations, labour and political associations. With predictable sources, you are sure to get something from there all the time.

3.1.2 Unpredictable Sources

This means a nose for news that borders on the ability, training, exposure and experience of the reporter to determine what news is and report it accordingly. Unpredictable sources are the likely sources where breaking news or tips that could lead to scoop could come from.

3.1.3 Anticipated Sources

This is similar to predictable sources except for the fact that anticipated sources are restricted to planned events that a reporter knows will definitely happen. Such events include a national day celebration, budget speech and special anniversaries, workers' day, and so on.

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No matter the sources of getting news, a good reporter should have the ability to listen, see and possess attributes of a good interviewer. These are needed in dealing with those sources.

In summary, a reporter gets news by:

- Going to the scene of the news event and observe events unfold;
- Talking to people who witnessed the event as it happens or what you will consider as using eye witness accounts;
- Consulting secondary sources like records, reports, documents, files, and so on to cross check and corroborate facts and figures.

Sources could also be human in nature, physical or online. Human

sources are those personal contacts you have build over time. They are also authorities and people involved in news events. The physical sources are consists of records, documents, reference works, and so on. The online sources include a vast array of human and physical sources, from academics to government data (Mencher, 2010).

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 1

Discuss the various ways a reporter could gather news of an event he or she did not witness.

3.2 How to Find the Story Idea

How to find the story idea has always pricked the mind of reporters especially during lull period. However, the imaginative reporter will discover in this section that the story idea could be obtained from a lot of places. For instance, readers sometimes bring story ideas to the newspaper office. Most of these story ideas are the result of an active imagination, a lively curiosity and assistance from friends. Journalists soon learn to recognise how stories written for other publications can be written for their own. They get in the habit of carrying a little notebook to jot down ideas when something somebody says strikes a responsive chord. Sometimes even for good journalists, the wellspring of ideas sometimes dries up. Therefore, take note of these 10 sources of story ideas. They are good for anytime and anyplace. They were compiled from the earlier version of Mencher (2003).

Other People

As a journalist, you meet many people from time to time. What are they discussing when they are not discussing business? What have they heard lately? Journalists have to listen even if it means eavesdropping while having a cup of tea. What do you think interest people? There is no

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better source of story ideas than the people you meet while you are off-duty or on duty. They are, after all, your readers. Therefore, take note of others and always try to find out what is on their mind. Whenever you look, try to see beyond your nose.

Other Publications

News stories are sometimes recycled across the country by different media organisations in different ways. Read other newspapers, magazines, books, pamphlets and the house journals and newsletters of businesses and organisations. Please note that all stories cannot fit in every community. You have to know your own readership. A story

about urban renewal will definitely attract more attention in urban area than in rural area. When you are reading other publications for ideas, remember that you should not duplicate a story in your own newspaper report verbatim; only look for idea from which to develop your story.

News releases

Releases from public relations persons are valuable sources of story ideas. Try to follow up on some of these regular releases that come to your media organisation. You may never know where they will take you to or predict the end.

Social services directory

Many cities and localities have a composite listing of all agencies providing social services. These listings could throw up different kinds of ideas about the society, which a reporter could follow through. You should therefore take note that each of those agencies and their clients could lead to a potential story.

Government reports

Aso Rock is the Nigerian seat of Government. On a daily basis, information and statistics flow from such a place. However, behind every piece of statistics is a person. Every person is a potential story. The census report for instance contains not only the number of people in a community, but also their income and education, how many cars they own, whether they rent or own a house, and so on. Such census reports tell much more. Therefore, find out what and why, and you have for yourself a treasure chest of stories.

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Stories in your newspaper

Many a stream has yielded gold nuggets after the first wave of miners have left. Newspapers sometimes play hit-and-run journalism. Always ask yourself, whenever you read a report in a newspaper, if the human interest angle has been reported adequately. When your newspaper is concentrating on the election winners, maybe you can get an interesting story by talking to the losers and their supporters. In addition, when the unemployment statistics are reported in your newspaper, remember that behind each of those numbers is a name of a person without a job and probably a family to support.

Advertisements and Yellow Pages

Advertisements especially classifieds, could be valuable sources of story ideas. Look through the Yellow Pages too. You may stumble on a good

story idea.

Wire copy

Whenever you go through the stories from the wire services, do not forget to ask yourself if there are any stories that can be localised amongst them. When a wire service story for instance describes the increase in the rate of inflation, you should ask yourself how the people in your community would be affected. Always look for a local angle or slant.

Local Newspapers

Do not ever brush off local news tips. Your readers may be more interested in them than the so-called national news stories.

You

In the final analysis, you are the one who must be alert enough to look and listen to what is going on around you. Always raise posers for yourself and attempt to answer them. Remember, reporters who are attuned to people rather than institutions will find the world around them a rich and fertile source of human interest. Do not tune out. Look and see!

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 2

As a resourceful reporter, discuss where you will look for story ideas in times of lull.

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3.3 Checking the Facts of a Story

A lot of places and information are available for the reporter who is very thorough in his job and desires to verify every fact that goes into his story before publication. Some of these avenues are found in the reference manuals maintained in most newsrooms or in newspaper libraries. Below is a list of some of the avenues and places available for the reporter to check, crosscheck or even triple-check his facts before going to press.

- **Local and Area Telephone Directories:** This could be used to verify the spelling of names and addresses, and so on. They are usually reliable, but they are not infallible.
- **City/Town Directories:** These provide the same information as the telephone directory but also provide information on the occupations of citizens and the owners or managers of businesses.
- **State Manuals/Brochures:** These sources provide information

on various government agencies.

- Maps of the City: County, State, Nation and World Local maps are usually posted in the newsrooms. Others may be found in atlases.
- Bartlett's Familiar Quotations: This will help you not to quote anyone out of context or state a quotation as anonymous when it actually has an author.
- National Assembly Records, Gazettes and Hansards: These are where Government establishments and parastatals store its official information for retrieval and reference.
- Facts on File (Facts on File Inc): This is a weekly compilation of news from metropolitan newspapers.
- Guinness Book of World Records: Anybody who has done any notable thing and probably what no one has done before is usually listed in Guinness Book of World Records.
- Current Biography: You no longer need to worry that you can find the date of birth of a notable personality or his middle name or even place of birth. Check current biographies.
- Trade and Professional Journals and Newsletters: This will obviously contain useful information on businesses and related matter.
- Reader's Guide and Reader's Digest: Any reporter who is not reading Reader's Guide or Reader's Digest is obviously missing out on an important information loaded book that could be useful to the modern reporter.
- Webster's New World Dictionary of the American Language: This is a good reference material for journalists.

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- Who's Who (St Martin's, New York): This source of facts shows who is who as published by St. Martin's.
- Who's Who in America (Marquis): This source also shows who is who in America.
- World Almanac and Book of Facts: A book where you may probably find any meaningful thing you are looking for.

These useful publications and others not mentioned here, enable reporters to verify data and so avoid unnecessary embarrassment caused by avoidable and recognisable errors.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 3

Identify and discuss 10 useful places to verify facts as a reporter.

3.4 How to Handle Sources

Journalists and the profession rely heavily on dependable sources to succeed with the reportorial assignment. One of the trade secrets of any reporter/journalist is the contact with people who confide what is happening in their places of work and interest, whether in politics, business or society. As such, sources are as necessary as notebooks. Here are some suggestions on how to manipulate and/or manage sources.

Use Sources as Starting Points for Some Stories

Use sources as starting points for your story but not the end point. Always double and triple check with other public and private sources before going to press or on air. Do your research and you will find the supporting facts that corroborate your story or questions the credibility and thus reliability of the facts you are about taking to the public sphere.

Maintain a Skeptical Attitude

Do not be reluctant to discard sources' tips if they cannot be substantiated. It is a healthy skeptical attitude that gets you out of trouble in the long run.

Be Careful with Confidential or Anonymous Sources

You must be careful with sources who give you information in confidence. The Off-the-record rule must be obeyed. In practice, you will sometimes have certain things only if you agree to go off the record and listen without quoting. If what the source said is true, you can verify it later from other sources or facts. Once you have promised to keep a

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source's comments confidential, do not break your promise. Be careful not to blunder into suggesting who your source is by some inadvertent reference that can be traced to your source. This could lead to dry up of sources for the industry.

Be Aware of Many Editors Attitude and Behaviour

The granting of secrecy to a source is an open invitation to exaggerate, embroider, embellish or slant. Some reporters have found ways to avoid using unnamed sources. One method is to read back the quote you want to use to diminish the source's anxieties and fears. A second technique is to take the time to discover documents that prove the source's allegation. If you can corroborate any information given to you of the record, you could go ahead and use such information without attributing it to your confidential sources.

3.5 Developing Your Sources

As you meet more people and learn from your community, you should continually update your records of contacts. They come in handy sometimes. Try to develop a bookkeeping method for keeping tracks of your contact. Developing sources differ from one journalist to another. Here are some tips on how to develop a source.

Keep a File Box of 3×5 Cards: Use one card for each source. Be sure to list the telephone numbers of both office and home or keep the same information in a small notebook you can carry with you or use both the file and the notebook. Sometimes it pays to leave your address and phone numbers with your source so that he can always call you up when something that is newsworthy turns up, since you as a journalist cannot be everywhere at the same time.

Always Review Your Card or Notebook from Time to Time: People are always moving. They are either changing jobs or location. You need to update your notebook from time to time or you will find out you just have a record of useless data.

Sometime you call your contacts just to say hello. Do not call them only when you want to use them.

If you can afford it, sometimes take your contacts to lunch, dinner, and so on. Know their kids and spouse's names, birthdays and anniversaries.

Build a healthy relation based on trust and confidence with sources. If they grow to trust you, they will not have problems talking to you when something important turns up.

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You can also reverse the process. Whenever any useful information comes to you, make it a habit to pass on such to your sources. When they get tips too, they will pass them on to you. It is a mutual thing.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Journalists have a common saying that a reporter can never be better than his or her sources. Reporters therefore spend quality time looking for and cultivating contacts that could become useful to them in the course of their assignment as reporters. Cultivating and developing sources becomes necessary for every reporter who wants to remain in the business.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit discussed the place of sources in the news gathering process. How to look for sources, cultivate them and grow them were the major

highlights of this unit. It is expected that you now know much about sources and the news gathering process as an upcoming reporter.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss the news gathering procedure and mention five places to verify your facts before turning them out to your editor.
2. Will all your sources be reliable? How would you handle sources to ensure they do not get you into trouble?

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 4 JOURNALESE

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 Newsroom Terminologies
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The media profession, like every other notable profession, has its language. This is sometimes referred to as jargons or technical terms associated with the profession. For the media industry, the technical language is called Journalese. Journalese is the language of the art of journalism. This will be the preoccupation of this unit. However, attention will only be paid to those terminologies associated with the newsroom where reporters and writers usually domicile.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- list and explain the technical words, phrases and terms commonly used in the newsroom by reporters, writers and their editors.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Newsroom Terminologies

Most of the definitions provided in this section were compiled from the Press Association, Reporters' Companion, Mencher (2010), online searches and media related dictionaries.

- **Add:** Additional news matter to a story already written or is about to be written.
- **Assignment:** This is an order to a reporter to cover an event. Assignment is the day's job given to a reporter to cover by his or her news editor or direct boss.
- **Attribution:** This means the identification of the person being quoted in the reporter's story. You only attribute a story to a source if he or she gives such information on record.

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- **Actuality:** This is an on-the-scene report in broadcasting.
- **Airtime:** The time at which a programme is broadcast.
- **Audio:** Sound
- **Background:** Information that may be used by a writer entirely on his own responsibility and cannot be attributed even to a "reliable source". The reporter can only use information given on background on his or her own risk.
- **Banner:** These are headlines written across or near the top of most newspaper page. It is also called a Streamer or Streaming headline.

- **Beat:** This is the area assigned to a reporter for regular coverage. A beat could be a place or a subject. For instance, State House Correspondent has the State House as his/her beat while Energy Correspondent has issues related to energy as his or her beat. In the US, beat could also be regarded as an exclusive story.
- **Break:** This is when a news development becomes known and available.
- **Beeper:** A telephone conversation or interview recorded for later playback on air.
- **Body type:** The type in which most of the newspaper is set, usually 8- or 9-point type.
- **Bulletin:** News of the day as presented in each of the media organisations.
- **By line:** This refers to the name of the author of a story or the name of the reporter who wrote a particular story.
- **Bulldog:** This is an early edition, usually the first of a newspaper's edition for the day.
- **Caps:** This refers to capital letters or uppercase letters.
- **Caption:** This is synonymous with cutline. It is the explanatory lines above or below a newspaper photograph, illustration or diagram.
- **Column:** This refers to the vertical division of the news page which is usually divided into about five or more columns. It could also be regarded as a signed article of opinion or strong personal expression by an expert.
- **Copy:** This refers to the news story or report.
- **Copy Flow:** This refers to the flow of a news story from the reporter to the news desk and to the editor who makes the final decision as to use the story or not.
- **CAR:** This is an acronym for Computer Assisted Reporting- the use of online databases and other related resources for the of a news story. Some refer to it as Database Journalism while others call it Precision Journalism.

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- **Crony Journalism:** This kind of reporting and coverage ignores or treats lightly negative news of about friends and acquaintances.
- **Continuity:** This refers to all radio and television scripts besides commercials
- **Cue (Noun):** This is a signal to an announcer, a newscaster or

production personnel to participate in a broadcast.

- Cub: This term is used to describe a beginning reporter.
- Cutaway: This refers to the transition shot from them to another. It is used to avoid jamb cut.
- Deadline: This refers to the time in which a reporter, editor or desk must have completed scheduled work for the day.
- Dateline: This refers to the name of the city or town and date, which are placed at the beginning of stories not of local origin.
- Credit line: This is line designates, if necessary, the source of a story or cut "By NAN–News Agency of Nigeria".
- Dry: This refers to a period lacking in news. It is also called a lull period.
- Dolly: This refers to a camera platform.
- Dub: This refers to the transfer of one videotape to another.
- Exclusive: This refers to a story that is printed solely by one newspaper or an individual. This could also be called a "scoop".
- Edition: This refers to one version of a newspaper per day.
- Editorial material: This means all materials in the newspaper that is advertising related.
- Enterprise copy: This is a story often covered by a reporter. It is like a news story but digs deeper than the usual news story.
- Establishing shot: This is a wide shot used to give the viewer a sense of the scene of action.
- Fade: This refers to either physical or mechanical lowering of a voice or music to smooth a transition between sounds.
- File: To send a story to office usually by wire or telephone or to put news services on the wire.
- Filler: This refers to minor news materials used to fill up spaces in the newspaper. It is also called column closers and shorts.
- Flag: This is the printed title of a newspaper on page 1. It is also called logotype or nameplate.
- Folo: This is a story that follows up a particular theme in a news story format.
- FM: This refers to Frequency Modulation.
- Freelance: This refers to an unattached writer, reporter, photojournalist or columnist who writes for a media organisation for a fee.
- Graf: This is an abbreviation for paragraph.

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- Handout: This is the term for written publicity or special interest

news sent to a newspaper firm.

- HFR: This abbreviation stands for “Hold for Release” material that cannot be used until it is released by the source or at a designated time. It is also used to tag a story as “embargoed”.
- Jump: This means continuation of a story from page one to another page.
- Kill: This refers to elimination of a news story or refusal to use it because it is not news worthy. This also means to spike a story.
- Log: This refers to schedule of broadcasting.
- LTK: This abbreviation stands for “lead to come” usually placed after the slug. This means the lead will be supplied later.
- Make up: This is also called layout or design. This is the arrangement of body type, headlines, and illustrations into pages.
- Masthead: This refers to the heading on the editorial page that gives information about the newspaper. This is sometimes confused with Flag or Nameplate.
- Must: This is the designation placed on a copy to indicate that it must be run or published.
- More: This is the designation used at the end of a page of copy to indicate there are one or more additional pages.
- Morgue: This refers to the newspaper library, where published stories photographs and resource materials are stored for reference purposes.
- Mix: Combining two or more sound elements into one.
- Montage: This refers to series of brief shots of various subjects to give a single impression or communicate one idea.
- News hole: This refers to a space in a newspaper allotted to news, illustrations and other nonadvertising material.
- O/C: This stands for “On camera.” It used to describe a reporter delivering copy directly to the camera without covering pictures.
- Outtakes: These scenes are discarded for the final story.
- Op-ed page: Abbreviation for the page opposite the editorial page.
- Precede: A story written prior to an event. It could also be referred to as the section of a story preceding the lead.
- Put to bed: Closing the forms of an edition.
- Rewrite: To write a story a second time to make it better or to condense it.
- Sacred cow: Slang for a subject or story in which the publishers or editors are interested and which must be printed.
- Scoop: See exclusive.

- Slug: The word or words placed on a copy to designate the story. This is usually placed in the top left hand corner of the page.

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- Stringer: A correspondent, not a regular staff member of the media organization, who is usually paid per story. Could also be regarded as a freelancer.
- Stet: Let it stand, restore.
- SOF: "Sound on Film recorded" simultaneously with the picture.
- SOT: "Sound on Tape" recorded simultaneously with picture on tape.
- Split page: Front page of an inside section. Also known as the break page, second front page.
- Text: Verbatim report of a speech or public statement.
- Tip: Information passed to a reporter, often in confidence.
- Trim: To reduce a news story carefully.
- Update: This is a story that brings the reader up-to-date on a situation already in the news.
- V/O: Reporter's voice over pictures. Also called "voice over."
- VTR: Videotape recording.
- Wire services: This is a synonym for press agencies or news agencies. Media organisations usually subscribe to these agencies for news stories, and so on.

4.0 CONCLUSION

It is important for every reporter to familiarise his or herself with the above newsroom terminologies in order to remain connected to fellow reporters in and out of the newsroom. Proper understanding by all makes communications very easy.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit dealt with terminologies commonly used in the newsrooms across the globe. It is expected that you can now identify 80 of these and explain them.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify 20 core newsroom terminologies and explain their meaning.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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MODULE 3 NEWS WRITING AND REPORTING FOR THE PRINT MEDIA

Unit 1 The Lead

Unit 2 The Story Structure/Components of the Story

Unit 3 Types of News Stories

Unit 4 The Qualities of Good News Story

Unit 5 Reporter's Checklist

UNIT 1 THE LEAD

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Function/Importance of the Lead

3.2 Hints on How to Write the Lead

3.3 Types of Leads

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The lead is the first paragraph of a news story and contains the 5Ws and H. In fact, the lead is the most important part of a news story because it contains the most important facts of such a news story. The lead also summarizes the facts of a news story and it must be attractive, interesting and readable. The lead could extend to the second paragraph of the story but under normal circumstances, it should not go into the third paragraph. This is not to say that one has not come across a story of three-paragraph lead in our dailies. What we are trying to emphasise here is that a reporter should not indulge in writing three-paragraph

leads.

According to Mencher (2010), "The lead sentence usually contains one idea and follows the subject-verb-object sentence structure for clarity." This means the lead should begin with the subject, followed by an active verb and conclude with the object of the verb. This structure also makes the reporter to write simple and short sentences.

Some writers and editors also prefer to place word limit on leads.

Mencher (2010) says a lead should not exceed 35 words. Since most

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stories are written in the inverted pyramid form, the news reporter must master the lead. This will be our focus in this unit.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- define a lead
- identify the elements of a lead
- identify and explain the functions/features of a lead
- identify common lead types as well as give examples of each
- write a good lead.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Function/Importance of the Lead

1. The lead summarizes the news

It gives the reader the sense of the story to follow and takes him or her to the supporting facts or claims presented in the opening statements.

2. The lead answers the questions raised by the 5Ws and H

However, not all the answers provided by the 5Ws and H must be present in every lead to make it acceptable but no important one should be left out or omitted.

3. The lead must emphasize the news feature

The lead is expected to play up the most interesting or significant aspect of the story. The news feature must be played up in the lead.

4. The lead must furnish the reader with identification needed for clarity

Persons, places and events must be given identification to make the lead clear to the reader. These bits of information may be considered as parts of the answers to the WHO, WHERE and WHAT of an event.

5. The lead must also suggest or give the authority on which the news is written

This is called DOCUMENTATION. Documentation gives credence to the news story.

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6. The lead must attract readers to the story

As the window of the story, the lead must get the attention of the reader and sustain this till he or she gets into the story.

7. The Lead Should Suggest the Headline

From the lead, it becomes easy for the sub-editor or editor to cast the headline for the story. The lead should help suggest this.

3.2 Hints on How to Write the Lead

1. Use the SVO (subject-verb-object) sentence structure.
2. Make use of simple and short sentences.
3. Discover the most important element of the story and play this up in your lead.
4. Decide on what lead feature to emphasize among the five Ws and H and make this part of the first sentence.
5. Use a single element if you find out that one element stands out clearly in the story.
6. Make your lead go straight to the point.
7. Always ensure that your main verb is in the active voice.

3.3 Types of Leads

There are several types of leads; however, Sonaike (1987) identifies nine thus.

1. Summary lead which comprises of a statement that answers the 5Ws and H of a news event
2. The effect's lead which focuses on the effect or consequences of an event
3. The contrast lead which portrays contrasts of news events
4. The direct address lead which directs its statement at the reader
5. The question lead which asks a questions and provides an answer as well
6. The cartridge lead which presents the gist of an even in the fewest words
7. The double feature lead which contains two separate ideas
8. The quote lead which starts with a quotation and
9. The shirt-tail lead which is a lead broken into two sentences expressing two related ideas.

We shall further explain some of these lead types that are relevant with

examples.

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1. Summary Lead

The summary lead is often used with the inverted pyramid form because it seeks to summarize the story in a few lines and tells the reader what he needs to know by answering the 5Ws and H. The summary lead summarizes the whole story and gives details later. It is very brief and deals only with the key points of the story.

Example:

- The ultra-modern Ariaria International Market in Aba, Abia State, reputed to be the biggest in Africa, was razed by fire on Tuesday.

2. Figurative or Coloured Lead

This lead permits the extensive use of figures of speech or allows the use of words in the figurative sense rather than the literal sense. The power of a figurative lead is in its eye-catching effect.

Example:

- After a countdown of several weeks, the Governor has put a fire button and blasted the MD of the state-owned sugar company into the rank of redundancy.

3. Quotation Lead

A quotation lead usually consists of a striking statement that could make readers interested in the story. Because the quotation lead is easy to write, the general rule is to use it sparingly. It should be used only where the quote is quite significant, and in cases where it could add drama to the story. Whenever a quotation is used, the explanation of such quotation should be made in the next paragraph.

- “The implementation of the present law on abortion would continue to impede the control of abortion in the country”

This was contained in a call to the federal government by the Nigerian Medical Association (NMA) to legalize abortion.

4. Question Lead

The question lead raises a question and attempts to answer the question. A question lead is commonly used in explanatory or specialised writing. The question at times answers itself when it is rhetoric.

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Example:

- What is constructive comment and what is disloyalty to the state?

This is the question in many minds today following the dismissal of a state commissioner as a result of an alleged anti-government speech.

The function of the second paragraph as statement following the questions is to explain the question to the listeners, readers or viewers.

5. Bullet Lead

Bullet lead is nearest to the headline. It is a short sentence that carries great impact. Example:

- Multibillionaire and business tycoon, Chief John Agoli was killed today in a car bomb blast outside his home.

6. Staccato Lead

This consists of short sentences, coming one after the other to create heightened effect. It is used to establish a mood best suited for the kind of news story.

Example:

- The disaster started with a building flash. Next, a shattering roar that led to a crumbling wall. Then breaking glass, and death.

7. Immediate-Identification Lead

In the immediate-identification lead, one of the most important facts of the story is the “WHO” element. Reporters often use this approach when someone important or someone whose name is widely recognised is making news. Example:

- Pop Singer Roy Kelly was hospitalized in good conditions with second-degree burns on his scalp last night after his hair caught fire when he was filming a commercial.

8. Delayed-Identification Lead

When a reporter uses this type of lead, usually it is because the person or persons involved have little name recognition among the readers.

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Example:

- Madison – A 39-year old carpenter was killed today in a two-car collision two blocks from his home.
- Dead is William Domonske of 205 W.Oak St. Injured in the accident and taken to Mercy Hospital were Mary Craig, 21, of 204 Maple Ave. and Rebecca Roets, 12, of 207 Maple Ave.

9. Multiple-Element Leads

In some stories, choosing one theme for the lead is too restrictive. In such cases the reporter can choose a multiple – element lead to work more information into the first paragraph. However, such a lead must be written within the confines of a clear, simple sentence(s). Example:

- PORTLAND – The city council Tuesday ordered three department heads fired, established an administrative review board and said it would begin to monitor the work habits of administrators.

10. Lead With Flair

Although the inverted pyramid is designed to tell readers the news first and fast, not all stories begin with the most important statement. When the news value you want to emphasise is novelty, often the lead is unusual.

Example:

- ROME, ITALY (AP) – The wedding guests included a drug suspect, the social coordinator was a narcotics agent, the justice of the peace was a police chief and 52 officers were party crashers.

For the unsuspecting bride and groom the ceremony Friday was truly unforgettable – a sting operation set up by state and local police that led to 30 arrests.

Please note you may come across other types of leads, depending on the author whose work you are reading. However, the summary lead is the most commonly used in this part of the world because of its tendency to summarize the 5Ws and H in the lead.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Why is a good lead important to a story?

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4.0 CONCLUSION

Good leads are essential to the overall value of a story. It is also important to the understanding of the major theme espoused in a story. Thus, writing a lead correctly becomes a primary skill every reporter must get. It is also important to conclude here that different authors may choose to give any suitable title or name to lead types. This is not the issue. A multiple element lead may be described as a summary lead in another context. This does not make the authors wrong or right. What is important to the editor is writing a good lead.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you were exposed to lead writing in the print media. The features, functions and types of leads were also discussed. It is expected that you can now write a good lead after studying this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Identify five leads of five lead stories in the Guardian newspaper and state the types of lead they are.
2. Identify and discuss two types of leads that will be suitable to the general interest newspaper.

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UNIT 2 THE STORY STRUCTURE/COMPONENTS OF THE STORY

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives

- 2.0 Main Content
- 3.1 The Inverted Pyramid Format
- 3.2 The Advantages/Importance of the IPF
- 3.3 The 5Ws and H
- 3.4 Components of the Story
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Story structure distinguishes news writing from other types of writing such as the essay, poetry, drama, novel, short story and so on. Whereas the author of these other forms of composition usually begin with minor incidental details and work to a climax near the end of their compositions, the news writer reverses this plan of organisation. He begins with the climax. In the first paragraph generally referred to as the lead or introduction, the news writer begins with the most important information or climax of the story. The second most important information comes second; the third most important information comes third and so on. This form of news writing is called the Inverted Pyramid Format.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- describe the news story format
- discuss the inverted pyramid format of writing
- identify and explain the 5Ws and H
- differentiate between news writing and other forms of writing
- identify and explain the components of the story.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Inverted Pyramid Format

The inverted pyramid format is a news story writing format used centuries ago; however, most modern newspapers still use the format because it is the most space-efficient story form known. It permits writers to deliver the most important information in a paragraph or two. This type of news writing format gives the most important information in the news first in form of a lead and goes on to develop the story in a descending order of importance. The inverted pyramid story has no

conclusion, as many single incident news stories are presented in this form. The illustration below shows the format.

Lead – the most important information

Second most important information

Third most vital information

Supporting details

Inverted Pyramid Format

The purpose of this type of structure is to present the news quickly, clearly and readably, to help the reader easily understand the content of the story. Its basic logic grows out of the different ways in which readers approach a news story. Some will be so interested in the subject that they will read every word the reporter writes, regardless of how it is written; others read only a few paragraphs; many will only read the headline and lead.

To provide all these readers with maximum benefit, the reporter arranges the fact in descending order of importance. The Inverted Pyramid form has a professional advantage over the conventional

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method of essay writing. When a news story is very long and needs cutting, the sub-editor can easily cut from the paragraphs, which contain the least important details.

3.2 The Advantages/Importance of the Inverted Pyramid Format

- a. It makes the reader get the gist quickly.
- b. It helps in headline writing.
- c. It facilitates reading.
- d. It satisfies the curiosity of the reader.
- e. It helps and facilitates page make up.
- f. It facilitates editing to suit the news hole.

3.3 The 5Ws and H

The first person associated with the 5Ws and H is Rudyard Kipling. “I keep six honest serving men, they taught me all I know and their names are What, Why, Where, When, Who, and How”. The question these “men” raise is What happened, Why it happened, Where it happened, When it happened, Who was involved and How it happened. It may be that not all of these questions can or should be answered in connection with a story but it will be unfortunate and unprofessional for a reporter not to make attempt to find answers to

these questions.

1. What happened?

From the analysis of news stories published in five notable newspapers in Nigeria, the “what” of the stories is the most common starting point. In answering the question “what happened”, the answer forms the opening of the story.

Example:

- a. A total sum of N2.8 billion was pumped into the foreign exchange market in March this year alone by the Central Bank of Nigeria.
- b. A further explanation of the “what” follows:
- c. This represents an increase of 15% over the level of N2.4 billion recorded last year.

2. Who was involved?

The news of “who” as the opening element shows the prominence of the personality involved in the news story and it is from this angle that

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Harold Evan in his book, “News Writing”, defines news as “people.” When the “who” is not prominent, that is, when it has no attraction in itself and leads to no special destination in the society, it will rarely open the news story. In some cases, special “who” may justify emphasis even though identification does not become part of the lead.

Examples:

- a. President Olusegun Obasanjo has promised to improve the conditions of service of federal civil servants in the country in order to stem corrupt practices.

United States President George W. Bush has announced a donation of \$50m in support of the AIDS epidemic in Africa.

3. Where did it happen?

The location of a news story is important and of interest when the media considers their area of coverage or place of reporting.

Example:

- a. An Evangelist of the Christ Church of the Lord, Mr Aboidun Baruwa, was killed by a lion at the zoological garden of the University of Ibadan last Saturday.

4. When did it happen?

Time element is important in a news story, and in most cases, it is

included in the lead. However, it often sounds odd to begin a news story with time. That is why “At noon last Saturday” cannot begin a story.

Example:

a. President Goodluck Jonathan leaves Abuja Monday morning for Madrid, to begin a three-day state visit to Spain.

5. Why did it happen?

The “why” of a news story is the circumstances surrounding the event behind the story. In most cases, the “why” is always answered in the body of the news story, unless when the circumstances surrounding the “why” deserves more explanation.

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Example:

a. INEC cannot remove Ngige based on his expulsion from the PDP. This clarification was made yesterday by the INEC Chairman, Abel Guobadia, to refuse claims credited to him.

6. How did it happen?

The “how” of a story is closely related to the “why.” That is why the “how” and the “why” of the story is usually left for the second or third paragraph that form the body of the story. However, the “how” of a news story is mostly used to explain the process the event takes to become a news story.

Example:

a. Taiwanese police have rescued a wealthy businessman kidnapped and held for two weeks in the boot of a car while his captors demanded a ransom of 50 million Taiwan dollars.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Justify why you may like to begin your news stories with any of the 5Ws and H.

3.4 Components of the Story

(This section is completely based on the work of the renowned News Writing and Reporting author, Melvin Mencher, 2010).

The components of a story are what the story must contain to be accepted. Mencher (2010) identifies seven of such components thus:

a. Accuracy

All information provided in a story must be accurate and the facts must also be verifiable.

b. Attribution

The sources which provided the reporter with information he or she used in writing his/her story must be properly identified.

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c. Complete

A news story should contain the specifics that illustrate, prove and document the main point of the story.

d. Balanced and Fair

A news story should make sure all sides in a controversial issue are presented.

e. Objective

The writer or reporter should never inject his or her own personal biases and prejudices into his or her story.

f. Brief and Focused

The good news story should get to the point as quickly as possible and should keep to the point.

g. Well-written

A good news story should be clear, direct, interesting and error-free.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Good journalism starts by having good reporters who thrive upholding the ABC of journalism - Accuracy, Brevity and Clarity. Sometimes, these values are seen as moral necessities for the practice of the profession and should be upheld by anyone who wishes to make a name in the industry. The eight components of a story discussed in this section are just expansions of the ABC of journalism.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you learnt the story structure where the inverted pyramid format, 5Ws and H were presented to you. You also studied the components of a story where seven of the most vital ones were also presented.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Differentiate between a news story structure and style with that of a normal essay in English Language.
2. Discuss why the components of a story are vital to a journalist's credibility.

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UNIT 3 TYPES OF NEWS STORIES

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 The Straightforward News Story

3.1.1 Hard News

3.1.2 Soft News

3.1.3 Human Interest News

3.1.4 Expected News

3.1.5 Unexpected News

3.2 Investigative Stories

3.3 Interpretation Stories

3.4 In-Depth Stories

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The challenge of news classification should not be seen as a simple one.

This is because the characteristics of one type of story may be found to be some of the characteristics of another type. For instance, the difference between an in-depth story and an investigative story is purely a matter of degree of thoroughness. In broad terms, there are four major types of news stories:

a. Straightforward news stories which include hard news, soft news

and human interest news

- b. Investigative stories
- c. Interpretative stories
- d. In-depth News stories

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify and explain the different types of news stories
- list different types of news stories.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Straightforward News Story

This is the product of the usual routine reporting. Most of the stories published in our commercial newspapers are straightforward news stories. Such stories are never interpreted, editorialised or laden with reporter's biases and prejudices. They are stories objectively and anchored on facts. The reporter adds or subtracts nothing from the facts on which the story is based.

A straightforward news story may be short or long, but it can hardly be long enough to occupy three-quarters of a page or a whole page. As a rule, its lead must answer to the 5Ws and H and the story, as a whole must leave no questions unanswered. The story must be simple, accurate concise and understandable. As stated earlier, straightforward news story may be subdivided into hard news, soft news and human-interest news.

3.1.1 Hard News

Hard news stories are stories that deal with government, economic, social and political policies. They are stories with a lot of facts and figures. Stories concerning the annual budget, political and economic programmes are all hard news stories.

3.1.2 Soft News

These are stories about trends, fashion, entertainment personalities and lifestyles. The time element is not too emphasised in writing such news stories.

3.1.3 Human Interest News

These are stories valued more for their emotional impact or oddity. They usually arouse human feelings and conjure up sentiments and emotions in the persons who read them.

3.1.4 Expected News

Expected News is anticipated and therefore planned for. It usually flows from events that are scheduled in advance.

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3.1.5 Unexpected News

Unexpected news is not anticipated. It takes people unawares. Examples include murders, natural disasters, accidents, and so on.

3.2 Investigative Stories

These types of news hinges on the pursuit of information that has been concealed. Investigative stories therefore require the digging out of facts. The investigative reporter is not expected to inject his own biased ideas or opinions into his story. He is not expected to editorialise or interpret the facts. Examples of investigate stories that made headlines are - "The Watergate Scandal," "The Buharigate Scandal," and "Enwerengate," and so on.

3.3 Interpretative Stories

This is a form of story in which the reporter is free to interpret the news the way he or she sees it. S/he is allowed to inject his own biased but expert opinion, editorialize and pass comments on the fact being reported. Interpretative stories require additional facts, detailed explanations and logical analysis. Examples include personality profiles and feature articles.

3.4 In-Depth Stories

This is complete quality news reporting. In-depth story needs the full treatment and it needs backgrounding. It requires creative thinking and deep imagination on the part of the reporter and writer. Most newsmagazine stories are usually in-depth stories and there is little difference between an in-depth story and an investigative story.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss four types of news stories.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The challenge of classifying news is not a small one. However, reporters and writers alike should make efforts to understand the style demands of the different types and adhere strictly to such demands. It is unforgivable for a reporter to pass comments or twist facts in a straightforward news story.

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5.0 SUMMARY

This unit has exposed you to the different types of news stories and the demands of writing them. It is expected that you can now identify the different story types and attempt writing each one of them.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss the major differences between a straightforward news story and an in-depth story.
2. Discuss the major differences between hard news and soft news.

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UNIT 4 THE QUALITIES OF GOOD NEWS STORY

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 The Qualities of Good News Story
 - 3.1.1 Accuracy
 - 3.1.2 Objectivity

3.1.3 Balance/Fairness

3.1.4 Currency

3.1.5 Clarity

3.1.6 Brevity

3.1.7 Attribution

3.1.8 Complete

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Editors generally feel that some new stories are good while some are not. This is because news stories must meet some certain criteria for them to be adjudged good. These criteria are referred to as the qualities of a good news story.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify and explain the qualities of a good news story.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Qualities of Good News Story

3.1.1 Accuracy

Accuracy is the pillar on which a news story rests. A news story can be regarded as accurate if all names, ages, addresses and direct quotations in the story are accurate and correct. Inaccuracy in news writing could lead to costly libel suits and a possible dismissal from your work. So, efforts must be made to ensure that the facts you used in writing any story are accurate to the best of your knowledge.

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3.1.2 Objectivity

This presupposes that the reporter presents the reader with all sides of an issue and all the facts involved in the issue. This nature of presentation allows the reader to decide what these facts mean and whose side he or she has sympathy for. For a news story to be objective, it must not be slanted or editorialised. There is no room here for the reporter to inject his or her opinion; no matter how specialised such opinion may be regarded.

The objective criterion has generated a lot of arguments because people believe it is difficult to be objective when writing a news story. They

assert that the word objective is relative and so mean different things to different people. Subjectivity could be displayed either in choice of words or in the choice of facts.

3.1.3 Balance/Fairness

This entails treating all sides of a story equally without showing any form or evidence of bias and partiality. This could also be described as giving equal attention and prominence to the two sides of a story. In broadcasting, it is called the “Fairness Doctrine.” The views expressed by opponents on an issue must be given adequate coverage without any form of preferential treatment to any of the opposing views. Balancing up a news story is tasking indeed. Unless a reporter remains objective, he or she will miss out this crucial requirement.

3.1.4 Currency

Yesterday’s news is no longer news. It is stale and no longer meant for consumption. A momentary delay in getting a story across to consumers as soon as it breaks could make it stale. The reporter should therefore be current in his or her search for news. A news story must be something new that has just happened.

3.1.5 Clarity

News stories must be written in clear, simple and easily comprehensible language. To achieve this, a reporter is advised to use simple and unambiguous words; simple sentences that mean exactly what the writer intends them to mean, and good grammar and punctuation that will bring the actual meaning closest to comprehension.

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3.1.6 Brevity

For a news story to attract the attention of both the editor and the readers, it must be very brief, clear and simple. Most readers are in such a hurry to read an entire story in a newspaper. Therefore, it is advisable to tell the news in such a concise manner as to maintain the interest of the reader. This criterion gave rise to the adoption of the inverted pyramid form and the summary lead.

3.1.7 Attribution

This is all about identifying the sources that provided information in the course of writing the story. Attribution help place a quote in proper context and also validate the claims of the reporter. It improves the overall credibility of the story.

3.1.8 Complete

According to Mencher (2010), complete stories are written by reporters who anticipate and answer the questions their readers, viewers and listeners will ask. The complete story contains the specifics that illustrate, prove and document the main point of the story.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss five primary qualities you think a good news story should have.

4.0 CONCLUSION

In the newspaper business, there will continue to be rejection and acceptance of copies. This is majorly because not every copy submitted will find itself in the day's edition of the newspaper. To be accepted, a story must have all the qualities discussed in this unit.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit dealt with the qualities of a news story. It is our expectation that you are now familiar with the reasons why some stories are rejected why others are not. The stories that lack some or most of the qualities discussed in this unit are most likely going to be rejected.

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6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Give three solid reasons why "attribution" is very vital to a story's completeness.
2. Is "objectivity" a realistic quality for a news story? Support your position with relevant facts.

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UNIT 5 REPORTER'S CHECKLIST

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objective

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Checklist before a Reporter Writes a Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Information is the key to good reporting. The reporter is expected to collect enough information and put it together to make meaning to the readers. Because facts are the ingredients used in writing a good story, a reporter must always have a checklist of this before the actual writing process begins.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify should be in a checklist before a reporter writes a story.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Checklist before a Reporter Writes a Story

The checklist before a reporter writes a story is based on the practical work and writing of Agbese (2008) as discussed below.

a. Do I have all the information I need to write a complete story?

A reporter must make sure all the required information are in before the writing process begins proper. A good reporter usually asks himself or herself the questions his or her readers will ask and find answers to the questions.

b. Have I covered all the angles, interviewed everyone concerned and verified all the information given to me by the various sources?

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An attempt to answer this question in the affirmative will definitely lead to a well-written and complete story. Any reporter who is in the habit of asking himself/herself this question and then making concerted efforts to find answers to it will end up an award-winning reporter.

c. Have I answered all the questions posed by the 5Ws and H?

The 5Ws and H raise questions whose answers summarize all that a reader needs to know about an event. Every reporter should make attempt to find answers to the questions they ask.

d. Am I clear in my mind what sort of story I want to write?

If the reporter has any doubts in his/her mind about the sort of story he/she intends to write, then something is wrong.

e. Do I fully understand the story I am about to write?

This follows from point 4 above. The reporter must fully understand the sort or type of story he/she is about to write by appreciating the nature of facts available and the possible consequences of the story's release.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss the checklist a reporter must take note of before writing his report.

4.0 CONCLUSION

This checklist is not exhaustive. There could be many more even some developed by reporters themselves to assist them in delivering quality. However, if the answers are provided to the questions asked in the checklist, then the reporter is ready to write the story.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this chapter, you learnt some of the items that must be available to you as a reporter before you write a story that could get you positive attention.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Discuss the question posed by the 5Ws and H and state why they are important to a story's completeness.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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MODULE 4 NEWS WRITING AND REPORTING FOR THE BROADCAST MEDIA

Unit 1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

Unit 2 Style

Unit 3 Features/Structure of a Broadcast News Story

Unit 4 Writing a Broadcast Copy

UNIT 1 CRITERIA FOR SELECTING BROADCAST STORIES

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

3.1.1 Timeliness

3.1.2 Information and Explanation

3.1.3 Audio or Visual Impact

3.1.4 The facts

3.2 The Don'ts of a Broadcast Copy

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Broadcast news stories are written differently when compared to print news stories that we have been dealing with in our earlier units.

Broadcast stories are written to be easily understood. According to Mencher (2010:195), "to write effectively for radio you must unlearn the prose writer's rules about sentence structure. Disregard such forms as dependent clauses and balanced sentences. You can even forget the first grammatical rule you ever learned – that a sentence must have a subject and a verb. Some of radio's most effective sentences are not complete sentences at all. They are descriptive phrases. They save a lot of words and go over very smoothly on the air".

These make broadcast copies a little more technical than the usual prose copies. This unit shall therefore focus on the criteria for selecting broadcast copy and the things a broadcaster cannot do when preparing a broadcast copy.

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2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- explain the criteria for selecting broadcast stories
- explain the don'ts of a broadcast copy
- distinguish between writing for the print and the broadcast media.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

There are many reasons why a broadcast news story may be rejected in the newsroom. Apart from the universally accepted standards, different broadcast stations have other unique parameters that their reporters must follow in writing for the station. However, the following could be regarded as some of the criteria that are generally applied in selecting broadcast news stories.

3.1.1 Timeliness

Timeliness as a news value is more important to the broadcast news writer than to the print reporter and writer. Print journalists tend to work on daily cycles but broadcast journalist work on hourly or less cycles. Generally, a news broadcaster has to “go to press” many times a day, particularly if he is working on radio. The news must be up to the minute. News that is more than an hour old may be too stale for broadcast selection (Aworo, 2005 in Folarin et al). So, timeliness is a core criterion in selecting broadcast copies.

3.1.2 Information, not Explanation

Broadcast news writers always look for selection stories that do not need a lot of explanations in order for listeners or viewers to understand them easily. They prefer stories that are relatively simple and can be told in a simple and straightforward manner. The suggested maximum length for most TV newscast is about 2 minutes; the normal length should be about 20 to 30 seconds (Aworo, 2005 in Folarin et al). What is important to the broadcaster is giving information not explaining in details what happened. In essence, the broadcast news story concentrates on the WHAT and WHERE and delves less into the WHY and HOW of events because of the airtime allocated to the story (Obe, 2005). Every

broadcast news writer must have this understanding if he or she intends to write acceptable copies.

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3.1.3 Audio or Visual Impact

Broadcast news editors will always select stories that the audience can hear or see. As a broadcast news writer, always write for the ear or eye if you want your copy selected all the time. This is because news events that have good visual appeals to the audience are usually hot cake. Some broadcast news events are selected because they have both visual and audio effects that the public want.

3.1.4 The Facts

In the course of an assignment, many facts will be thrown up at the reporter. It is his or her duty to organise these facts into some sort of order. Do not forget that broadcast reports do not require do much detail; it becomes important that the reporter must organise the facts in such a way that the important details are not lost. The best practical way to go about this is to fully understand the facts you want to base your story on before you begin the writing process. Afterwards, you could write from your memory and only use the facts to crosscheck. This technique when expertly used results in concise, clear copy.

Other Criteria

A broadcast story that must be accepted according to Mencher (2010) should use everyday language, written in short sentences, limit every sentence to one idea, use the present tense whenever appropriate and usually the story should confine itself to one overriding theme.

3.2 The Don'ts of a Broadcast Copy

- a. Do not scare listeners
- b. Do not give orders
- c. Do not start a story with:
 - "As expected"
 - "In a surprise move"
 - " A new development today"
 - "Our top story tonight is"
 - "There is" or "It is"
 - A participial phrase
 - A personal pronoun
 - A question
 - A quotation

- An unknown or unfamiliar name
- Someone's "making news" or "making history"

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- "Another", "more" or "once again".
- d. Do not characterise news as good or bad
- e. Do not use any form of "to be" as the main verb in your lead
- f. Do not bury the verb in a noun
- g. Do not use "yesterday" or "continues" in your first sentence
- h. Do not use "no", "not" and negatives in your first sentence
- i. Do not use newspaper style, language or rituals
- j. Do not cram too much information into a story
- k. Do not lose or mislead a listener
- l. Do not make a factual error

Adapted from Mencher, Melvin (2010). Mencher's News Writing and Reporting (11th ed.). Boston: McGraw-Hill Higher Education.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Explain 10 don'ts of a broadcast news copy.

4.0 CONCLUSION

From our discussion so far, it is obvious that broadcast news serves a purpose different from the print output. It is basically intended to provide the audience with information without necessarily bugging them down with so many details. How to go about doing this correctly is the focus of the unit which concentrated on the criteria for selecting a broadcast story.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the criteria for selecting a broadcast copy and the things a broadcast news reporter is not expected to do in the course of preparing and writing a broadcast news story.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Justify with four valid reasons why a broadcast copy is more interested in giving out information and not details.
2. How will you use facts in writing a typical broadcast story?

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 STYLE

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 Style
 - 3.1.1 Personal Style
 - 3.1.2 Era or Period Style
 - 3.1.3 Media Style and Mechanics
 - 3.2 Broadcast Style
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Every media organisation of worth has a style guide, which helps the journalists in that organisation know how to present their copy in an acceptable manner. This is because writing, whether for print or broadcast, runs on style. Style distinguishes, say a print copy from a broadcast copy. The major difference between a broadcast copy and advertising copy is style. The way Public Relations' copies are written is different from the way advert copy is written. Again, the difference manifests as style. Style is everything that makes a copy from a particular type of medium different from the others. Therefore, reporters are expected to conform to the style guide in writing and presenting their copy.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- describe what style is all about
- identify the unique broadcast style of writing stories
- apply broadcast style in writing and presenting your own broadcast stories.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Style

Ekwelie (1992:56) notes that every aspiring writer must contend with three basic styles thus:

- a. His own emerging style which will make his writing distinct.
- b. The style of his times with regard to sentence construction, diction as well as syntax.
- c. The style of his or her medium, which is a hybrid between normal and the idiosyncratic use of language.

These are further explained below.

3.1.1 Personal Style

Personal style is usually identified with individual writers. It is a style most established authors are known for. Chinua Achebe, for instance, has his style of writing as reflected in his novels. The same is applicable to the Nobel Laureate, Professor Wole Soyinka, who is known to write for a particular audience. This comes in their choice of words, phrases etc and the way and manner such words, phrases etc are presented in their works. Wole Soyinka's "The Lion and the Jewel" is written in a

different linguistic style from “The Man Died”. Journalists should strive to apply personal style in whatever they do. It makes you unique. Personal style does not have to flagrantly abuse the house or media style of a particular media organisation. House style takes precedence but a journalist may decide to apply such a House style in a very unique and personal way.

3.1.2 Era or Period Style

This is the prevailing style of a particular period in history. The style of the Shakespearean Age and the Modern American Literature are totally different. Language changes with history and time. For instance, during the colonial days in Africa, the rhetoric of politicians and the so-called statesmen were largely nationalistic. Today, the language has changed. Such rousing patriotic speeches then may not impress anyone again especially in the midst of abundance and paradoxical lack caused largely by a very corrupt and inhuman political class who are basically amassing wealth at the instance of the hungry masses.

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3.1.3 Media Style and Mechanics

As we noted in the introductory part of the unit, every media organisation has its style, usually called House Style or Style Guide. A House Style is a journalistic code book, detailing how everything that pertains to writing should be handled. The House Style differs from media house to media house; from the print media to the broadcast media etc. However, notwithstanding the differences manifested in styles in the different media organisations, the standards and mechanics of writing remain universal. Each House Style stems from standard language usage but sometimes bows to stylistic idiosyncrasies. Bad mechanical style is a bane to good writing. Ume-Nwagbo cited in Aworo (2005) noted for example that the English Treason Act of 1351 came under strict scrutiny during the trial of the Irish nationalist Roger David Casement in 1916, over the way the wording, originally in Norman French, was or was not punctuated. That case was one instance in which the absence of comma would have saved the neck of accused for high treason.

It is no longer news that poor punctuation gets in the way of good writing. Written language is a very demanding assignment and must be treated as such. This is corroborated by Francis Bacon, the father of English essays, when he noted that “words are like leaves. Where they most abound we cannot find the fruit of the truth beneath”. This is a

serious warning against verbiage or simply verbosity. A writer therefore must follow the medium's style guide on punctuation, spelling, capitalization, diction, syntax, and taste.

3.1.4 Broadcast Style

Broadcast news writers make use of the conversational style or what we refer to as "language style." According to Mencher (2010), broadcast news serves a purpose different from that of the print. Its primary intent is to provide the public with basic information quickly and clearly. The broadcast writer is much more interested in getting the story idea across without the details. This is the major reason the broadcast style is unique and rigid. The broadcast journalist examines every word and idea before use. This is because too many words may squeeze another item in the story and too many ideas and the listener or viewer may become confused.

A typical broadcast style of writing will contain the following guidelines:

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1. Use short sentences and words the announcer can pronounce without gasping for breath.
2. Do not attempt to tell too much in your opening statement. The radio listener requires a little time to adjust after each story.
3. Never lead into a story with a question. There is a little line between such leads and commercials.
4. Avoid hanging and dangling phrases since they break up the flow of thought.
5. Attribution should precede assertion where and when a story must be attributed. Also, attribution should come at the beginning of a sentence where necessary.
6. Be conversational. This means you should write the way you talk.
7. Do not start a story with a participial phrase.
8. Use ordinary, one-syllable words whenever possible.
9. Use vigorous verbs. This means you should as much as possible avoid adjectives and adverbs.
10. The active voice is always preferable than the passive voice. Use it.
11. Use familiar words in familiar combinations.
12. Write simply and in a direct manner. Always avoid the use of unnecessary words.
13. Write in language that could be read easily.

14. Use a phrase to indicate someone is being quoted.
15. Place titles before names and they should be used for proper identification of people and nothing more.
16. Where appropriate and accurate, use the present tense or the present perfect tense.
17. Numbers must be written to be read aloud. The best way is to write out numbers from one to 10 and then to use figures for numbers up through 999.
18. Round off figures especially the ones dealing with budgets, money matters, and so on.
19. Avoid the use of tongue-twisting words.
20. Avoid abbreviations unless they are standard abbreviations that could easily be understood by all.
21. Avoid the use of symbols or sketches.
22. Do not hyphenate words.
23. Avoid unnecessary use of quotations and reduce the use of punctuation marks too.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss 15 things you must not do when writing a broadcast copy.

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4.0 CONCLUSION

The broadcast writer must be simple and direct. He or she must always bear in mind that he/she is writing for the ear and the eye. Make sentences simple, short and easy to understand. Do not attempt to cram too many information and facts in your story and remember your listeners and viewers are basically in a hurry. Do not keep them waiting and guessing.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt the meaning of style and the implication in broadcast news writing. You have also learnt the broadcast style and how to apply the knowledge in writing and acceptable broadcast copy.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Define style in broadcasting.
2. Why is it necessary to have style guides in broadcast media houses?

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 3 FEATURES/STRUCTURE OF A BROADCAST

NEWS STORY

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Structure of a Broadcast News Story

3.1.1 News Highlights

3.1.2 Lead

3.1.3 Correspondents' Reports and Inserts

3.1.4 Lead-in and Lead-out

3.1.5 Wrap Around

3.2 Features of a Broadcast News Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Broadcast news writing is unique and designed to suit the mechanics of the profession. The writing also requires a higher order of skill than those required for writing for newspapers and newsmagazines.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the basic structure of broadcast news stories
- identify the features of a broadcast news story
- list and discuss the characteristics of broadcast news writing which differentiate it from other forms of writing.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Structure of a Broadcast News Story

News broadcasts have identifiable features and sections with special significance. It is usual for news broadcasts to begin with a time check, station identification, greeting and the name of the newscaster (s). However, different broadcast stations have individual styles, which do not differ significantly from what is presented below.

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3.1.1 News Highlights

This comes up at the beginning of the programmes and gives listeners an idea or run-down of the major stories contained in the day's programme in a descending order of importance. News highlights are also referred to as top stories of the day. They should be brief, punchy, interesting, attracting and written in the present tense. They also serve to arrest listener attention and get the listener to sit down for the real gist.

Examples as adapted from Kombol (2005) include the following.

- a. National Economic Council meets over current power sector reforms.
- b. A bill to enforce the use of seat belts by motorists is being considered by the Senate.
- c. Sokoto House of Assembly grants Governor Degoye Kpongo a

leave of absence of 120 days.

d. Federal Government designates Bar Beach Towers Lagos as military barracks

3.1.2 Lead

The broadcast lead opens news stories. In writing the broadcast lead, immediacy is the key. Listeners and viewers must be made to understand that the news is current and the events are happening now. Because of this, broadcast leads are always written in the present tense. The broadcast lead should not attempt to answer the 5Ws and H like its print counterpart. Only the most important of all of these should be featured in the broadcast lead.

Example:

- a. The First Lady of Lagos State, Mrs. Kemi Fashola, says maternal mortality is on the rise in the state.
- b. Two types of broadcast lead are commonly used in most broadcast stations. The first is the shot-gun lead, which identifies a single development in the story and the second is the umbrella lead, which is also called summary lead because of its tendency to highlights a series of developments in the story.

3.1.3 Correspondents' Reports and Inserts

Correspondents' reports add credibility to the broadcast news report as the various media audiences are made to see that the media organization in question was actually at the scene of the event and had reporters on ground to monitor the situation and report direct from the scene.

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Through correspondents' reports and inserts, listeners and viewers are brought to the scene of the event. This also helps to add detail to the report.

Example:

- a. The National Assembly says all governments parastatals will be offered for sale. The spokesperson for the Assembly Kalu Ngor stated this at
- b. Correspondent Jimoh Ibrahim completes the story.

3.1.4 Lead-in and Lead-out

The lead-in is used to prepare the minds of listeners for correspondents' reports and inserts. It is regarded as a transition device that transports the listeners from the story into the correspondents' reports that has more detail.

On the other hand, the lead-out takes the listeners from the scene of the event back to the studio where the story is expected to be wrapped up. Lawrence (1983) cited in Kombol (2005) notes that while the lead-in prepares the audience for the video or audio report, the lead-out re-identifies the voice in the actuality or video segment.

Examples:

- a., State House Correspondent Yemi Adenuga now completes the report. (Lead-in).
- b., from Lagos, Amaka Igwe now reports (Lead-in).
- c. that was Yemi Adenuga from the State House (Lead-out).
- d.Amaka Igwe from Lagos (Lead-out).

3.1.5 Wrap Around

Wrap around is simply a sign out by correspondents to indicate that they are through with their correspondents' reports. Upcoming reporters should note that it is proper for the correspondent to say his or her name and the name of the station before signing off on the reports.

Example:

- a. From Lagos, Amaka Igwe reporting for Channels Television.
- b. Amaka Igwe, Channels Television.

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3.2 Features of a Broadcast News Story

Features or characteristics of a broadcast news story have a lot to do with the style of broadcast media organisations. Since style has been dealt with in the preceding unit, we will for the sake of emphasis reiterate some of the basic features of a broadcast news story thus:

1. Broadcast copy is written in the way people speak. So, it is conversational.

Example:

- a. The lead defence counsel in an advanced fee fraud trial, Mr. Olisa Agbakoba, is threatening to file a motion for mistrial unless some documents are furnished by the prosecution.
- 2. Sentences in broadcast news stories are usually short. Brevity in sentence construction is the key word here. Apart from being short, the sentences should also be simple in nature. Complex sentence structures confuse listeners.

Example:

- a. Complex sentence:

Following the decision of the International Court of Justice at The Hague, the Netherlands, over the sovereignty of Bakassi Peninsula, the Cross River State Government has been barred from exercising any control or power over the communities in its estuary.

b. Shorter sentences (Acceptable for broadcast news story):

The Cross River State Government has been barred from exercising any control over the communities in the Bakassi region.

This follows the decision of the International Court of Justice at The Hague, the Netherlands, over the sovereignty of Bakassi Peninsula.

3. Independent clauses should be avoided in broadcast news writing because they often delay the main theme of the story.

Example:

a. POOR: Having identified the problems inherent in corruption, the Chancellor of Covenant University has condemned corruption in its totality.

b. BETTER: The Chancellor of Covenant University has condemned corruption due to its inherent problems.

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4. The sentence structure for broadcast news stories remains the Subject-Verb-Object type of writing sentences even for print media organizations.

5. Broadcast news stories are written in the active voice. The active voice is rigorous and lively, while the passive voice is dull.

Example:

a. Active voice: The lawyer took his wife home

b. Passive voice: His wife was taken home by the lawyer

6. Use the present tense which gives a sense of immediacy and currency.

Example:

a. WEAK: The Vice-Chancellor said Monday she will remove her deputy over the allegation.

b. STRONG: The Vice-Chancellor says she will remove the deputy over the allegation.

7. Always use words that convey currency like "Today", "This morning", "Earlier today", "Monday morning", and so on.

8. Use contractions where appropriate. It is part of everyday speech because people tend to cut words short to say more in less time.

Contractions obviously make broadcast news writing more

conversational. However, where they will mislead the listener or be totally misunderstood, they must be avoided. The broadcast news writer should also know that negative contractions are avoided in broadcast news writing (Kombol, 2005).

Example:

- a. POOR: The Vice-Chancellor says she won't apologize for the many rules in Covenant University.
- b. GOOD: The Vice-Chancellor says she will not apologize for the many rules in Covenant University.

9. Homonyms are certain words that sound alike and it very easy to mistake one for another. Broadcast writers should guard against such mistakes. Proper use and in the right context is advised.

10. Punctuation, quotations, use of numbers, abbreviations and acronyms are usually subject to House Styles and Guides. This has been dealt with in the unit on Style. Please, go back to that unit if in doubt.

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11. Finally, it is expected that a typical broadcast copy should have the following basic rules.

- a. All copy should be typed.
- b. All copies should be doubled-spaced.
- c. One story should be limited to a page.
- d. Words that are difficult to pronounce or require some special emphasis should be underlined.
- e. A single word should not be split between pages.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Justify the application of the first three rules discussed under the features of broadcast news story.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Broadcast news writing is guided by many rules as could be seen from this unit and the other preceding units. To have a full grasp of these rules and apply them without stress, it is advisable that upcoming broadcast news writers should constantly practice these rules. By so doing, they will become familiar with their use and application.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt about the structure and standard features of broadcast news writing. It is expected that you are now familiar with such structural features and is able to apply them in your writing.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify and discuss the structure of a broadcast news story.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

Agbese, D. (2008). *The Reporters' Companion*. Lagos Nigeria: Newswatch Books Limited.

Bonder, F. F; Davenport, J. R., & Drager, M. W. (2005). *Reporting for the Mass Media* (8th ed.). New York: Oxford University Press.

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UNIT 4 WRITING A BROADCAST COPY

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objective

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Steps to Writing News for the Broadcast Media

3.1.1 Start with a Broadcast Lead

3.1.2 Introduce Lead-ins and Lead-outs

3.1.3 Remember to Wrap Up

3.1.4 Remember to Relate Words to Pictures

3.1.5 Avoid Clichés

3.2 Writing a Broadcast News Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Writing a broadcast news story or copy to be read by a newscaster is different from writing it for a newspaper. Broadcast copies are written in a way that it would be easy for newscasters to read. The primary goal of the broadcast news story is to make the copy easy for the newscaster to read as well as easy for the audience to understand.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- write a typical radio and television news story or copy.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Steps to Writing News for the Broadcast Media

3.1.1 Start with a Broadcast Lead

The broadcast lead opens news stories. In writing the broadcast lead, immediacy is the key. Listeners and viewers must be made to understand that the news is current and the events are happening now. Because of this, broadcast leads are always written in the present tense. The broadcast lead should not attempt to answer the 5Ws and H like its print counterpart. Only the most important of all of these should be featured in the broadcast lead.

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Example:

- The First Lady of Lagos State, Mrs. Kemi Fashola, says maternal mortality is on the rise in the state.
- Two types of broadcast lead are commonly used in most broadcast stations. The first is the shot-gun lead which identifies a single development in the story and the second is the umbrella lead which is also called summary lead because of its tendency to highlight a series of developments in the story.

3.1.2 Introduce Lead-ins and Lead-outs

The lead-in is used to prepare the minds of listeners for correspondents' reports and inserts. It is regarded as a transition device that transports the listeners from the story into the correspondents' reports that has more detail.

On the other hand, the lead-out takes the listeners from the scene of the event back to the studio where the story is expected to be wrapped up. Lawrence (1983) cited in Kombol (2005) notes that while the lead-in prepares the audience for the video or audio report, the lead-out re-identifies the voice in the actuality or video segment.

Examples:

- a., State House Correspondent Yemi Adenuga now completes the report (Lead-in)
- b., from Lagos, Amaka Igwe now reports (Lead-in)
- c. that was Yemi Adenuga from the State House (Lead-out)
- d.Amaka Igwe from Lagos (Lead-out).

3.1.3 Remember to Wrap Up

Wrap-up is simply a sign out by correspondents to indicate that they are through with their correspondents' reports. Upcoming reporters should note that it is proper for the correspondent to say his or her name and the name of the station before signing off on the reports.

Example:

- a. From Lagos, Amaka Igwe reporting for Channels Television.
- b. Amaka Igwe, Channels Television.

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3.1.4 Remember to Relate Words to Pictures

This aspect is applicable to visuals only. While relaying a videotaped report, it is important that the words must tally with the pictures. This requires good editing to ensure words and pictures are complementary.

3.1.5 Avoid Clichés (This section is adapted from Oloruntola Sunday's "News Reporting and Writing")

Eric Partridge, in his Dictionary of Clichés, defines a cliché as a phrase so hackneyed as to be knock-kneed and spavined. They not only fail to enliven dull copy, clichés make even the most significant item sound trite. Hyperboles and clichés are for hacks.

Examples of clichés that should not appear in broadcast news stories are given below.

- Absolute farce, got the message, painted a grim picture, all-out-effort, heated debate, picking up the pieces, anybody's guess, high-ranking official, pool of blood, at this point in time, how does it feel?, probe, beat a hasty retreat, in due course, put into perspective, bid (for attempt), iron out the problem, quiz (for questioning), bolt from the blue, jobless youngsters, rushed to the

scene, a brutal reminder, last but not the least, selling like hot cakes, calm before the storm, last minute decision, shot himself in the foot, calm but tense, leaps and bound, show of force, chequered career, leave no stone unturned, sitting on the fence, clampdown, loud and clear, square peg in a round hole, daylight robbery, major new developments, desperate attempt/bid, up in arms, stuck to his/her guns, marked contrast, dramatic decisions, vanished into thin air, dug in their heels, new move, mindless vandals, nipped in the bud, virtual standstill, effortless victory, over and above, weighty matter, fell on deaf ears, a whole new ball game, get under way, saw the writing on the wall, given the green light.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Identify 10 common clichés that should be avoided in a broadcast news copy and attempt to replace such with an acceptable word or phrase or statement.

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3.2 Writing a Broadcast News Story [This section is partly adapted from Obe (2005:36-38), "Reporting Diverse Areas: A Concise Text"]

Broadcast news writers must have a clear understanding that they require enough space and paper to write and that they do not have the economy of space associated with newspapers and newsmagazines. They must therefore be vast and knowledgeable in broadcast news writing to overcome any challenge encountered. Since broadcast news reports are written for easy delivery, the font size should be big, about 32 points, while the double line or sometimes triple line spacing should be applied.

When writing a broadcast news story, the writer should begin every new story from a different page. For television copies, they should be positioned on the right half of the page while the left side is used for instructions on video or audio. These instructions are meant for only the newscasters and are usually written in capital letters while the actual story is written in small letters. Television copy is written on the right half of the page in a 40-character line. Each line will contain average of six words, and the newscaster will use about 25 lines per minute. When the story continues on the next page, -MORE- is used to indicate this. This is usually written in parentheses at the bottom of the page. It is also advised that you end a typical broadcast news story with a complete

sentence. Should the story continue on the next page, it should begin with a new paragraph.

Samples of broadcast news stories adapted from already cited authors are reproduced here to guide you in practice and writing:

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Sample Radio Copy [Adapted from Oloruntola Sunday (n.d.)]

West Broadway

12- 30

1 - 11 - 88

Flanagan

Members of Citizens for the Preservation of West Broadway plan to gear up their petition drive again this weekend. The group began circulating petitions last weekend.

The petitions request the city council to repeal all previous ordinances and resolutions on the widening of the West Broadway. Many residents of the West Broadway area complain that the proposed widening project will damage its residential nature.

Petition drive coordinator Vera Hanson says the group is pleased with the show of support from residents all over Springfield.... But it wouldn't know exactly how many signatures it has until next week.

- Key for Sample Radio Copy

"West Broadway" is the slug for the story

"12 - 30" is the time of the newscast

"1 - 11 - 88" is the date of the broadcast

"Flanagan" is the name of the reporter

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Sample TV Copy [Adapted from Oloruntola Sunday (n.d.)]

Six 6 - 17 art

Jorgenson

MOC JORGENSON A lesson in art and architecture paid off for some Buchanan High School Students today. Ribbons were the prizes for entries in a sketch exhibit of scenery and buildings in the capital city area.

SOF: 27

NAT SND UNDER

VOICE OVER

KEY: BUCHANAN The Springfield art club

sponsored the show and called in Springfield College art Professor Bill Ruess to judge the artwork.

HIGH SCHOOL

:00-05 Ruess says he was impressed by the students' skills, especially those who tried their hands at the different media for the first time.

- Key For Sample TV Copy

"Six" is the time of the newscast

"6-17" is the day of the broadcast

"art" is the slug for the story

"Jorgenson" is the name of the reporter

"MOC" means the person is live on camera with audio from this microphone

"SOF: 27" means there is sound on the film lasting 27 seconds

"NAT SND UNDER" means the film sound should be kept at a low level

"VOICEOVER" means the voice is from the anchor person in the studio speaking over the film that is being shown.

"KEY: BUCHANAN HIGH SCHOOL" indicates the title that should be shown over the film.

"00-05" indicates that the title should be shown five seconds after the report of the news items begins.

Example of a Newspaper Lead Rewritten for Broadcast

Newspaper Lead (Adapted from Mencher 2010):

- As Gov. Alfred Caster neared the end of his seven-day working vacation aboard a riverboat today, his aides said that he was

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unconcerned about editorial criticism that he had become an absentee governor whose administration was adrift.

Broadcast Lead:

- Some newspaper editorials have criticized Governor Caster as an absentee governor. But officials aboard a riverboat with the governor say the criticisms don't bother him. The governor is nearing the end of his seven-day working vacation on the boat.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Copy out two newspaper stories from the Punch newspaper and rewrite them for broadcast use.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Writing for the broadcast media is both tedious and interesting. An upcoming reporter or writer should pay attention to the details of doing this and do a lot of practice to master the art.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit re-emphasised some of the points discussed in the preceding units of this module. It is expected that you can now write a good broadcast story following the style and rules discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss five of some of the things you need to know as you prepare to write a broadcast news story.
2. Get any daily newspaper in Nigeria and rewrite its five top news stories into a radio news copy.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

- Agbese, D. (2008). *The Reporters' Companion*. Lagos: Newswatch Books Limited.
- Bonder, F. F.; Davenport, J. R., & Drager, M. W. (2005). *Reporting for the Mass Media* (8th ed.). New York: Oxford University Press.
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MODULE 1 GENERAL INTRODUCTION

Unit 1 What is News?/Elements of News Values and News Virtues

Unit 2 Qualities of a News Reporter

Unit 3 What Motivates a News Reporter?

Unit 4 General Rules for News Writing

UNIT 1 WHAT IS NEWS?/ELEMENTS OF NEWS

VALUES AND NEWS VIRTUES

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 What is News?

3.2 Elements of News Values

3.2.1 Determinants

3.2.2 Components

3.3 News Virtues

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

At this level of your academic life and studies, it is obvious one of the words you have accustomed to is NEWS. Each day, the Federal Radio Corporation of Nigeria (FRCN) gives you the Network News at 7am, updated again at 4pm and 10pm. The same goes for the Nigerian Television Authority (NTA) News at Dawn, Network News at 9pm, and so on. And with the era of private broadcast stations, the airwaves are now replete with all kinds of news. The same is not left out in the print media where the primary content is news. Therefore, it is common to hear “Here is the News at 7 read by Funmi Makanna.” “This is CNN with the News on the Hour”. On and on like that you are bombarded with news bulletins for upward of 18 hours a day. In addition, every morning you hear vendors hawking and distributing their newspapers with all kinds of techniques. In fact, before you stepped into the Department of Mass Communication, NOUN, for this course on News Writing and Reporting, you were already familiar with the pillars (or some of them at least) on which newspaper work is based. Therefore, for this course, before we delve into the rudiments of News Writing and

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Reporting, we must first and foremost understand what is news and the nature of news.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- define news
- identify and describe elements of news values
- identify and describe news virtues
- identify and explain the determinants and the components of news.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 What is News?

News is one of the most difficult issues to define in mass communication. There are almost as many definitions of news as there are journalists. Even laymen in the streets can readily come up with acceptable definitions of news. In general terms, news is very relative and depends on what one thinks is news. At any given moment, millions of events happen simultaneously throughout the world. “Obasanjo sacks Education Minister”, “FRA Williams dies,” “Super Eagles thrashes Gabon,” “Obama wins Re-election, Clinton in Sex Scandal, and so on are potentially news. However, they do not become news until some reporters give an account of them. In other words, news is the account of an event, not the event itself.

We can now consider some definitions given by scholars and media professionals thus:

William S. Maulsby defined news thus:

- News is an accurate, unbiased account of the significant facts of a timely happening that is of interest to the readers of the newspaper that prints the account.

William G. Bleyer defines it like this:

- News is anything timely that interests a number of people; and the best news is that which has the greatest interest for the greatest number.

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Mitchel Chainley defined news as:

- The timely report of facts or opinions that hold interest of

importance, or both for a considerable number of people.

Prof. Charles Coates defined it thus:

- News is what interests the reader, the viewer, the reporter, the editor, the producer, their spouses and their neighbours. News is what affects their diets and their lives.

Sam Zelman of CNN says:

- News is what is important because of its impact on society; it is what people need to know and what they want to know.

There have been other numerous definitions of news but interwoven in all of this is the fact that news must be something of interest to a significant number of people. In this regard, the nature of news is always changing because community interests and standards are always changing. For instance, the Western definition of news emphasises an event that is out of the ordinary, exciting, sensational, and of the “man-biting dog” variety. According to Lord Northcliffe, who revolutionised journalism in England between 1890 and 1920 (incidentally he died a raving lunatic but very wealthy), “if a dog bites a man, it is NOT news, but when a man bites a dog, it is News.”

This definition has since influenced Western journalists and media in the reportorial duties. To them, news is made in the developing countries only when there are scandals, coups, civil wars, uprisings, natural disasters, and so on. Western norms and values maintain that “bad” news is better than “good” news. That is why when 100 planes take off from a base to a destination and 99 of them arrive safely and one crashes, the 99 that arrived safely will not be mentioned or reported but much noise will be made about the only one that crashed. That is news for the Western mass media and audience.

However, for this course, I will define news as an accurate, unbiased account of a current, timely event, which is reported in the mass media and is significant to a large number of people in a locality. Furthermore, in contemporary thinking, today’s news is about real life, real people, real events, real places or real issues in a real world reported in real time using any available means of communication. Agbese (2008) also sees news as finding out and publishing the things people do not want others to know and second, anything that will make people talk.

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3.2 Elements of News Values

While definitions of news vary, the main determinant of what can be

considered as news is “INTEREST.” To be news, an account of an event must be of interest to the readers, listeners or viewers. Interest in a story is determined by the news values. The elements that determine news values may be subdivided into two groups.

- a. Determinants
- b. Components

3.2.1 Determinants

A determinant is a factor that sets the character of something, in this case, news. The determinants of news are as follow.

- a. Timeliness
- b. Proximity/geographic location
- c. Prominence/personality involved
- d. Consequence/impact/significance
- e. Human interest
- f. Novelty
- g. Conflict
- h. Necessity

Timeliness

Today’s news may be stale tomorrow. Therefore, to attain that reader – viewer or listener interest or appeal, facts must be fresh. However, some issues of great impact are timeliness. Therefore, the best time to tell an important story is as soon as it happens or as soon as possible.

Proximity/Geographic Location

Distance between the news item’s place of origin and its place of publication determines its degree of reader – appeal, and the limits of reader – interest. Usually, the nearer an individual is to the location of a news event, the more relevant it becomes for him/her. This is referred to as geographic proximity.

There are two types of proximity:

- Geographical Proximity - This has been described above.
- Proximity of Interest

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An account of students’ unrest in Kano will definitely interest students in Owerri than a businessman in Kano. This is referred to as proximity of interest.

Prominence/Personality Involved

All men may be created equal, but some are more equal and more newsworthy than others. In fact, “names make news” goes a cliché.

However, names do not always make news. Still, happenings that involve well-known people or institutions are likely to be interesting even if not very important.

Consequence/Impact/Significance/Magnitude

How many people an event or idea affects and how seriously it affects them determine its importance as news, as well as the extent to which the information may be useful. Again, an item or event may give rise to thought not because of itself but because of its probable consequences – its significance.

Human Interest

Interest in human beings and events because they concern men and women in situations that might confront anyone else, is called human interest. In a general way, human-interest stories might be defined as those stories that arouse an emotion in the reader/ listener/ viewer and evoke emotional response.

Novelty

This sounds like human interest but shows some differences. The unusual makes news. The bizarre makes news too. Remember the-man-bite-dog principle. The principle applies here. The first flight to the moon was big news, so was Sandra Day O' Connor's appointment as the first woman Justice of the United States Supreme Court. The day a female becomes the Vice President of the US it will be the biggest news around the globe. "Firsts," "Lasts," and "Only" have always been newsworthy. So also are stories of freak occurrences and scientific or pseudoscientific phenomena.

Conflict

Nearly every story on each of our front pages is a report of conflict. Conflict is a central feature of most news. Sometimes it is physical, as in wars or sports. Sometimes it is more subtle and sophisticated like political conflicts.

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Necessity

The seven earlier discussed news values involve people, events and situations that call out for coverage. The value of necessity is, however, the journalist's making (Mencher, 2010). According to the Mencher (2010), the journalist has discovered something he or she feels it is necessary to disclose. The essential element here is that the journalist considers a situation to be something everyone should know about and

usually it is a situation that needs to be exposed and remedied.

3.2.2 The Components of News

So far, we have been discussing the determinants of news. In this section, we shall be examining the components or the contents of news. A component is a constituent part of something. They tend to have more news values or higher news values than stories that lack them. The more of news components you find in a story, the higher the news worthiness of such a story.

Many items could easily fall into the components of news. However, we shall discuss eight that always sell a story anytime it is a content of such story. The eight components of news are:

1. Age
2. Animal
3. Sex
4. Conflict
5. Money
6. Children
7. Beauty
8. Human interest

News Virtues

Now that what news is and what determines readers' interest in a story have been discussed, reporters should strive to make the news they publish or broadcast win the credibility and confidence of their readers and listeners by adhering firmly to the triple news virtues.

These triple news virtues are:

Truth

All news stories must represent factual events and personalities. The reporter should also ensure that the facts of the News are truthful to the best of his/her knowledge before publishing or broadcasting such story.

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Objectivity

Objectivity presupposes that the reporter presents the reader with all sides of an issue, presents all the facts and allows the reader to decide what these facts mean. For a story to be objective, it must be devoid of a reporter's biases and prejudice. It must not also be slanted or editorialised.

Accuracy

This is the last news virtue. Accuracy is a pillar on which every story

rests. A news story can be regarded as accurate if all names, ages, addresses and direct quotations in the story are accurate or correct. The only way to meet this requirement is for the reporter to check, double-check or even triple-check his facts before going to the press.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss the elements of news values and why you think they are important in determining a story's relevance.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Definitions of news change with time, place and who is defining it. Many media organisations and individual journalists also define news differently partially influenced by their varying backgrounds. However, what constitutes news values remains constant-interest. This interest comes in form of values. In conclusion, Thomas Griffith famous quote [cited in Mencher (2010)] becomes relevant here: "Journalism is in fact history on the run. It is history written in time to be acted upon; thereby not only recording events but also at times influencing them. Journalism is also the recording of history while the facts are not all in."

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on news and what constitutes news values and virtues. In this unit, you were specifically taught about the various definitions of news, bringing up different perspectives; the eight elements of news values and the triple news virtues, which must be present for news stories to have credibility, relevance and wide acceptance.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Why do we have many and different definitions of news?
2. Discuss the major reasons why necessity made the list of news values.
3. Which among the news values must be present for a news story to have credibility? Justify your selection.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 QUALITIES OF A NEWS REPORTER

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Qualities of the News Reporter

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Reporters write stories, report events and happenings in and around the society. They provide the core of news stories that are published daily in our commercial newspapers or broadcast in the electronic media. As there is no substitute for good reporting, so also there is no substitute for good reporters. A good reporter is a great asset for his/her media organisation. He/she is the ear and the eye of his/her medium.

It is what he/she reports that the audience will know about. The reporter touches lives with his report.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify who a reporter is and what differentiates him/her from other media practitioner
- identify qualities of good reporters
- differentiate between a good reporter and a bad one.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Qualities of the News Reporter

Some of the major qualities that make a good reporter are discussed below.

S/he must have a mastery of the written or spoken language of the medium of expression: This will enable him/her to interact easily with news sources, eyewitnesses or even the victims of events.

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S/he must have a nose for news: This means the reporter or journalist

must be curious about getting news from newsy or stale situations. A good reporter must have a natural instinct for news and should be able to identify news from seemingly events that may not be considered newsworthy by everyone else.

S/he must be current and keep abreast of events and happenings: In the media industry, yesterday's news is stale and no more needed. To remain relevant in the industry, therefore, the reporter must keep abreast of happenings in and around him/her.

A good reporter must be fair, accurate and objective in his news writing and reporting job. Fairness, accuracy and objectivity are news virtues, which the profession thrives on. Any attempt to compromise any of these values makes a mess of the reputation and credibility of the industry. These qualities of a reporter must be jealously guarded.

A good reporter must be creative: Creativity makes the reporter see another unique story from an already published report. Without creativity, the reporter will remain dry, uninspiring and boring to his readers and even his sources.

S/he must also have the ability to dress well: A common idiom says how you dress is how you are addressed and I add that it also betrays your address. A good reporter must know how to dress for the occasion otherwise he/she will be lost in the crowd or misrepresented. Dressing well is not necessarily dressing expensively. It only means having the right kind of dress for each occasion or situation.

A good reporter must have perseverance: Perseverance is having the staying power and refusing to give up even when the situation calls for giving up. A good reporter must have the ability to stay longer and under stress or pressure.

A good reporter must be a "good mixer": There is no room for the reserved kind of reporter who cannot easily get into a discussion with a potential news source. A good reporter should be able to blend easily with all kinds of persons especially when such persons are primary to getting the news he/she is pursuing at that moment. The good reporter should be able to make contacts, grow and maintain them.

S/he must have a high level of comportsment: The good reporter must have self-control and high level of comportsment no matter the situation or circumstances. He/she is not expected to be carried away easily by any surrounded situation.

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A good reporter must have the ability to embark on creative risk and courage especially in reporting coups, wars, conflicts, crime, disaster etc.

S/he must have the ability to ferret out news through the process of monitoring people and events.

S/he must also possess good observatory skills and have an eye for details: Poorly trained reporters look without seeing. The good reporter is able to see leads and news worthy situations by merely observing people and situations. Whenever the good reporter looks, he/she sees. He/she is also able to taken in a lot of details by mere observation.

S/he must be a good listener and must have an unusual patience: The poorly trained reporters are only interested in hearing their voices in an interview situation. However, a good reporter is only interested in hearing the news source talk. Therefore, listening becomes a vital quality a reporter must possess in order to succeed.

S/he should also possess enough idealism to inspire indignant prose but not too much as to obstruct detached professionalism (Ragged Right cited in Agbese, 2008).

A good and modern reporter must be multi-skilled: S/he should be equipped with an array of skills to meet the demands of diverse media users (Mencher, 2010).

A good and modern reporter must also have the unique quality called enterprise: He/she should be able to work through tougher assignments or situation by instantaneously assessing the situation and taking decisions and steps that will give him/her what the media organisation wants.

A good reporter must also have the strength of character to lead a disrupted personal life without going absolutely haywire (Ragged Right cited in Agbese, 2008).

4.0 CONCLUSION

Good reporters are great assets to their media organisations. Not everyone who went to a journalism school usually turns out to become a good reporter. This is the primary reason they are always sought after anywhere they could be found. According to Sid Bedingfield, President, Fault Line Productions (cited in Mencher, 2010), "Reporting is the essential ingredient in good journalism. Everything else is

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dressing....The reporter is the engine that drives the newspaper, the

contributor who makes the newscast worthwhile.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit specifically dealt with the qualities a good reporter who wants to work in a reputable media organisation must have. Fifteen of such qualities were discussed in this unit. Further readings may bring up some more.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. As an aspiring reporter identify and discuss five solid qualities you think you must possess to be able to assume a reportorial role in a Newspaper organisation.
2. The Nigerian media industry is a unique media terrain. Discuss 10 relevant and time-tested qualities that will help you survive as an upcoming reporter.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 3 WHAT MOTIVATES A NEWS REPORTER?

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
- 3.1 What Motivates a News Reporter?
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Reporters populate most media organisations but not all of them win the Pulitzer Prize. Those who do are usually motivated by something to do the extra, which results in awards and peer-recognition. This unit therefore focuses on the seven motivating factors identified by Byron

Calame, the Public Editor of New York Times (cited in Mencher, 2010).

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the motivating factor for news reporter.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 What Motivates a News Reporter?

Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010) identified seven motivating factors while working and competing with more than a 100 reporters in his successful career as a reporter and editor.

Being first with new facts or fresh insights

Every reporter really desires to be the first to get the news out. The so-called old fashioned scoops are still fashionable even in today's media industry. Being the first gives them a sense of fulfillment and originality.

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Pursuing stories that can have impact

Successful reporters are usually motivated by the desire that their outputs changed the course history. Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein of the famed Watergate Scandal are examples of reporters in this class.

Winning prizes

This is a little controversial because most journalists argue that their stories were not motivated by prize and awards. But a careful look at the work of journalists suggests this is one of the motivating factors.

Impressing sources

According to Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010), most of the journalists remain highly motivated to impress their sources with the accuracy, fairness and depth of their work.

Finding out what's really happening

According to Byron Calame cited in Mencher (2010), "A fundamental motivation of reporters is the curiosity that drives them to get to the bottom of a confusing or complicated situation and to find patterns that help explain it to readers. Making sense out of chaos-especially when you can do it first-is something many reporters find rewarding."

Telling stories in a compelling way

Most reporters who aim to the top are usually moved to tell their stories in a way that their listeners or audiences are compelled to see to the end of the story.

Getting on the front page

Any reporter who spends five months in a media organisation, say newspaper, and does not get on the front page of the paper, may be regarded as not doing well. Front page stories are big stories in the judgment of editors. So, reporters strive to have a sense of fulfillment that their story was considered big and good to make a front page. The feeling is always rewarding and unexplainable.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

In your own words, discuss five factors that drive reporters to success.

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4.0 CONCLUSION

In life, there must be something that drives you to fulfillment. The same is applicable to careers especially in the media industry. Reporters are not amongst the richest in the society and the profession is not very financially rewarding especially in Nigeria. There must be something then that drives reporters in this part of the world to be courageous and take creative risks. These factors are what we attempted to discuss in this unit.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, we considered the various factors motivating reporters and journalists alike to career growth and fulfillment. These factors were from the work of Byron Calame, the Public Editor or Ombudsman of The New York Times. Seven of such motivating factors were identified and discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. In your own assessment, suggest two other factors that you think motivate reporters that were not discussed in this unit.
2. Defend the argument that winning prizes does not motivate reporters.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

Agbese, D. (2008). *The Reporters' Companion*. Lagos Nigeria: Newswatch Books Limited.

Mencher, M. (2010). *Mencher's News Writing and Reporting*. (11th ed.). Boston: McGraw-Hill Higher Education.

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UNIT 4 GENERAL RULES FOR NEWS WRITING

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

1.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 General Rules for News Writing and Reporting

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The success of any profession depends on the quality of rules and regulations guiding such a profession and concerted efforts to ensure such regulations are not tampered with. In this unit, we shall be considering the general and basic rules that guide news writing and reporting.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify not less than 20 rules that guide news writing and reporting.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 General Rules for News Writing and Reporting

- Do not pass a verdict or make a judgment: It is not your duty as a reporter or writer to pass a verdict or make judgment. Just gather the facts of the story, present them to your audience and let them decide on whose side they will want to go.

- Do not editorialise: Leave editorialising to the editorial writers.

News reports must be as straightforward and objective as possible.

- Avoid the use of unfamiliar jargon: Do not assume that your audience understands the meanings of the unfamiliar jargons you are using. Always use familiar words.

- Keep yourself and other reporters out of the story: Keep yourself and other colleagues out of the story unless you and them are an essential part of the news.

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- Avoid the use of “told me,” “told this writer” or “told our reporter: The phrase “in an interview will serve your purpose.
- There must be perfect accuracy in writing and reporting:

When in doubt, leave it out.

- There must be no willful distortion of facts in either news or headlines: Never tamper with the facts of a story no matter the benefits that may accrue to you as a result. This is an unforgivable offence in journalism. Any reporter who tampers or fabricates the so-called facts of a story is “finished” in the industry. You become leprous, untouchable and unemployable.
 - Guard against publication of libelous statement: The good reporter is the one who lives to write another report and see the fame of the previous reports come to him. Avoid writing your way into jail. Libelous statements should be avoided because of its capacity to keep you in jail and close down your media organisation because of insolvency resulting from the inability to pay court fines.
 - Always use simple words: News writing and reporting are not the platforms to impress anybody with long sounding and big words. Always use the nearest simple word. A good news report is the one the average reader reads and understands.
 - All news copies must be typewritten and double-spaced: The era of hand-written copies is gone. Therefore, a reporter must know how to type his story using the computer. It must also be typed in double space so that sub-editors and editors will be able to edit the copy.
 - The first page must carry the reporter’s surname, a slug line and date in the top left hand corner: Slug lines must be short-preferably one word.
 - Start your story halfway down the first page: You must give enough space for your superior editorial staff to work on your copy.
 - Leave at least one-inch margin at left, right, top and bottom of each page: Do not overcrowd the pages. Leave appropriate margins as required.
 - Each page must be numbered or lettered: The correct letter or numeral is in the form of “B copy next” or “page 2 next.” This type of numbering must appear at the bottom right hand corner of each page except the last.
- The end of a story must be marked by a centred “30” or “***” or “#.”
- Always make your lead interesting: Guard against misleading leads. Leads sell a story. Therefore, to get and keep the attention of your audience, the lead must be interesting.

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- Use the inverted pyramid format when writing your news story: This is the generally accepted format for writing news reports because it presents the most important elements of a story in the first few paragraphs. The format also makes it easy to cut stories from the bottom without losing any substance of the story.
- You must quote accurately: Use quotes only where necessary to brighten up your story. Please, do not overdo this in your copy.
- Use “said” if you want to write in the present tense and “said that” if it is reported speech: This style helps the copy retain currency and life.
- Always read your copy carefully and connect all typographical spelling and grammatical mistakes before turning it in: This is a primary rule even in ordinary or everyday writing. No amount of haste could justify a badly written copy.
- Your copy must be submitted in duplicate and both copies must be properly edited
- Never underline words or phrases or titles of books in your copy
- A seasoned reporter and publisher, do not exaggerate, do not over-dramatise, beware of adjectives, use the active voice and be natural and conversational when you write

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Identify at least 10 rules guiding writing a good copy of news and report.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The media industry is an organised industry and so there must rules and regulations guiding how copies are written and filled for publication. Some of these rules may differ from country to country but the underlying fact is that they make for good writing. Any report that lacks these rules or some of them will definitely turn out rejected by a reputable editor or media organisation.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the rules that make for a good copy. It is believed that you are now familiar with these rules after going through this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify 10 rules of news writing and argue that they should be retained even beyond this century.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

Agbese, D. (2008). *The Reporters' Companion*. Lagos: Newswatch Books Limited.

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MODULE 2 THE BASICS

Unit 1 Elements of Good Writing/What Makes for Poor Writing?

Unit 2 Conducting Interviews

Unit 3 News Gathering and Sources

Unit 4 Journales

UNIT 1 ELEMENTS OF GOOD WRITING/WHAT MAKES FOR POOR WRITING?

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Elements of Good Writing

3.1.1 Precision

3.1.2 Clarity

3.1.3 Pace

3.1.4 Transitions

3.1.5 Sensory Appeal

3.1.6 Analogies

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

A good reporter must first and foremost be a good writer. This is because his writing skills are needed in his news writing and reporting job as a journalist. A poor writer can never make a good news writer or reporter. Good news writing begins first from understanding the elements of good writing and applying them in our writing assignments. This is the focus of this unit. Good writing has six characteristics, which are called elements of good writing.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the rules or elements of good writing and demonstrate a reasonable skill in the use of such element
- identify and discuss the elements that could constitute poor writing.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Elements of Good Writing

3.1.1 Precision

A good writer must always obey the rule of precision. Words should be used and they should mean exactly what you intend them to mean. You should never use for example “uninterested” when you mean “disinterested”, nor should you use “farther” for “further”. For instance, if you report that fire has destroyed a house, you mean it must be rebuilt, not repaired. If you say fire fighters donned oxygen masks to enter a burning building, you are impugning either their intelligence or yours. Oxygen is dangerous around fire; fire fighters use their tanks.

Words are the tools of your trade and the writer can use only certain words in certain situations. In addition, the writer can choose from many words. That freedom can be both exhilarating and dangerous.

3.1.2 Clarity

All news reports and stories must be clearly written. Every reporter should be aware of the following when attempting to write clear stories.

- Use simple sentences and familiar words.
- Use correct grammar and punctuation.
- Structure the story to have a beginning (lead), middle (body) and end (conclusion).
- Make use of the active voice.
- Avoid adjectives and exaggeration.

3.1.3 Pace

Good writing must have a pace appropriate to the content. Sentences and words give a story mood. Short sentences convey action, tension and movement. A series of long sentences conveys a more relaxed mood; long sentences slow down the reader. Between these two extremes are sentences of varying lengths, and good writers use them all. Not all sentences should be long or short. Nor should they all be of medium length. An abrupt change in sentence length draws attention to the

sentence. Try it sometimes.

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3.1.4 Transitions

Good writing uses transitional devices that lead the reader from one thought to the next. A transition is a bridge, which assures the reader that the writer has a sense of direction. A transition can be a word, a phrase, a sentence or a paragraph. Common transitions are “and,” “but” and “however.”

3.1.5 Sensory Appeal

Good writing must appeal to the reader’s senses. Good writing appeals to one or more of our five senses: sight, hearing, smell, taste and touch.

3.1.6 Analogies

Good writing uses analogies. Analogies permit writers to show similarities and contrasts. Similes and metaphors are often used to achieve this purpose. Where the simile compares one thing to another, a metaphor says one thing is another. With similes and metaphors, writers draw word pictures.

What Makes For Poor Writing?

If the story shows dull writing: Dull writing never makes good copy. To avoid this always use active voice and make your write up conversational and lively.

If the story is not interesting: Interest is a constant variable in selecting a story as good. Any uninteresting story will sure pass off as a clear evidence of poor writing.

If the story is too vague, abstract or unclear: Vague and abstract stories will always be rejected on the platform of poor writing. To make your stories interesting, it must be clear and unambiguous.

If there are too many stories already on the subject: Your story could be rejected as poor if you are writing on what every other person has written on. This is even worsened by the fact that you did not bring in any new or fresh facts to your writing. Therefore, avoid writing on what every other person has written on if you do not want your report to be considered poor.

If the story is a piece of propaganda or resembles one: Any attempt to pass off a piece of propaganda for a news report or story will definitely be rejected as poor writing.

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If the story is trivial: Trivial and unimportant stories are likely to be rejected as poor writing or evidence of it. Write on important issues that will interest majority of your audience.

If the story is not in good taste: Any writing that offends public morality or shows evidence of bad taste in the choice of words and phrases will be rejected as poor writing.

If the story runs against the policy of the newspaper or its style guide: Every media organisation has a style guide- a body of rules that guides how a particular media establishment intends to present its reports and stories. Any violation of the style guide will send your paper to the editor's wastebasket.

If the story has too many figures and statistics: People naturally hate stories with too many figures and statistics. If your story is, for instance, about a budget proposal, find a creative way of presenting.

If the story is free publicity stunt: A story that is free publicity stunt usually tries to trick readers with an advertising matter in a form of a news story. Readers and editors normally abandon such stories.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

1. Discuss five elements that must be available before you could consider writing as good.
2. Why will an editor or writer regard a story as poor writing?

4.0 CONCLUSION

Knowing how to write generally is the first practical step to knowing how to write for media organisations. The elements of good writing therefore serve as fundamental pillars upon which good writing rests.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the elements of good writing. Six of such elements were discussed. Also discussed in this unit are the elements that could make one's writing turn out poor. About 10 of such were also discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Defend the argument that the presence of the elements of good writing will definitely return a copy as good.
2. Discuss the major reasons why a copy may turn out as poor writing.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 CONDUCTING INTERVIEWS

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 4.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 Types of Interviews
 - 3.2 Preparing and Conducting the Interview
 - 3.3 Phrasing the Questions
 - 3.4 Establishing Rapport with a Source
 - 3.5 How to Ensure Accuracy in an Interview
 - 3.5.1 Techniques to Ensuring Accuracy
 - 3.5.2 Other Techniques to Achieving Accuracy
 - 3.6 Quotes and Attributions
 - 3.6.1 What to Quote Directly
 - 3.6.2 Problems in Direct Quotation

3.6.3 Correcting Quotes

3.6.4 Attributing Direct and Indirect Quotes

3.6.5 Guidelines on How to Attribute Information

3.7 Handling On and Off-the-Record Information

3.7.1 Guidelines for Citing Sources

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The interview is the art of meeting people and asking them questions with a view to eliciting information on specific issues or happenings. Generally, a reporter conducts interviews when he needs information about events or issues of public significance. The interview is a journalist's tool for digging out facts and its importance in the news gathering process cannot be over-emphasised.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- prepare and carry out a successful interview
- identify the different types of interviews and how to organise them
- establish rapport with an interviewee
- quote and attribute correctly
- handle on- and off-the-record information more professionally.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Types of Interviews

Exclusive Interview

This refers to an interview exclusively conducted by a reporter without any other reporter participating in it.

Panel Interview

In this interview, more than one reporter from a particular media establishment participates in the interview.

Telephone Interview

This is conducted through the telephone especially now that telecommunication industry in Nigeria has improved greatly.

Personality Interview

This is conducted with the view to gathering information concerning a person whose life's activities the reporter wants to write about. Most personality interviews are usually done on an exclusive basis.

On-the-Spot Interviews

This refers to situations when reporters ask other persons impromptu questions, usually people who are important in government, visiting dignitaries, social celebrities, top military officers, academics, big business persons etc. The interview is usually transit in nature and takes place during stop over at the Airport, venue of events, and so on.

Group Interviews

Many reporters from different media organisations participate in this type of interview. It is usually a question-and-answer session during press conferences, press briefings, and so on.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 1

Identify and discuss five types of interviews usually conducted in the Nigerian media industry today.

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3.2 Preparing and Conducting the Interview (Interview Skills)

1. The reporter who wants to conduct an interview must "Be Prepared." The first step is to identify the subject of the interview and the personality to be interviewed. As a reporter, you must establish the need for the interview. You must also have a good idea of the kind of information you seek, so that everything that is given to you will not seem like what you are looking for. Having identified the subject and the person to be interviewed, you go ahead and book an appointment with the interviewee. You can book appointment through the telephone, you can go to his/her office or visit him/her at home as a last resort. Make sure you book an appointment first.
2. If the interviewee wants to know why you want to interview him/her, you could give him/her a general idea and nothing more. It is unprofessional to give out your entire questions to the interviewer ahead of time. You will end up with canned answers.
3. You then prepare your questions and arrange them in order of importance. You are not expected to forward the questions to the interview before the interview date.
4. Do a thorough background research on the subject matter and

familiarise yourself with the historical background, social and economic activities of the interviewee. His political leanings and hobbies must not be overlooked.

5. On the day of the interview, arrive at the venue of the interview on time at least 15 minutes before the interview. This gives you a cool start.

6. Listen and listen well. Let the interviewee do the talking and encourage him by nodding your head, but do not overdo this. Do not interrupt to offer your opinion, but you can ask necessary follow-up questions when the need arises.

7. You should watch out for the interviewee's emotional tone level (ETL) as the interview progresses. The ETL may fluctuate from time to time due to the intensity of the interview. If the ETL is too high, you should try to bring it low by asking trivial questions. If it is too low, you should try to raise it by asking sensitive and breath-taking questions.

8. If you are conducting the interview with a microphone or tape recorder, always hold it yourself. Never allow your interviewees to hold the microphone otherwise they will take over the control of the interview.

9. When the interview reaches the central theme, the question should be short and delivered at a time. Try to make the interviewee answer the central questions.

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10. Never feel intimidated about the personality you are to interview. Do not forget you are not there in your own capacity, you are representing majority of the audience who read or watch your media organisation. Therefore, be confident. It gives you a cool and calculated head.

11. The first question is very vital. Settle for a simple, non-committal question. This will help to reduce any tension already in the atmosphere.

12. Do not ask dead-end questions. Dead end questions do not require detailed answers. They may end up with YES or NO kind of responses.

13. Do not be prosecutorial in your approach. Remember the interviewee is not on trial and you are not a lawyer or judge.

14. Do not lecture the interviewee; ask your questions as straightforward as possible.

15. Take note of the tape recorder, midget or any other electronic

device you are using as anything they can easily develop fault.

16. At the end of the interview, you should not hesitate to thank the interviewee and assure him that you may call again if the need arises for further clarification about issues raised in the interview.

17. Finally, when writing your story, never forget the off-the-record rule as some information might have been given to you off record. Never abuse privileges and confidences. Such abuses hinder the growth of the industry.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 2

Discuss 10 vital skills a budding reporter needs to have in conducting interviews.

3.3 Phrasing the Questions

The way an accomplished lawyer asks questions determines whether the lawyer will win his case or not. The journalist faces the same challenge. Reporters have missed many stories because they did not know how to ask questions. By the phrasing of the question, many reporters signal the response they expect or prejudices they have. There are basically two ways a reporter could phrase his/her questions to get the desired results. The first is through the open-ended questions and the second is through the close-ended question.

Open-Ended Questions

Open-ended questions allow the respondent some flexibility. In response to an open-ended question, the source often reveals more than he or she realises or intends to. Open-ended questions are less direct and less

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threatening. They are more exploratory and more flexible. However, if you want a person's biographical data, do not say "Tell me about yourself".

Close-ended Questions

Close-ended questions are designed to elicit specific responses. Instead of asking a previous employee to appraise a Minister-designates' managerial competence, you may ask, "How well does Chief Ekeanyanwu listen to the people who work for him?" "Does he explain his decisions?" When you ask vague questions, you may likely get vague answers. By asking a specific question, you are more likely to get a specific answer.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 3

Discuss four benefits close-ended questions have over open-ended

questions.

3.4 Establishing Rapport with a Source

The right chemistry produces an interview that is fun for both parties. When John Lindsay was the mayor of New York, the AP's Pett opened an interview with the question, "Would you want your daughter to marry a mayor of New York?" Lindsay roared in laughter and Pett had a great interview.

Rapport is the relationship between the reporter and the source and is very crucial to the source of the interview. The relationship is sometimes relaxed, sometimes strained. Often it is somewhere in between. The type of relationship you try to establish with your source is determined by the kind of story you are writing.

There are several approaches to establishing rapport with a source (These approaches also serve as interview approaches). They include:

1. You can start off with small talk and allow the familiarity to graduate to the level you could take advantage of and then bring up the major issues of the interview.
2. Bring up something humorous about the interviewee you have found out during your research and which you think can interest the interviewee in your opening statements. This may be the small talk that will create the needed rapport for you.
3. Ask about something you know the source will want to talk about. If he is a premiership fan and ready to bet his life over Chelsea, take advantage and talk about the Chelsea versus Man U

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penultimate game that may decide who wins the EPL 2011 Season. Once he identifies he has same addictions and hobbies like you, he creates the rapport for you to talk to him.

4. Show sources what you have in common. This will support the Number 3 point made above.
5. Empathise with your sources or subjects. Do not be judgemental. Sometimes, it may help to put yourself in their shoe and feel their pains. This may draw you closer during the interview process.
6. Conduct the interview where the source feels most comfortable. When you create such a relaxed mood for him, he comes out as if he has known you for a long time. The ultimate outcome may a great interview for you.
7. Where you sit in relation to the person you are interviewing could also be important in determining the kind of rapport you develop.

Unless you are deliberately trying to make the interviewee feel uncomfortable, do not sit directly in front of him/her. Permit your sources to establish eye contact if and when they wish.

8. Tape recorders ensure accuracy of quotes, but they make many speakers self-conscious or nervous. Try to place it in an inconspicuous spot and ignore it.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 4

Discuss four practical things you need to do to establish a rapport with a source you are about to interview.

3.5 How to Ensure Accuracy in an Interview

Accuracy is a major problem in all interviews. Both the question and the answer may be ambiguous. You may not understand what is said and you may record it incorrectly too. You may not know the context of the remarks and your biases may interfere with the message.

3.5.1 Techniques to Ensuring Accuracy

To ensure accuracy, the following techniques could be adopted.

- a. Observing: Some reporters look but do not see. As a reporter, when you look, please, observe.
- b. Understanding: Understanding what you see is crucial to the news gathering process, so also is the understanding of what you hear. Never assume you understand. Make sure you do. Ignorance is never an excuse in law.
- c. Asking Follow-up Questions: If you understand what the source is saying, you should show this by asking meaningful follow-up questions.

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3.5.2 Other Techniques to Achieving Accuracy

1. Encourage the speaker to add more details.
2. Another device to making the source talk is not a question at all; it is a pause.
3. Before you leave, ask if there is anything you forgot to ask. Put the burden on the source. You are also doing him a favour by giving him the chance to contribute to direction of the interview.
4. Quickly review your note and check facts, especially dates, numbers, quotes, spellings and titles.
5. As a matter of courtesy, tell the source when the story might appear.
6. Remember that the interview may be over, but your relationship

with the source still stays.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 5

Discuss the primary techniques adopted by reporters to achieve accuracy.

3.6 Quotes and Attributions

Introduction: Direct quotes add colour and credibility. By using direct quotes, you are putting your audience directly in touch with the speaker. Like a letter, direct quotes are personal. Not everything people say should be put into direct quotes. You need to learn what to quote directly, when to use partial quotes and when to paraphrase. You must also learn how and how often to attribute a remark because some information may not excuse you from a possible libel suit. Therefore, you must also learn to deal with off-the-record quotes and background information.

3.6.1 What to Quote Directly

Brief, precise and relevant quotes spice up any story. However, you can overdo a good thing. You need direct quotes in your story, no doubt but you also need to develop your skill in recognising what is worth quoting. Make use of the following guidelines:

- Use direct quotes when someone says something unique.
- Use direct quotes when someone says something uniquely.
- Use direct quotes when someone important says something important.

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3.6.2 Problems in Direct Quotation

a. Paraphrasing quotes: Some quotations need verifications while others need clarification. Do not quote someone unless you are sure of what that person means. The best way to avoid confusing and unclear quotes or needlessly long wordy quotes is to paraphrase.

b. Partial quotes: It is also much better to paraphrase or to use full quotes than to use fragmentary or partial quotes. Example:

- The Vice-Chancellor said lecturers should “turn off” unnecessary lights and “lock up” before closing for the day.

This sentence will be better off without quotation marks. Again, partial quotes often contain an ellipsis inside them to tell the reader that some of the words of the quotes are missing. Example:

- “I have come here tonight ... and I have crossed state lines ... to

conspire against the government”.

This practice at times may be justifiable, but you should not keep the reader guessing and wondering what is missing.

3.6.3 Correcting Quotes

None of us regularly speaks in perfect, grammatical sentences. The same persons when writing down his remarks presumably would write grammatically and correctly.

Therefore, it is accepted practice on many newspapers to correct grammar and to put a person’s remark into complete sentences. This has, however, brought some controversy. The question is “Would you fix a quote to make the person you are quoting sound grammatical?” Here are some opinions and answers from renowned reporters.

- Columnist James Kilpatrick: Sure. It is elementary courtesy, and every one does it. You don’t change the substance of your subject’s thought, of course. You could make anyone in politics look ridiculous if you quoted him verbatim all the time with all the ands, ifs, buts, and ors.
- Jack Newfield, former Senior Editor for Village Voice: No, I don’t. New York political leader Meade Esposito’s colorfulness comes from his lack of grammar.
- The AP Style Book: According to this style, quotations normally should be corrected to avoid the errors in grammar and word

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usage that often occur unnoticed when someone is speaking but are embarrassing in print.

- Use of Obscenity: On most newspapers, some things people say are never permitted in print, even if they are said uniquely. Newspapers rarely print obscenities, profanities or vulgarities unless they are essential to the story. For instance, obscenities are not used in the Washington Post except with the approval of a top editor. However, if it is a “Hardcore” obscenity referring to the body and sexual or excretory functions, The Washington Post’s Style Book calls for the first letter followed by dashes. E.g. He called the President a “f--king fool”

3.6.4 Attributing Direct and Indirect Quotes

In composition and creative writing classes, you may have been told to avoid repeating the same words. This is not so in news writing and reporting especially for the word “said”. Reporters and editors prefer

forms of the verb “to say” in most instances, even if they are repeated throughout a story. There are reasons for doing so:

- ‘Said’ is Unobtrusive – Not easily noticeable and hides in the news columns and calls no attention to itself.
- ‘Said’ is Neutral - It has no connotations.
- ‘Said’ is Objective – It does not depict the reporter’s biases.

3.6.5 Guidelines on How to Attribute Information

1. If a direct quote is more than one sentence long, place the attribution at the end of the first sentence. Example:

- The bus overturned at least three times,” the policeman said.
“None of the twenty passengers was hurt. Luckily, the car did not explode to flames.

2. Do not follow a fragment of a quote with a continuing complete sentence of quotation. For example:

- WRONG: - The Vice-Chancellor said the time had come “to turn off some lights. We all must do something to conserve electricity.”
- RIGHT: - “The time has come to turn off some lights,” the Vice Chancellor said. “We must all do something to conserve electricity.”

Always separate partial quotes and complete quotes.

3. The First time you attribute a direct or indirect quote, identify the speaker fully. Example:

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- The Vice-Chancellor of Covenant University, Prof Aize Immonokhome Obayan, said students will no longer be allowed to wear jean trousers to lectures.

4. Do not attribute direct quotes to more than one person, as in the following:

- “The bullets came out from everywhere,” witnesses said. “The protesters had guns, even the children amongst them.”

You can however eliminate the quotation marks, if indeed any witness made the statement. Never make up a source and never invent a quote for anonymous witnesses. It is dishonest, inaccurate and inexcusable.

5. In stories covering past news events, use the past tense in attributing, and use it throughout the story. However, stories that do not report on news events, such as features, may be effective if

the attributions are consistently in present tense. Example:

- “‘I like being the mayor,’ she says”

You are indicating that she still enjoys it.

6. Ordinarily, place the noun or pronoun before the verb in attributions. Example:

- “Everything is under control,” the Inspector General of Police said.

7. If you must identify a person by indicating a long title, it is better to begin the attribution with the verb. Example:

- “I enjoy the new position,” says Prof. Prince Izedonmi, Dean of Post Graduate Studies, Covenant University.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 6

1. How would you handle errors in direct quotation?
2. Discuss the guidelines in attributing information.

3.7 Handling On and Off – the – Record Information

Introduction: Sometimes a speaker or source may not want to be quoted at all – directly or indirectly. Therefore, you must learn to use sound professional judgement in handling them. If you agree to accept their information, you must honour their request to remain off the record. Breaching that confidence destroys trust and credibility.

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3.7.1 Guidelines for Citing Sources

Not naming sources is dangerous for two important reasons:

- Such information will lack credibility and make the reporter and the newspaper suspect.
- The source may be lying.

The following distinctions are made regarding sources and attributions:

1. Off-the-Record: This means you cannot use the information given to you no matter the situation or pressure of breaking out with a scoop.
2. On Record: This means you can use the information as well as attribute it to the source. This is the ideal situation you must get your sources to give you information. Anything outside this is a risk.
3. Not for Attribution: This means you may use the information but may not attribute it to the source. You must take responsibility for the use of the information.

4. On Background: This means you may use the information but with a general title for a source. Example: "A Presidential Aide", "A Senior Official". The real source's name must be mentioned.
5. On Deep Background: This means you may use the information, but you must say it on your own and take responsibility.

Please note that there is currently no universal agreement on these terms as different practitioners in different circumstances interpret them differently. Therefore, your obligation is to make sure you and your sources understand each other. Set the ground rules ahead of time. Clarify your terms and make sure you know the policy of your paper on such matters.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 7

Discuss the guidelines for citing sources.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The interview remains one of practical ways a reporter uses to gather news and information in the course of his/her assignment. It is necessary therefore for every reporter to learn the skills of interviewing and apply them where and when necessary.

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5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt:

- the meaning of interviewing
- the art of interviewing
- different types of interviews
- the techniques and skills required to carry out an interview and the various ways to quote and attribute information that comes from interviews.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Is interviewing and art or a science? Please, justify your answer with valid argument.
2. Discuss five primary types of interviews a news reporter could carry out in the course of his/her assignment.
3. Discuss 10 effective approaches to carrying out a successful interview.

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UNIT 3 NEWS GATHERING AND SOURCES

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

To define news is one thing to get it is another. To gather news the

reporter must know where and when to look for it, what and whom to see, why and how to verify the facts he assembled and when and how to use the information he has gotten to write a story. News gathering is the major occupation of both cub and experienced reporters. This is the major reason greater attention will be paid to it in this unit.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- explain the meaning of news gathering and its vital role in the daily reportorial duty of a journalist
- differentiate the types of sources available to the reporter and how to deal with them
- discuss how to find the story idea, especially during periods of news “scarcity”
- discuss how to cross-check the facts of your story
- discuss how to develop and grow your sources.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 News Gathering and Sources

Every story begins as a stream does “from a source”. You cannot find a great story today that does not have a source. This reminds me what one of my great Professors told me “every PhD has a story!” Such stories also have a beginning. This is the major reason most persons who are unfamiliar with the news gathering process often wonder how reporters gather and assemble their information, how do they get access to information and information sources, and how do they sustain the daily publication of news in their media organisations. This shall be our concern in this section. There are three broad categories of sources of news stories thus:

1. Predictable Sources
2. Unpredictable Sources
3. Anticipated Sources

3.1.1 Predictable Sources

These are sources that regularly service the news industry either because of their function that make their activities of public interest or by their nature that help generate events that attract a large number of people. Predictable sources include diary of news, published reports in form of newspapers, magazines, journals, and handouts, broadcast on Radio/TV and prepared speeches. It also includes active or dramatic newsbreaks,

which include news from the police, hospitals, fire service, hotels, schools, religious organisations, labour and political associations. With predictable sources, you are sure to get something from there all the time.

3.1.2 Unpredictable Sources

This means a nose for news that borders on the ability, training, exposure and experience of the reporter to determine what news is and report it accordingly. Unpredictable sources are the likely sources where breaking news or tips that could lead to scoop could come from.

3.1.3 Anticipated Sources

This is similar to predictable sources except for the fact that anticipated sources are restricted to planned events that a reporter knows will definitely happen. Such events include a national day celebration, budget speech and special anniversaries, workers' day, and so on.

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No matter the sources of getting news, a good reporter should have the ability to listen, see and possess attributes of a good interviewer. These are needed in dealing with those sources.

In summary, a reporter gets news by:

- Going to the scene of the news event and observe events unfold;
- Talking to people who witnessed the event as it happens or what you will consider as using eye witness accounts;
- Consulting secondary sources like records, reports, documents, files, and so on to cross check and corroborate facts and figures.

Sources could also be human in nature, physical or online. Human sources are those personal contacts you have build over time. They are also authorities and people involved in news events. The physical sources are consists of records, documents, reference works, and so on. The online sources include a vast array of human and physical sources, from academics to government data (Mencher, 2010).

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 1

Discuss the various ways a reporter could gather news of an event he or she did not witness.

3.2 How to Find the Story Idea

How to find the story idea has always pricked the mind of reporters especially during lull period. However, the imaginative reporter will discover in this section that the story idea could be obtained from a lot of places. For instance, readers sometimes bring story ideas to the

newspaper office. Most of these story ideas are the result of an active imagination, a lively curiosity and assistance from friends. Journalists soon learn to recognise how stories written for other publications can be written for their own. They get in the habit of carrying a little notebook to jot down ideas when something somebody says strikes a responsive chord. Sometimes even for good journalists, the wellspring of ideas sometimes dries up. Therefore, take note of these 10 sources of story ideas. They are good for anytime and anyplace. They were compiled from the earlier version of Mencher (2003).

Other People

As a journalist, you meet many people from time to time. What are they discussing when they are not discussing business? What have they heard lately? Journalists have to listen even if it means eavesdropping while having a cup of tea. What do you think interest people? There is no

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better source of story ideas than the people you meet while you are off-duty or on duty. They are, after all, your readers. Therefore, take note of others and always try to find out what is on their mind. Whenever you look, try to see beyond your nose.

Other Publications

News stories are sometimes recycled across the country by different media organisations in different ways. Read other newspapers, magazines, books, pamphlets and the house journals and newsletters of businesses and organisations. Please note that all stories cannot fit in every community. You have to know your own readership. A story about urban renewal will definitely attract more attention in urban area than in rural area. When you are reading other publications for ideas, remember that you should not duplicate a story in your own newspaper report verbatim; only look for idea from which to develop your story.

News releases

Releases from public relations persons are valuable sources of story ideas. Try to follow up on some of these regular releases that come to your media organisation. You may never know where they will take you to or predict the end.

Social services directory

Many cities and localities have a composite listing of all agencies providing social services. These listings could throw up different kinds of ideas about the society, which a reporter could follow through. You

should therefore take note that each of those agencies and their clients could lead to a potential story.

Government reports

Aso Rock is the Nigerian seat of Government. On a daily basis, information and statistics flow from such a place. However, behind every piece of statistics is a person. Every person is a potential story. The census report for instance contains not only the number of people in a community, but also their income and education, how many cars they own, whether they rent or own a house, and so on. Such census reports tell much more. Therefore, find out what and why, and you have for yourself a treasure chest of stories.

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Stories in your newspaper

Many a stream has yielded gold nuggets after the first wave of miners have left. Newspapers sometimes play hit-and-run journalism. Always ask yourself, whenever you read a report in a newspaper, if the human interest angle has been reported adequately. When your newspaper is concentrating on the election winners, maybe you can get an interesting story by talking to the losers and their supporters. In addition, when the unemployment statistics are reported in your newspaper, remember that behind each of those numbers is a name of a person without a job and probably a family to support.

Advertisements and Yellow Pages

Advertisements especially classifieds, could be valuable sources of story ideas. Look through the Yellow Pages too. You may stumble on a good story idea.

Wire copy

Whenever you go through the stories from the wire services, do not forget to ask yourself if there are any stories that can be localised amongst them. When a wire service story for instance describes the increase in the rate of inflation, you should ask yourself how the people in your community would be affected. Always look for a local angle or slant.

Local Newspapers

Do not ever brush off local news tips. Your readers may be more interested in them than the so-called national news stories.

You

In the final analysis, you are the one who must be alert enough to look

and listen to what is going on around you. Always raise posers for yourself and attempt to answer them. Remember, reporters who are attuned to people rather than institutions will find the world around them a rich and fertile source of human interest. Do not tune out. Look and see!

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 2

As a resourceful reporter, discuss where you will look for story ideas in times of lull.

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3.3 Checking the Facts of a Story

A lot of places and information are available for the reporter who is very thorough in his job and desires to verify every fact that goes into his story before publication. Some of these avenues are found in the reference manuals maintained in most newsrooms or in newspaper libraries. Below is a list of some of the avenues and places available for the reporter to check, crosscheck or even triple-check his facts before going to press.

- **Local and Area Telephone Directories:** This could be used to verify the spelling of names and addresses, and so on. They are usually reliable, but they are not infallible.
- **City/Town Directories:** These provide the same information as the telephone directory but also provide information on the occupations of citizens and the owners or managers of businesses.
- **State Manuals/Brochures:** These sources provide information on various government agencies.
- **Maps of the City: County, State, Nation and World Local maps** are usually posted in the newsrooms. Others may be found in atlases.
- **Bartlett's Familiar Quotations:** This will help you not to quote anyone out of context or state a quotation as anonymous when it actually has an author.
- **National Assembly Records, Gazettes and Hansards:** These are where Government establishments and parastatals store its official information for retrieval and reference.
- **Facts on File (Facts on File Inc):** This is a weekly compilation of news from metropolitan newspapers.
- **Guinness Book of World Records:** Anybody who has done any notable thing and probably what no one has done before is

usually listed in Guinness Book of World Records.

- **Current Biography:** You no longer need to worry that you can find the date of birth of a notable personality or his middle name or even place of birth. Check current biographies.
- **Trade and Professional Journals and Newsletters:** This will obviously contain useful information on businesses and related matter.
- **Reader's Guide and Reader's Digest:** Any reporter who is not reading Reader's Guide or Reader's Digest is obviously missing out on an important information loaded book that could be useful to the modern reporter.
- **Webster's New World Dictionary of the American Language:** This is a good reference material for journalists.

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- **Who's Who (St Martin's, New York):** This source of facts shows who is who as published by St. Martin's.
- **Who's Who in America (Marquis):** This source also shows who is who in America.
- **World Almanac and Book of Facts:** A book where you may probably find any meaningful thing you are looking for.

These useful publications and others not mentioned here, enable reporters to verify data and so avoid unnecessary embarrassment caused by avoidable and recognisable errors.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE 3

Identify and discuss 10 useful places to verify facts as a reporter.

3.4 How to Handle Sources

Journalists and the profession rely heavily on dependable sources to succeed with the reportorial assignment. One of the trade secrets of any reporter/journalist is the contact with people who confide what is happening in their places of work and interest, whether in politics, business or society. As such, sources are as necessary as notebooks. Here are some suggestions on how to manipulate and/or manage sources.

Use Sources as Starting Points for Some Stories

Use sources as starting points for your story but not the end point. Always double and triple check with other public and private sources before going to press or on air. Do your research and you will find the supporting facts that corroborate your story or questions the credibility

and thus reliability of the facts you are about taking to the public sphere.

Maintain a Skeptical Attitude

Do not be reluctant to discard sources' tips if they cannot be substantiated. It is a healthy skeptical attitude that gets you out of trouble in the long run.

Be Careful with Confidential or Anonymous Sources

You must be careful with sources who give you information in confidence. The Off-the-record rule must be obeyed. In practice, you will sometimes have certain things only if you agree to go off the record and listen without quoting. If what the source said is true, you can verify it later from other sources or facts. Once you have promised to keep a

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source's comments confidential, do not break your promise. Be careful not to blunder into suggesting who your source is by some inadvertent reference that can be traced to your source. This could lead to dry up of sources for the industry.

Be Aware of Many Editors Attitude and Behaviour

The granting of secrecy to a source is an open invitation to exaggerate, embroider, embellish or slant. Some reporters have found ways to avoid using unnamed sources. One method is to read back the quote you want to use to diminish the source's anxieties and fears. A second technique is to take the time to discover documents that prove the source's allegation. If you can corroborate any information given to you of the record, you could go ahead and use such information without attributing it to your confidential sources.

3.5 Developing Your Sources

As you meet more people and learn from your community, you should continually update your records of contacts. They come in handy sometimes. Try to develop a bookkeeping method for keeping tracks of your contact. Developing sources differ from one journalist to another. Here are some tips on how to develop a source.

Keep a File Box of 3×5 Cards: Use one card for each source. Be sure to list the telephone numbers of both office and home or keep the same information in a small notebook you can carry with you or use both the file and the notebook. Sometimes it pays to leave your address and phone numbers with your source so that he can always call you up when something that is newsworthy turns up, since you as a journalist cannot be everywhere at the same time.

Always Review Your Card or Notebook from Time to Time: People are always moving. They are either changing jobs or location. You need to update your notebook from time to time or you will find out you just have a record of useless data.

Sometime you call your contacts just to say hello. Do not call them only when you want to use them.

If you can afford it, sometimes take your contacts to lunch, dinner, and so on. Know their kids and spouse's names, birthdays and anniversaries.

Build a healthy relation based on trust and confidence with sources. If they grow to trust you, they will not have problems talking to you when something important turns up.

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You can also reverse the process. Whenever any useful information comes to you, make it a habit to pass on such to your sources. When they get tips too, they will pass them on to you. It is a mutual thing.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Journalists have a common saying that a reporter can never be better than his or her sources. Reporters therefore spend quality time looking for and cultivating contacts that could become useful to them in the course of their assignment as reporters. Cultivating and developing sources becomes necessary for every reporter who wants to remain in the business.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit discussed the place of sources in the news gathering process. How to look for sources, cultivate them and grow them were the major highlights of this unit. It is expected that you now know much about sources and the news gathering process as an upcoming reporter.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss the news gathering procedure and mention five places to verify your facts before turning them out to your editor.
2. Will all your sources be reliable? How would you handle sources to ensure they do not get you into trouble?

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UNIT 4 JOURNALESE

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Newsroom Terminologies

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The media profession, like every other notable profession, has its language. This is sometimes referred to as jargons or technical terms associated with the profession. For the media industry, the technical language is called Journalese. Journalese is the language of the art of journalism. This will be the preoccupation of this unit. However, attention will only be paid to those terminologies associated with the newsroom where reporters and writers usually domicile.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- list and explain the technical words, phrases and terms commonly used in the newsroom by reporters, writers and their editors.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Newsroom Terminologies

Most of the definitions provided in this section were compiled from the Press Association, Reporters' Companion, Mencher (2010), online searches and media related dictionaries.

- **Add:** Additional news matter to a story already written or is about to be written.
- **Assignment:** This is an order to a reporter to cover an event. Assignment is the day's job given to a reporter to cover by his or her news editor or direct boss.
- **Attribution:** This means the identification of the person being quoted in the reporter's story. You only attribute a story to a source if he or she gives such information on record.

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- **Actuality:** This is an on-the-scene report in broadcasting.
- **Airtime:** The time at which a programme is broadcast.
- **Audio:** Sound
- **Background:** Information that may be used by a writer entirely on his own responsibility and cannot be attributed even to a "reliable source". The reporter can only use information given on background on his or her own risk.
- **Banner:** These are headlines written across or near the top of most newspaper page. It is also called a Streamer or Streaming headline.
- **Beat:** This is the area assigned to a reporter for regular coverage. A beat could be a place or a subject. For instance, State House Correspondent has the State House as his/her beat while Energy Correspondent has issues related to energy as his or her beat. In the US, beat could also be regarded as an exclusive story.
- **Break:** This is when a news development becomes known and available.
- **Beeper:** A telephone conversation or interview recorded for later playback on air.
- **Body type:** The type in which most of the newspaper is set, usually 8- or 9-point type.
- **Bulletin:** News of the day as presented in each of the media organisations.

- **By line:** This refers to the name of the author of a story or the name of the reporter who wrote a particular story.
- **Bulldog:** This is an early edition, usually the first of a newspaper's edition for the day.
- **Caps:** This refers to capital letters or uppercase letters.
- **Caption:** This is synonymous with cutline. It is the explanatory lines above or below a newspaper photograph, illustration or diagram.
- **Column:** This refers to the vertical division of the news page which is usually divided into about five or more columns. It could also be regarded as a signed article of opinion or strong personal expression by an expert.
- **Copy:** This refers to the news story or report.
- **Copy Flow:** This refers to the flow of a news story from the reporter to the news desk and to the editor who makes the final decision as to use the story or not.
- **CAR:** This is an acronym for Computer Assisted Reporting- the use of online databases and other related resources for the of a news story. Some refer to it as Database Journalism while others call it Precision Journalism.

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- **Crony Journalism:** This kind of reporting and coverage ignores or treats lightly negative news of about friends and acquaintances.
- **Continuity:** This refers to all radio and television scripts besides commercials
- **Cue (Noun):** This is a signal to an announcer, a newscaster or production personnel to participate in a broadcast.
- **Cub:** This term is used to describe a beginning reporter.
- **Cutaway:** This refers to the transition shot from them to another. It is used to avoid jamb cut.
- **Deadline:** This refers to the time in which a reporter, editor or desk must have completed scheduled work for the day.
- **Dateline:** This refers to the name of the city or town and date, which are placed at the beginning of stories not of local origin.
- **Credit line:** This is line designates, if necessary, the source of a story or cut "By NAN-News Agency of Nigeria".
- **Dry:** This refers to a period lacking in news. It is also called a lull period.
- **Dolly:** This refers to a camera platform.

- Dub: This refers to the transfer of one videotape to another.
- Exclusive: This refers to a story that is printed solely by one newspaper or an individual. This could also be called a “scoop”.
- Edition: This refers to one version of a newspaper per day.
- Editorial material: This means all materials in the newspaper that is advertising related.
- Enterprise copy: This is a story often covered by a reporter. It is like a news story but digs deeper than the usual news story.
- Establishing shot: This is a wide shot used to give the viewer a sense of the scene of action.
- Fade: This refers to either physical or mechanical lowering of a voice or music to smooth a transition between sounds.
- File: To send a story to office usually by wire or telephone or to put news services on the wire.
- Filler: This refers to minor news materials used to fill up spaces in the newspaper. It is also called column closers and shorts.
- Flag: This is the printed title of a newspaper on page 1. It is also called logotype or nameplate.
- Folio: This is a story that follows up a particular theme in a news story format.
- FM: This refers to Frequency Modulation.
- Freelance: This refers to an unattached writer, reporter, photojournalist or columnist who writes for a media organisation for a fee.
- Graf: This is an abbreviation for paragraph.

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- Handout: This is the term for written publicity or special interest news sent to a newspaper firm.
- HFR: This abbreviation stands for “Hold for Release” material that cannot be used until it is released by the source or at a designated time. It is also used to tag a story as “embargoed”.
- Jump: This means continuation of a story from page one to another page.
- Kill: This refers to elimination of a news story or refusal to use it because it is not news worthy. This also means to spike a story.
- Log: This refers to schedule of broadcasting.
- LTK: This abbreviation stands for “lead to come” usually placed after the slug. This means the lead will be supplied later.
- Make up: This is also called layout or design. This is the arrangement of body type, headlines, and illustrations into pages.

- **Masthead:** This refers to the heading on the editorial page that gives information about the newspaper. This is sometimes confused with Flag or Nameplate.
- **Must:** This is the designation placed on a copy to indicate that it must be run or published.
- **More:** This is the designation used at the end of a page of copy to indicate there are one or more additional pages.
- **Morgue:** This refers to the newspaper library, where published stories, photographs and resource materials are stored for reference purposes.
- **Mix:** Combining two or more sound elements into one.
- **Montage:** This refers to a series of brief shots of various subjects to give a single impression or communicate one idea.
- **News hole:** This refers to a space in a newspaper allotted to news, illustrations and other nonadvertising material.
- **O/C:** This stands for "On camera." It is used to describe a reporter delivering copy directly to the camera without covering pictures.
- **Outtakes:** These scenes are discarded for the final story.
- **Op-ed page:** Abbreviation for the page opposite the editorial page.
- **Precede:** A story written prior to an event. It could also be referred to as the section of a story preceding the lead.
- **Put to bed:** Closing the forms of an edition.
- **Rewrite:** To write a story a second time to make it better or to condense it.
- **Sacred cow:** Slang for a subject or story in which the publishers or editors are interested and which must be printed.
- **Scoop:** See exclusive.
- **Slug:** The word or words placed on a copy to designate the story. This is usually placed in the top left hand corner of the page.

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- **Stringer:** A correspondent, not a regular staff member of the media organization, who is usually paid per story. Could also be regarded as a freelancer.
- **Stet:** Let it stand, restore.
- **SOF:** "Sound on Film recorded" simultaneously with the picture.
- **SOT:** "Sound on Tape" recorded simultaneously with picture on tape.
- **Split page:** Front page of an inside section. Also known as the break page, second front page.

- Text: Verbatim report of a speech or public statement.
- Tip: Information passed to a reporter, often in confidence.
- Trim: To reduce a news story carefully.
- Update: This is a story that brings the reader up-to-date on a situation already in the news.
- V/O: Reporter's voice over pictures. Also called "voice over."
- VTR: Videotape recording.
- Wire services: This is a synonym for press agencies or news agencies. Media organisations usually subscribe to these agencies for news stories, and so on.

4.0 CONCLUSION

It is important for every reporter to familiarise his or herself with the above newsroom terminologies in order to remain connected to fellow reporters in and out of the newsroom. Proper understanding by all makes communications very easy.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit dealt with terminologies commonly used in the newsrooms across the globe. It is expected that you can now identify 80 of these and explain them.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify 20 core newsroom terminologies and explain their meaning.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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COURSE TITLE: INTRODUCTION TO FILM, CINEMA AND LITERATURE

COURSE CODE: MCM 108

LECTURE ON: ANIMATION AND TYPES OF ANIMATION

Animation refers to the art and technique of creating the illusion of movement by displaying a sequence of still images (frames) which include drawings, digital images, or photographs in rapid sessions. Animation is a vital part of modern visual communication. When these images are shown at certain speed (typically 12-24 frames per second), the human eye perceives them as continuous movement due to a phenomenon known as persistence of vision. Animation blends creativity and technology to produce moving images that inform, entertain, persuade, and simulate experiences. It is widely used in film, television, advertising, gaming, education and digital media. Animation has grown into a global industry influencing entertainment, education, advertising, science, and digital media. Film animation has to do with the following:

- Frame: A single still image within an animation sequence.
- Frame Rate (FPS): Number of frames shown per second. (e.g., 24 fps for film)
- Persistence of Vision: A phenomenon where the human eye retains an image for a fraction of a second, creating the illusion of movement.
- Motion Graphics: Graphic design in motion, often used for advertising and digital media.
- Rendering: Finalizing images from animation software into a finished output.

HISTORY OF ANIMATION

Animation evolved through several technological and artistic stages which include the Pre-Cinematic Devices (Early 1800s – Late 1800s), before it is called film as we know it, inventors explored optical illusion toys as inventors like Thaumatrope (1825) this has to do with a card with images on both sides appearing as one when spun, also Phenakistoscope (1832) which is a spinning disc showing animation when viewed in a mirror. There is the Zoetrope (1834) it entails a spinning cylinder with slits revealing moving drawings, Praxinoscope (1877) uses mirrors to produce clearer animation it is an upgraded zoetrope. Also, there is the Émile Reynaud's Théâtre Optique (1892) it projected animated films to audiences before cinema existed. So, all these devices laid the foundation for modern animation by experimenting with persistence of vision.

Early Film Animation (1900–1920) the major pioneers include the Émile Cohl (1908) who is considered one of the earliest true cartoons, also Winsor McCay he brought about artistic sophistication like the Little Nemo (1911), Gertie the Dinosaur (1914), The Sinking of the Lusitania (1918) which is the first animated documentary. Then there is J. Stuart Blackton, he is responsible for early stop-motion and chalkboard animations. The Characteristics of this period is that the period is mostly experimental, labor-intensive hand-drawn animation and no synchronized sound. The Silent Era and Commercialization (1920–1928) this is when animation becomes a commercial industry, introduction of the cel animation technique by Earl Hurd and J.R. Bray and also the creation of iconic characters like Felix the Cat. After this comes the Studios emerging with the Fleischer Studios, Bray Productions, and early Disney.

Sound Era and Disney Revolution (1928–1940) started with Steamboat Willie (1928) Walt Disney's Steamboat Willie introduced synchronized sound, changing animation forever. Then comes the 1930s Innovations with full-color animation using Technicolor, better storytelling, character development, and music integration, Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs (1937) which

was the first feature-length cel-animated film, massive commercial success and led to more classics animations like Pinocchio, Fantasia, Bambi.

Golden Age of American Animation (1940–1960) the American studios dominated with iconic characters like Warner Bros, some of their film are Bugs Bunny, Daffy Duck, Looney Tunes, MGM e.g. Tom & Jerry, Fleischer Studios – Popeye, Betty Boop and UPA – Modern, graphic animation style, this era help improved humor, timing, and characterization, it is the rise of animation as mainstream entertainment and short films shown before cinema features.

Television and Limited Animation Era (1960–1980)

Television's rise created demand for cheaper animation. This era has the Limited Animation Techniques which are the fewer frames per second, repeated backgrounds and simplified character movements. The Key Productions include the Hanna-Barbera's The Flintstones, Scooby-Doo, Yogi Bear, the Japanese anime begins global influence with Astro Boy (1963). This era emphasized cost-saving but expanded animation to households worldwide.

Digital and Computer Animation Revolution (1980–2000)

Key Technological Advances are Computer graphics (CGI) integrated into film, 1982 Disney's Tron it is the early use of CGI and the 1989 when The Little Mermaid used digital coloring. Also, the Pixar Innovations Toy Story (1995) it was the first fully 3D computer-animated feature film, it introduced advanced rendering, shading, and storytelling techniques. Anime Boom Akira (1988) and Studio Ghibli films gained global recognition.

21st Century: 3D Dominance and Multimedia Expansion (2000–Present)

The Key Trends in this era include 3D animation becomes standard, rise of major film studios like Pixar, DreamWorks, Illumination, Sony Pictures Animation, heavy use of motion capture (e.g., Avatar) and integration with live-action films (CGI characters and environments). The Digital Platforms like YouTube, TikTok, and streaming services create new markets, independent animators thrive online and VR and AR expand immersive experiences.

The Contemporary Animation Styles

- Hyper-realistic CGI
- Stylized 3D (e.g., Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse)
- Hybrid 2D-3D aesthetics

Types of Animation

1. Traditional (Cel) Animation – Hand-drawn on transparent sheets.
2. Stop-Motion Animation – Uses clay figures, puppets, or objects.
3. 2D Computer Animation – Vector and raster-based digital animation.
4. 3D Computer Animation – Models built in 3D environments (Pixar style).
5. Rotoscoping – Tracing live-action footage to produce realistic movement.
6. Motion Capture (MoCap) – Capturing live human movement digitally.
7. Experimental Animation – Mixed media, abstraction, sand animation, etc.

S/N USES OF ANIMATION BENEFIT

1. Animation in Entertainment

- Feature films and shorts • Allows creation of impossible
- TV cartoons and series scenarios.
- Video games • Appeals to all age groups.
- Virtual reality simulations • Enhances storytelling through expressive visuals.
- Music videos
- Streaming content

2. Animation in Public Relations (PR)

- Creating awareness campaigns (public • Engaging and memorable. health, safety, environment)
- Conveying corporate messages with • Can simplify serious or complex clarity issues.
- Enhancing brand identity through • Appeals to diverse audiences. animated mascots and logos
- Producing educational outreach programs

3. Animation in Advertising

- TV and digital commercials • High visual appeal
- Animated product demonstrations • Cost-effective compared to live action
- Story-based brand campaigns
- Flexible in style and creativity
- Digital billboards and social media ads
- Helps create enduring brand mascots (e.g., Geico Gecko)

4. Animation in Research and Education

- Animations help explain: • Breaks down complex ideas.
- Biological and chemical processes • Visualizes invisible or microscopic concepts.
 - Engineering mechanisms
 - Enhances retention and
 - Astronomy and physics phenomena comprehension.
 - Historical recreations
 - Allows interactive learning.
 - Medical procedures and simulations

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MODULE 3 NEWS WRITING AND REPORTING FOR THE PRINT MEDIA

Unit 1 The Lead

Unit 2 The Story Structure/Components of the Story

Unit 3 Types of News Stories

Unit 4 The Qualities of Good News Story

Unit 5 Reporter's Checklist

UNIT 1 THE LEAD

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Function/Importance of the Lead

3.2 Hints on How to Write the Lead

3.3 Types of Leads

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The lead is the first paragraph of a news story and contains the 5Ws and H. In fact, the lead is the most important part of a news story because it contains the most important facts of such a news story. The lead also summarizes the facts of a news story and it must be attractive, interesting and readable. The lead could extend to the second paragraph of the story but under normal circumstances, it should not go into the third paragraph. This is not to say that one has not come across a story of three-paragraph lead in our dailies. What we are trying to emphasise here is that a reporter should not indulge in writing three-paragraph leads.

According to Mencher (2010), "The lead sentence usually contains one idea and follows the subject-verb-object sentence structure for clarity." This means the lead should begin with the subject, followed by an active verb and conclude with the object of the verb. This structure also makes the reporter to write simple and short sentences.

Some writers and editors also prefer to place word limit on leads.

Mencher (2010) says a lead should not exceed 35 words. Since most

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stories are written in the inverted pyramid form, the news reporter must master the lead. This will be our focus in this unit.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- define a lead
- identify the elements of a lead
- identify and explain the functions/features of a lead
- identify common lead types as well as give examples of each
- write a good lead.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Function/Importance of the Lead

1. The lead summarizes the news

It gives the reader the sense of the story to follow and takes him or her to the supporting facts or claims presented in the opening statements.

2. The lead answers the questions raised by the 5Ws and H

However, not all the answers provided by the 5Ws and H must be present in every lead to make it acceptable but no important one should be left out or omitted.

3. The lead must emphasize the news feature

The lead is expected to play up the most interesting or significant aspect of the story. The news feature must be played up in the lead.

4. The lead must furnish the reader with identification needed for clarity

Persons, places and events must be given identification to make the lead clear to the reader. These bits of information may be considered as parts of the answers to the WHO, WHERE and WHAT of an event.

5. The lead must also suggest or give the authority on which the news is written

This is called DOCUMENTATION. Documentation gives credence to the news story.

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6. The lead must attract readers to the story

As the window of the story, the lead must get the attention of the reader and sustain this till he or she gets into the story.

7. The Lead Should Suggest the Headline

From the lead, it becomes easy for the sub-editor or editor to cast the

headline for the story. The lead should help suggest this.

3.2 Hints on How to Write the Lead

1. Use the SVO (subject-verb-object) sentence structure.
2. Make use of simple and short sentences.
3. Discover the most important element of the story and play this up in your lead.
4. Decide on what lead feature to emphasize among the five Ws and H and make this part of the first sentence.
5. Use a single element if you find out that one element stands out clearly in the story.
6. Make your lead go straight to the point.
7. Always ensure that your main verb is in the active voice.

3.3 Types of Leads

There are several types of leads; however, Sonaike (1987) identifies nine thus.

1. Summary lead which comprises of a statement that answers the 5Ws and H of a news event
2. The effect's lead which focuses on the effect or consequences of an event
3. The contrast lead which portrays contrasts of news events
4. The direct address lead which directs its statement at the reader
5. The question lead which asks a questions and provides an answer as well
6. The cartridge lead which presents the gist of an even in the fewest words
7. The double feature lead which contains two separate ideas
8. The quote lead which starts with a quotation and
9. The shirt-tail lead which is a lead broken into two sentences expressing two related ideas.

We shall further explain some of these lead types that are relevant with examples.

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1. Summary Lead

The summary lead is often used with the inverted pyramid form because it seeks to summarize the story in a few lines and tells the reader what he needs to know by answering the 5Ws and H. The summary lead summarizes the whole story and gives details later. It is very brief and deals only with the key points of the story.

Example:

- The ultra-modern Ariaria International Market in Aba, Abia State, reputed to be the biggest in Africa, was razed by fire on Tuesday.

2. Figurative or Coloured Lead

This lead permits the extensive use of figures of speech or allows the use of words in the figurative sense rather than the literal sense. The power of a figurative lead is in its eye-catching effect.

Example:

- After a countdown of several weeks, the Governor has put a fire button and blasted the MD of the state-owned sugar company into the rank of redundancy.

3. Quotation Lead

A quotation lead usually consists of a striking statement that could make readers interested in the story. Because the quotation lead is easy to write, the general rule is to use it sparingly. It should be used only where the quote is quite significant, and in cases where it could add drama to the story. Whenever a quotation is used, the explanation of such quotation should be made in the next paragraph.

- “The implementation of the present law on abortion would continue to impede the control of abortion in the country”

This was contained in a call to the federal government by the Nigerian Medical Association (NMA) to legalize abortion.

4. Question Lead

The question lead raises a question and attempts to answer the question. A question lead is commonly used in explanatory or specialised writing. The question at times answers itself when it is rhetoric.

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Example:

- What is constructive comment and what is disloyalty to the state?

This is the question in many minds today following the dismissal of a state commissioner as a result of an alleged anti-government speech.

The function of the second paragraph as statement following the questions is to explain the question to the listeners, readers or viewers.

5. Bullet Lead

Bullet lead is nearest to the headline. It is a short sentence that carries

great impact. Example:

- Multibillionaire and business tycoon, Chief John Agoli was killed today in a car bomb blast outside his home.

6. Staccato Lead

This consists of short sentences, coming one after the other to create heightened effect. It is used to establish a mood best suited for the kind of news story.

Example:

- The disaster started with a building flash. Next, a shattering roar that led to a crumbling wall. Then breaking glass, and death.

7. Immediate-Identification Lead

In the immediate-identification lead, one of the most important facts of the story is the “WHO” element. Reporters often use this approach when someone important or someone whose name is widely recognised is making news. Example:

- Pop Singer Roy Kelly was hospitalized in good conditions with second-degree burns on his scalp last night after his hair caught fire when he was filming a commercial.

8. Delayed-Identification Lead

When a reporter uses this type of lead, usually it is because the person or persons involved have little name recognition among the readers.

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Example:

- Madison – A 39-year old carpenter was killed today in a two-car collision two blocks from his home.
- Dead is William Domonske of 205 W.Oak St. Injured in the accident and taken to Mercy Hospital were Mary Craig, 21, of 204 Maple Ave. and Rebecca Roets, 12, of 207 Maple Ave.

9. Multiple-Element Leads

In some stories, choosing one theme for the lead is too restrictive. In such cases the reporter can choose a multiple – element lead to work more information into the first paragraph. However, such a lead must be written within the confines of a clear, simple sentence(s). Example:

- PORTLAND – The city council Tuesday ordered three department heads fired, established an administrative review board and said it would begin to monitor the work habits of administrators.

10. Lead With Flair

Although the inverted pyramid is designed to tell readers the news first and fast, not all stories begin with the most important statement. When the news value you want to emphasise is novelty, often the lead is unusual.

Example:

- ROME, ITALY (AP) – The wedding guests included a drug suspect, the social coordinator was a narcotics agent, the justice of the peace was a police chief and 52 officers were party crashers.

For the unsuspecting bride and groom the ceremony Friday was truly unforgettable – a sting operation set up by state and local police that led to 30 arrests.

Please note you may come across other types of leads, depending on the author whose work you are reading. However, the summary lead is the most commonly used in this part of the world because of its tendency to summarize the 5Ws and H in the lead.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Why is a good lead important to a story?

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4.0 CONCLUSION

Good leads are essential to the overall value of a story. It is also important to the understanding of the major theme espoused in a story. Thus, writing a lead correctly becomes a primary skill every reporter must get. It is also important to conclude here that different authors may choose to give any suitable title or name to lead types. This is not the issue. A multiple element lead may be described as a summary lead in another context. This does not make the authors wrong or right. What is important to the editor is writing a good lead.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you were exposed to lead writing in the print media. The features, functions and types of leads were also discussed. It is expected that you can now write a good lead after studying this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Identify five leads of five lead stories in the Guardian newspaper and state the types of lead they are.
2. Identify and discuss two types of leads that will be suitable to the general interest newspaper.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 2 THE STORY STRUCTURE/COMPONENTS OF THE STORY

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 2.0 Main Content
- 3.1 The Inverted Pyramid Format
- 3.2 The Advantages/Importance of the IPF
- 3.3 The 5Ws and H
- 3.4 Components of the Story
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Story structure distinguishes news writing from other types of writing such as the essay, poetry, drama, novel, short story and so on. Whereas the author of these other forms of composition usually begin with minor incidental details and work to a climax near the end of their compositions, the news writer reverses this plan of organisation. He begins with the climax. In the first paragraph generally referred to as the lead or introduction, the news writer begins with the most important information or climax of the story. The second most important information comes second; the third most important information comes third and so on. This form of news writing is called the Inverted Pyramid Format.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- describe the news story format
- discuss the inverted pyramid format of writing
- identify and explain the 5Ws and H
- differentiate between news writing and other forms of writing
- identify and explain the components of the story.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Inverted Pyramid Format

The inverted pyramid format is a news story writing format used centuries ago; however, most modern newspapers still use the format because it is the most space-efficient story form known. It permits writers to deliver the most important information in a paragraph or two. This type of news writing format gives the most important information in the news first in form of a lead and goes on to develop the story in a descending order of importance. The inverted pyramid story has no conclusion, as many single incident news stories are presented in this form. The illustration below shows the format.

Lead – the most important information

Second most important information

Third most vital information

Supporting details

Inverted Pyramid Format

The purpose of this type of structure is to present the news quickly, clearly and readably, to help the reader easily understand the content of the story. Its basic logic grows out of the different ways in which readers

approach a news story. Some will be so interested in the subject that they will read every word the reporter writes, regardless of how it is written; others read only a few paragraphs; many will only read the headline and lead.

To provide all these readers with maximum benefit, the reporter arranges the fact in descending order of importance. The Inverted Pyramid form has a professional advantage over the conventional

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method of essay writing. When a news story is very long and needs cutting, the sub-editor can easily cut from the paragraphs, which contain the least important details.

3.2 The Advantages/Importance of the Inverted Pyramid Format

- a. It makes the reader get the gist quickly.
- b. It helps in headline writing.
- c. It facilitates reading.
- d. It satisfies the curiosity of the reader.
- e. It helps and facilitates page make up.
- f. It facilitates editing to suit the news hole.

3.3 The 5Ws and H

The first person associated with the 5Ws and H is Rudyard Kipling. "I keep six honest serving men, they taught me all I know and their names are What, Why, Where, When, Who, and How". The question these "men" raise is What happened, Why it happened, Where it happened, When it happened, Who was involved and How it happened. It may be that not all of these questions can or should be answered in connection with a story but it will be unfortunate and unprofessional for a reporter not to make attempt to find answers to these questions.

1. What happened?

From the analysis of news stories published in five notable newspapers in Nigeria, the "what" of the stories is the most common starting point. In answering the question "what happened", the answer forms the opening of the story.

Example:

- a. A total sum of N2.8 billion was pumped into the foreign exchange market in March this year alone by the Central Bank of Nigeria.

- b. A further explanation of the “what” follows:
- c. This represents an increase of 15% over the level of N2.4 billion recorded last year.

2. Who was involved?

The news of “who” as the opening element shows the prominence of the personality involved in the news story and it is from this angle that

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Harold Evan in his book, “News Writing”, defines news as “people.” When the “who” is not prominent, that is, when it has no attraction in itself and leads to no special destination in the society, it will rarely open the news story. In some cases, special “who” may justify emphasis even though identification does not become part of the lead.

Examples:

- a. President Olusegun Obasanjo has promised to improve the conditions of service of federal civil servants in the country in order to stem corrupt practices.

United States President George W. Bush has announced a donation of \$50m in support of the AIDS epidemic in Africa.

3. Where did it happen?

The location of a news story is important and of interest when the media considers their area of coverage or place of reporting.

Example:

- a. An Evangelist of the Christ Church of the Lord, Mr Aboidun Baruwa, was killed by a lion at the zoological garden of the University of Ibadan last Saturday.

4. When did it happen?

Time element is important in a news story, and in most cases, it is included in the lead. However, it often sounds odd to begin a news story with time. That is why “At noon last Saturday” cannot begin a story.

Example:

- a. President Goodluck Jonathan leaves Abuja Monday morning for Madrid, to begin a three-day state visit to Spain.

5. Why did it happen?

The “why” of a news story is the circumstances surrounding the event behind the story. In most cases, the “why” is always answered in the body of the news story, unless when the circumstances surrounding the “why” deserves more explanation.

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Example:

a. INEC cannot remove Ngige based on his expulsion from the PDP. This clarification was made yesterday by the INEC Chairman, Abel Guobadia, to refuse claims credited to him.

6. How did it happen?

The “how” of a story is closely related to the “why.” That is why the “how” and the “why” of the story is usually left for the second or third paragraph that form the body of the story. However, the “how” of a news story is mostly used to explain the process the event takes to become a news story.

Example:

a. Taiwanese police have rescued a wealthy businessman kidnapped and held for two weeks in the boot of a car while his captors demanded a ransom of 50 million Taiwan dollars.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Justify why you may like to begin your news stories with any of the 5Ws and H.

3.4 Components of the Story

(This section is completely based on the work of the renowned News Writing and Reporting author, Melvin Mencher, 2010).

The components of a story are what the story must contain to be accepted. Mencher (2010) identifies seven of such components thus:

a. Accuracy

All information provided in a story must be accurate and the facts must also be verifiable.

b. Attribution

The sources which provided the reporter with information he or she used in writing his/her story must be properly identified.

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c. Complete

A news story should contain the specifics that illustrate, prove and document the main point of the story.

d. Balanced and Fair

A news story should make sure all sides in a controversial issue are

presented.

e. Objective

The writer or reporter should never inject his or her own personal biases and prejudices into his or her story.

f. Brief and Focused

The good news story should get to the point as quickly as possible and should keep to the point.

g. Well-written

A good news story should be clear, direct, interesting and error-free.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Good journalism starts by having good reporters who thrive upholding the ABC of journalism - Accuracy, Brevity and Clarity. Sometimes, these values are seen as moral necessities for the practice of the profession and should be upheld by anyone who wishes to make a name in the industry. The eight components of a story discussed in this section are just expansions of the ABC of journalism.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you learnt the story structure where the inverted pyramid format, 5Ws and H were presented to you. You also studied the components of a story where seven of the most vital ones were also presented.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Differentiate between a news story structure and style with that of a normal essay in English Language.
2. Discuss why the components of a story are vital to a journalist's credibility.

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Education.

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UNIT 3 TYPES OF NEWS STORIES

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 The Straightforward News Story

3.1.1 Hard News

3.1.2 Soft News

3.1.3 Human Interest News

3.1.4 Expected News

3.1.5 Unexpected News

3.2 Investigative Stories

3.3 Interpretation Stories

3.4 In-Depth Stories

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

The challenge of news classification should not be seen as a simple one. This is because the characteristics of one type of story may be found to be some of the characteristics of another type. For instance, the difference between an in-depth story and an investigative story is purely a matter of degree of thoroughness. In broad terms, there are four major types of news stories:

- a. Straightforward news stories which include hard news, soft news and human interest news
- b. Investigative stories
- c. Interpretative stories
- d. In-depth News stories

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify and explain the different types of news stories
- list different types of news stories.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Straightforward News Story

This is the product of the usual routine reporting. Most of the stories published in our commercial newspapers are straightforward news stories. Such stories are never interpreted, editorialised or laden with reporter's biases and prejudices. They are stories objectively and anchored on facts. The reporter adds or subtracts nothing from the facts on which the story is based.

A straightforward news story may be short or long, but it can hardly be long enough to occupy three-quarters of a page or a whole page. As a rule, its lead must answer to the 5Ws and H and the story, as a whole must leave no questions unanswered. The story must be simple, accurate concise and understandable. As stated earlier, straightforward news story may be subdivided into hard news, soft news and human-interest news.

3.1.1 Hard News

Hard news stories are stories that deal with government, economic, social and political policies. They are stories with a lot of facts and figures. Stories concerning the annual budget, political and economic programmes are all hard news stories.

3.1.2 Soft News

These are stories about trends, fashion, entertainment personalities and lifestyles. The time element is not too emphasised in writing such news stories.

3.1.3 Human Interest News

These are stories valued more for their emotional impact or oddity. They usually arouse human feelings and conjure up sentiments and emotions in the persons who read them.

3.1.4 Expected News

Expected News is anticipated and therefore planned for. It usually flows from events that are scheduled in advance.

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3.1.5 Unexpected News

Unexpected news is not anticipated. It takes people unawares. Examples include murders, natural disasters, accidents, and so on.

3.2 Investigative Stories

These types of news hinges on the pursuit of information that has been

concealed. Investigative stories therefore require the digging out of facts. The investigative reporter is not expected to inject his own biased ideas or opinions into his story. He is not expected to editorialise or interpret the facts. Examples of investigate stories that made headlines are – “The Watergate Scandal,” “The Buharigate Scandal,” and “Enwerengate,” and so on.

3.3 Interpretative Stories

This is a form of story in which the reporter is free to interpret the news the way he or she sees it. S/he is allowed to inject his own biased but expert opinion, editorialize and pass comments on the fact being reported. Interpretative stories require additional facts, detailed explanations and logical analysis. Examples include personality profiles and feature articles.

3.4 In-Depth Stories

This is complete quality news reporting. In-depth story needs the full treatment and it needs backgrounding. It requires creative thinking and deep imagination on the part of the reporter and writer. Most newsmagazine stories are usually in-depth stories and there is little difference between an in-depth story and an investigative story.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss four types of news stories.

4.0 CONCLUSION

The challenge of classifying news is not a small one. However, reporters and writers alike should make efforts to understand the style demands of the different types and adhere strictly to such demands. It is unforgivable for a reporter to pass comments or twist facts in a straightforward news story.

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5.0 SUMMARY

This unit has exposed you to the different types of news stories and the demands of writing them. It is expected that you can now identify the different story types and attempt writing each one of them.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss the major differences between a straightforward news story and an in-depth story.
2. Discuss the major differences between hard news and soft news.

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UNIT 4 THE QUALITIES OF GOOD NEWS STORY

CONTENTS

- 1.0 Introduction
- 2.0 Objectives
- 3.0 Main Content
 - 3.1 The Qualities of Good News Story
 - 3.1.1 Accuracy
 - 3.1.2 Objectivity
 - 3.1.3 Balance/Fairness
 - 3.1.4 Currency
 - 3.1.5 Clarity
 - 3.1.6 Brevity
 - 3.1.7 Attribution
 - 3.1.8 Complete
- 4.0 Conclusion
- 5.0 Summary
- 6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment
- 7.0 References/Further Reading
- 1.0 INTRODUCTION

Editors generally feel that some new stories are good while some are not. This is because news stories must meet some certain criteria for them to be adjudged good. These criteria are referred to as the qualities of a good news story.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify and explain the qualities of a good news story.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 The Qualities of Good News Story

3.1.1 Accuracy

Accuracy is the pillar on which a news story rests. A news story can be regarded as accurate if all names, ages, addresses and direct quotations in the story are accurate and correct. Inaccuracy in news writing could lead to costly libel suits and a possible dismissal from your work. So, efforts must be made to ensure that the facts you used in writing any story are accurate to the best of your knowledge.

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3.1.2 Objectivity

This presupposes that the reporter presents the reader with all sides of an issue and all the facts involved in the issue. This nature of presentation allows the reader to decide what these facts mean and whose side he or she has sympathy for. For a news story to be objective, it must not be slanted or editorialised. There is no room here for the reporter to inject his or her opinion; no matter how specialised such opinion may be regarded.

The objective criterion has generated a lot of arguments because people believe it is difficult to be objective when writing a news story. They assert that the word objective is relative and so mean different things to different people. Subjectivity could be displayed either in choice of words or in the choice of facts.

3.1.3 Balance/Fairness

This entails treating all sides of a story equally without showing any form or evidence of bias and partiality. This could also be described as giving equal attention and prominence to the two sides of a story. In broadcasting, it is called the “Fairness Doctrine.” The views expressed by opponents on an issue must be given adequate coverage without any form of preferential treatment to any of the opposing views. Balancing up a news story is tasking indeed. Unless a reporter remains objective,

he or she will miss out this crucial requirement.

3.1.4 Currency

Yesterday's news is no longer news. It is stale and no longer meant for consumption. A momentary delay in getting a story across to consumers as soon as it breaks could make it stale. The reporter should therefore be current in his or her search for news. A news story must be something new that has just happened.

3.1.5 Clarity

News stories must be written in clear, simple and easily comprehensible language. To achieve this, a reporter is advised to use simple and unambiguous words; simple sentences that mean exactly what the writer intends them to mean, and good grammar and punctuation that will bring the actual meaning closest to comprehension.

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3.1.6 Brevity

For a news story to attract the attention of both the editor and the readers, it must be very brief, clear and simple. Most readers are in such a hurry to read an entire story in a newspaper. Therefore, it is advisable to tell the news in such a concise manner as to maintain the interest of the reader. This criterion gave rise to the adoption of the inverted pyramid form and the summary lead.

3.1.7 Attribution

This is all about identifying the sources that provided information in the course of writing the story. Attribution help place a quote in proper context and also validate the claims of the reporter. It improves the overall credibility of the story.

3.1.8 Complete

According to Mencher (2010), complete stories are written by reporters who anticipate and answer the questions their readers, viewers and listeners will ask. The complete story contains the specifics that illustrate, prove and document the main point of the story.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss five primary qualities you think a good news story should have.

4.0 CONCLUSION

In the newspaper business, there will continue to be rejection and acceptance of copies. This is majorly because not every copy submitted will find itself in the day's edition of the newspaper. To be accepted, a

story must have all the qualities discussed in this unit.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit dealt with the qualities of a news story. It is our expectation that you are now familiar with the reasons why some stories are rejected why others are not. The stories that lack some or most of the qualities discussed in this unit are most likely going to be rejected.

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6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Give three solid reasons why “attribution” is very vital to a story’s completeness.
2. Is “objectivity” a realistic quality for a news story? Support your position with relevant facts.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 5 REPORTER’S CHECKLIST

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objective

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Checklist before a Reporter Writes a Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Information is the key to good reporting. The reporter is expected to collect enough information and put it together to make meaning to the readers. Because facts are the ingredients used in writing a good story, a reporter must always have a checklist of this before the actual writing process begins.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify should be in a checklist before a reporter writes a story.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Checklist before a Reporter Writes a Story

The checklist before a reporter writes a story is based on the practical work and writing of Agbese (2008) as discussed below.

- a. Do I have all the information I need to write a complete story?

A reporter must make sure all the required information are in before the writing process begins proper. A good reporter usually asks himself or herself the questions his or her readers will ask and find answers to the questions.

- b. Have I covered all the angles, interviewed everyone concerned and verified all the information given to me by the various sources?

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An attempt to answer this question in the affirmative will definitely lead to a well-written and complete story. Any reporter who is in the habit of asking himself/herself this question and then making concerted efforts to find answers to it will end up an award-winning reporter.

- c. Have I answered all the questions posed by the 5Ws and H?

The 5Ws and H raise questions whose answers summarize all that a reader needs to know about an event. Every reporter should make

attempt to find answers to the questions they ask.

d. Am I clear in my mind what sort of story I want to write?

If the reporter has any doubts in his/her mind about the sort of story he/she intends to write, then something is wrong.

e. Do I fully understand the story I am about to write?

This follows from point 4 above. The reporter must fully understand the sort or type of story he/she is about to write by appreciating the nature of facts available and the possible consequences of the story's release.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss the checklist a reporter must take note of before writing his report.

4.0 CONCLUSION

This checklist is not exhaustive. There could be many more even some developed by reporters themselves to assist them in delivering quality. However, if the answers are provided to the questions asked in the checklist, then the reporter is ready to write the story.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this chapter, you learnt some of the items that must be available to you as a reporter before you write a story that could get you positive attention.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Discuss the question posed by the 5Ws and H and state why they are important to a story's completeness.

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7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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MODULE 4 NEWS WRITING AND REPORTING FOR THE BROADCAST MEDIA

Unit 1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

Unit 2 Style

Unit 3 Features/Structure of a Broadcast News Story

Unit 4 Writing a Broadcast Copy

UNIT 1 CRITERIA FOR SELECTING BROADCAST STORIES

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

3.1.1 Timeliness

3.1.2 Information and Explanation

3.1.3 Audio or Visual Impact

3.1.4 The facts

3.2 The Don'ts of a Broadcast Copy

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Broadcast news stories are written differently when compared to print news stories that we have been dealing with in our earlier units.

Broadcast stories are written to be easily understood. According to Mencher (2010:195), "to write effectively for radio you must unlearn the prose writer's rules about sentence structure. Disregard such forms as dependent clauses and balanced sentences. You can even forget the first grammatical rule you ever learned – that a sentence must have a subject and a verb. Some of radio's most effective sentences are not complete sentences at all. They are descriptive phrases. They save a lot of words and go over very smoothly on the air".

These make broadcast copies a little more technical than the usual prose copies. This unit shall therefore focus on the criteria for selecting broadcast copy and the things a broadcaster cannot do when preparing a broadcast copy.

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2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- explain the criteria for selecting broadcast stories

- explain the don'ts of a broadcast copy
- distinguish between writing for the print and the broadcast media.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Criteria for Selecting Broadcast Stories

There are many reasons why a broadcast news story may be rejected in the newsroom. Apart from the universally accepted standards, different broadcast stations have other unique parameters that their reporters must follow in writing for the station. However, the following could be regarded as some of the criteria that are generally applied in selecting broadcast news stories.

3.1.1 Timeliness

Timeliness as a news value is more important to the broadcast news writer than to the print reporter and writer. Print journalists tend to work on daily cycles but broadcast journalist work on hourly or less cycles. Generally, a news broadcaster has to “go to press” many times a day, particularly if he is working on radio. The news must be up to the minute. News that is more than an hour old may be too stale for broadcast selection (Aworo, 2005 in Folarin et al). So, timeliness is a core criterion in selecting broadcast copies.

3.1.2 Information, not Explanation

Broadcast news writers always look for selection stories that do not need a lot of explanations in order for listeners or viewers to understand them easily. They prefer stories that are relatively simple and can be told in a simple and straightforward manner. The suggested maximum length for most TV newscast is about 2 minutes; the normal length should be about 20 to 30 seconds (Aworo, 2005 in Folarin et al). What is important to the broadcaster is giving information not explaining in details what happened. In essence, the broadcast news story concentrates on the WHAT and WHERE and delves less into the WHY and HOW of events because of the airtime allocated to the story (Obe, 2005). Every broadcast news writer must have this understanding if he or she intends to write acceptable copies.

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3.1.3 Audio or Visual Impact

Broadcast news editors will always select stories that the audience can hear or see. As a broadcast news writer, always write for the ear or eye if you want your copy selected all the time. This is because news events that have good visual appeals to the audience are usually hot cake. Some

broadcast news events are selected because they have both visual and audio effects that the public want.

3.1.4 The Facts

In the course of an assignment, many facts will be thrown up at the reporter. It is his or her duty to organise these facts into some sort of order. Do not forget that broadcast reports do not require do much detail; it becomes important that the reporter must organise the facts in such a way that the important details are not lost. The best practical way to go about this is to fully understand the facts you want to base your story on before you begin the writing process. Afterwards, you could write from your memory and only use the facts to crosscheck. This technique when expertly used results in concise, clear copy.

Other Criteria

A broadcast story that must be accepted according to Mencher (2010) should use everyday language, written in short sentences, limit every sentence to one idea, use the present tense whenever appropriate and usually the story should confine itself to one overriding theme.

3.2 The Don'ts of a Broadcast Copy

- a. Do not scare listeners
- b. Do not give orders
- c. Do not start a story with:
 - "As expected"
 - "In a surprise move"
 - "A new development today"
 - "Our top story tonight is"
 - "There is" or "It is"
 - A participial phrase
 - A personal pronoun
 - A question
 - A quotation
 - An unknown or unfamiliar name
 - Someone's "making news" or "making history"

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- "Another", "more" or "once again".
- d. Do not characterise news as good or bad
- e. Do not use any form of "to be" as the main verb in your lead
- f. Do not bury the verb in a noun
- g. Do not use "yesterday" or "continues" in your first sentence

- h. Do not use “no”, “not” and negatives in your first sentence
- i. Do not use newspaper style, language or rituals
- j. Do not cram too much information into a story
- k. Do not lose or mislead a listener
- l. Do not make a factual error

Adapted from Mencher, Melvin (2010). *Mencher’s News Writing and Reporting* (11th ed.). Boston: McGraw-Hill Higher Education.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Explain 10 don’ts of a broadcast news copy.

4.0 CONCLUSION

From our discussion so far, it is obvious that broadcast news serves a purpose different from the print output. It is basically intended to provide the audience with information without necessarily bugging them down with so many details. How to go about doing this correctly is the focus of the unit which concentrated on the criteria for selecting a broadcast story.

5.0 SUMMARY

This unit focused on the criteria for selecting a broadcast copy and the things a broadcast news reporter is not expected to do in the course of preparing and writing a broadcast news story.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Justify with four valid reasons why a broadcast copy is more interested in giving out information and not details.
2. How will you use facts in writing a typical broadcast story?

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UNIT 2 STYLE

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

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3.1.1 Personal Style

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3.2 Broadcast Style

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

Every media organisation of worth has a style guide, which helps the journalists in that organisation know how to present their copy in an acceptable manner. This is because writing, whether for print or broadcast, runs on style. Style distinguishes, say a print copy from a broadcast copy. The major difference between a broadcast copy and advertising copy is style. The way Public Relations' copies are written is different from the way advert copy is written. Again, the difference manifests as style. Style is everything that makes a copy from a

particular type of medium different from the others. Therefore, reporters are expected to conform to the style guide in writing and presenting their copy.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end this unit, you should be able to:

- describe what style is all about
- identify the unique broadcast style of writing stories
- apply broadcast style in writing and presenting your own broadcast stories.

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3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Style

Ekwelie (1992:56) notes that every aspiring writer must contend with three basic styles thus:

- a. His own emerging style which will make his writing distinct.
- b. The style of his times with regard to sentence construction, diction as well as syntax.
- c. The style of his or her medium, which is a hybrid between normal and the idiosyncratic use of language.

These are further explained below.

3.1.1 Personal Style

Personal style is usually identified with individual writers. It is a style most established authors are known for. Chinua Achebe, for instance, has his style of writing as reflected in his novels. The same is applicable to the Nobel Laureate, Professor Wole Soyinka, who is known to write for a particular audience. This comes in their choice of words, phrases etc and the way and manner such words, phrases etc are presented in their works. Wole Soyinka's "The Lion and the Jewel" is written in a different linguistic style from "The Man Died". Journalists should strive to apply personal style in whatever they do. It makes you unique. Personal style does not have to flagrantly abuse the house or media style of a particular media organisation. House style takes precedence but a journalist may decide to apply such a House style in a very unique and personal way.

3.1.2 Era or Period Style

This is the prevailing style of a particular period in history. The style of the Shakespearean Age and the Modern American Literature are totally different. Language changes with history and time. For instance, during

the colonial days in Africa, the rhetoric of politicians and the so-called statesmen were largely nationalistic. Today, the language has changed. Such rousing patriotic speeches then may not impress anyone again especially in the midst of abundance and paradoxical lack caused largely by a very corrupt and inhuman political class who are basically amassing wealth at the instance of the hungry masses.

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3.1.3 Media Style and Mechanics

As we noted in the introductory part of the unit, every media organisation has its style, usually called House Style or Style Guide. A House Style is a journalistic code book, detailing how everything that pertains to writing should be handled. The House Style differs from media house to media house; from the print media to the broadcast media etc. However, notwithstanding the differences manifested in styles in the different media organisations, the standards and mechanics of writing remain universal. Each House Style stems from standard language usage but sometimes bows to stylistic idiosyncrasies. Bad mechanical style is a bane to good writing. Ume-Nwagbo cited in Aworo (2005) noted for example that the English Treason Act of 1351 came under strict scrutiny during the trial of the Irish nationalist Roger David Casement in 1916, over the way the wording, originally in Norman French, was or was not punctuated. That case was one instance in which the absence of comma would have saved the neck of accused for high treason.

It is no longer news that poor punctuation gets in the way of good writing. Written language is a very demanding assignment and must be treated as such. This is corroborated by Francis Bacon, the father of English essays, when he noted that “words are like leaves. Where they most abound we cannot find the fruit of the truth beneath”. This is a serious warning against verbiage or simply verbosity. A writer therefore must follow the medium’s style guide on punctuation, spelling, capitalization, diction, syntax, and taste.

3.1.4 Broadcast Style

Broadcast news writers make use of the conversational style or what we refer to as “language style.” According to Mencher (2010), broadcast news serves a purpose different from that of the print. Its primary intent is to provide the public with basic information quickly and clearly. The broadcast writer is much more interested in getting the story idea across without the details. This is the major reason the broadcast style is unique

and rigid. The broadcast journalist examines every word and idea before use. This is because too many words may squeeze another item in the story and too many ideas and the listener or viewer may become confused.

A typical broadcast style of writing will contain the following guidelines:

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1. Use short sentences and words the announcer can pronounce without gasping for breath.
2. Do not attempt to tell too much in your opening statement. The radio listener requires a little time to adjust after each story.
3. Never lead into a story with a question. There is a little line between such leads and commercials.
4. Avoid hanging and dangling phrases since they break up the flow of thought.
5. Attribution should precede assertion where and when a story must be attributed. Also, attribution should come at the beginning of a sentence where necessary.
6. Be conversational. This means you should write the way you talk.
7. Do not start a story with a participial phrase.
8. Use ordinary, one-syllable words whenever possible.
9. Use vigorous verbs. This means you should as much as possible avoid adjectives and adverbs.
10. The active voice is always preferable than the passive voice. Use it.
11. Use familiar words in familiar combinations.
12. Write simply and in a direct manner. Always avoid the use of unnecessary words.
13. Write in language that could be read easily.
14. Use a phrase to indicate someone is being quoted.
15. Place titles before names and they should be used for proper identification of people and nothing more.
16. Where appropriate and accurate, use the present tense or the present perfect tense.
17. Numbers must be written to be read aloud. The best way is to write out numbers from one to 10 and then to use figures for numbers up through 999.
18. Round off figures especially the ones dealing with budgets, money matters, and so on.
19. Avoid the use of tongue-twisting words.

20. Avoid abbreviations unless they are standard abbreviations that could easily be understood by all.
21. Avoid the use of symbols or sketches.
22. Do not hyphenate words.
23. Avoid unnecessary use of quotations and reduce the use of punctuation marks too.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Discuss 15 things you must not do when writing a broadcast copy.

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4.0 CONCLUSION

The broadcast writer must be simple and direct. He or she must always bear in mind that he/she is writing for the ear and the eye. Make sentences simple, short and easy to understand. Do not attempt to cram too many information and facts in your story and remember your listeners and viewers are basically in a hurry. Do not keep them waiting and guessing.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt the meaning of style and the implication in broadcast news writing. You have also learnt the broadcast style and how to apply the knowledge in writing and acceptable broadcast copy.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Define style in broadcasting.
2. Why is it necessary to have style guides in broadcast media houses?

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UNIT 3 FEATURES/STRUCTURE OF A BROADCAST

NEWS STORY

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objectives

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Structure of a Broadcast News Story

3.1.1 News Highlights

3.1.2 Lead

3.1.3 Correspondents' Reports and Inserts

3.1.4 Lead-in and Lead-out

3.1.5 Wrap Around

3.2 Features of a Broadcast News Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Broadcast news writing is unique and designed to suit the mechanics of the profession. The writing also requires a higher order of skill than

those required for writing for newspapers and newsmagazines.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- identify the basic structure of broadcast news stories
- identify the features of a broadcast news story
- list and discuss the characteristics of broadcast news writing which differentiate it from other forms of writing.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Structure of a Broadcast News Story

News broadcasts have identifiable features and sections with special significance. It is usual for news broadcasts to begin with a time check, station identification, greeting and the name of the newscaster (s). However, different broadcast stations have individual styles, which do not differ significantly from what is presented below.

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3.1.1 News Highlights

This comes up at the beginning of the programmes and gives listeners an idea or run-down of the major stories contained in the day's programme in a descending order of importance. News highlights are also referred to as top stories of the day. They should be brief, punchy, interesting, attracting and written in the present tense. They also serve to arrest listener attention and get the listener to sit down for the real gist.

Examples as adapted from Kombol (2005) include the following.

- a. National Economic Council meets over current power sector reforms.
- b. A bill to enforce the use of seat belts by motorists is being considered by the Senate.
- c. Sokoto House of Assembly grants Governor Degoye Kpongo a leave of absence of 120 days.
- d. Federal Government designates Bar Beach Towers Lagos as military barracks

3.1.2 Lead

The broadcast lead opens news stories. In writing the broadcast lead, immediacy is the key. Listeners and viewers must be made to understand that the news is current and the events are happening now. Because of this, broadcast leads are always written in the present tense. The broadcast lead should not attempt to answer the 5Ws and H like its print counterpart. Only the most important of all of these should be

featured in the broadcast lead.

Example:

- a. The First Lady of Lagos State, Mrs. Kemi Fashola, says maternal mortality is on the rise in the state.
- b. Two types of broadcast lead are commonly used in most broadcast stations. The first is the shot-gun lead, which identifies a single development in the story and the second is the umbrella lead, which is also called summary lead because of its tendency to highlights a series of developments in the story.

3.1.3 Correspondents' Reports and Inserts

Correspondents' reports add credibility to the broadcast news report as the various media audiences are made to see that the media organization in question was actually at the scene of the event and had reporters on ground to monitor the situation and report direct from the scene.

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Through correspondents' reports and inserts, listeners and viewers are brought to the scene of the event. This also helps to add detail to the report.

Example:

- a. The National Assembly says all governments parastatals will be offered for sale. The spokesperson for the Assembly Kalu Ngor stated this at
- b. Correspondent Jimoh Ibrahim completes the story.

3.1.4 Lead-in and Lead-out

The lead-in is used to prepare the minds of listeners for correspondents' reports and inserts. It is regarded as a transition device that transports the listeners from the story into the correspondents' reports that has more detail.

On the other hand, the lead-out takes the listeners from the scene of the event back to the studio where the story is expected to be wrapped up. Lawrence (1983) cited in Kombol (2005) notes that while the lead-in prepares the audience for the video or audio report, the lead-out re-identifies the voice in the actuality or video segment.

Examples:

- a., State House Correspondent Yemi Adenuga now completes the report. (Lead-in).
- b., from Lagos, Amaka Igwe now reports (Lead-in).
- c. that was Yemi Adenuga from the State House (Lead-out).

d.Amaka Igwe from Lagos (Lead-out).

3.1.5 Wrap Around

Wrap around is simply a sign out by correspondents to indicate that they are through with their correspondents' reports. Upcoming reporters should note that it is proper for the correspondent to say his or her name and the name of the station before signing off on the reports.

Example:

- a. From Lagos, Amaka Igwe reporting for Channels Television.
- b. Amaka Igwe, Channels Television.

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3.2 Features of a Broadcast News Story

Features or characteristics of a broadcast news story have a lot to do with the style of broadcast media organisations. Since style has been dealt with in the preceding unit, we will for the sake of emphasis reiterate some of the basic features of a broadcast news story thus:

1. Broadcast copy is written in the way people speak. So, it is conversational.

Example:

- a. The lead defence counsel in an advanced fee fraud trial, Mr. Olisa Agbakoba, is threatening to file a motion for mistrial unless some documents are furnished by the prosecution.

2. Sentences in broadcast news stories are usually short. Brevity in sentence construction is the key word here. Apart from being short, the sentences should also be simple in nature. Complex sentence structures confuse listeners.

Example:

- a. Complex sentence:

Following the decision of the International Court of Justice at The Hague, the Netherlands, over the sovereignty of Bakassi Peninsula, the Cross River State Government has been barred from exercising any control or power over the communities in its estuary.

- b. Shorter sentences (Acceptable for broadcast news story):

The Cross River State Government has been barred from exercising any control over the communities in the Bakassi region.

This follows the decision of the International Court of Justice at The Hague, the Netherlands, over the sovereignty of Bakassi Peninsula.

3. Independent clauses should be avoided in broadcast news writing

because they often delay the main theme of the story.

Example:

- a. POOR: Having identified the problems inherent in corruption, the Chancellor of Covenant University has condemned corruption in its totality.
- b. BETTER: The Chancellor of Covenant University has condemned corruption due to its inherent problems.

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4. The sentence structure for broadcast news stories remains the Subject-Verb-Object type of writing sentences even for print media organizations.

5. Broadcast news stories are written in the active voice. The active voice is rigorous and lively, while the passive voice is dull.

Example:

- a. Active voice: The lawyer took his wife home
 - b. Passive voice: His wife was taken home by the lawyer
6. Use the present tense which gives a sense of immediacy and currency.

Example:

- a. WEAK: The Vice-Chancellor said Monday she will remove her deputy over the allegation.
- b. STRONG: The Vice-Chancellor says she will remove the deputy over the allegation.

7. Always use words that convey currency like “Today”, “This morning”, “Earlier today”, “Monday morning”, and so on.

8. Use contractions where appropriate. It is part of everyday speech because people tend to cut words short to say more in less time. Contractions obviously make broadcast news writing more conversational. However, where they will mislead the listener or be totally misunderstood, they must be avoided. The broadcast news writer should also know that negative contractions are avoided in broadcast news writing (Kombol, 2005).

Example:

- a. POOR: The Vice-Chancellor says she won’t apologize for the many rules in Covenant University.
 - b. GOOD: The Vice-Chancellor says she will not apologize for the many rules in Covenant University.
9. Homonyms are certain words that sound alike and it very easy to

mistake one for another. Broadcast writers should guard against such mistakes. Proper use and in the right context is advised.

10. Punctuation, quotations, use of numbers, abbreviations and acronyms are usually subject to House Styles and Guides. This has been dealt with in the unit on Style. Please, go back to that unit if in doubt.

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11. Finally, it is expected that a typical broadcast copy should have the following basic rules.

- a. All copy should be typed.
- b. All copies should be doubled-spaced.
- c. One story should be limited to a page.
- d. Words that are difficult to pronounce or require some special emphasis should be underlined.
- e. A single word should not be split between pages.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Justify the application of the first three rules discussed under the features of broadcast news story.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Broadcast news writing is guided by many rules as could be seen from this unit and the other preceding units. To have a full grasp of these rules and apply them without stress, it is advisable that upcoming broadcast news writers should constantly practice these rules. By so doing, they will become familiar with their use and application.

5.0 SUMMARY

In this unit, you have learnt about the structure and standard features of broadcast news writing. It is expected that you are now familiar with such structural features and is able to apply them in your writing.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

Identify and discuss the structure of a broadcast news story.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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UNIT 4 WRITING A BROADCAST COPY

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

2.0 Objective

3.0 Main Content

3.1 Steps to Writing News for the Broadcast Media

3.1.1 Start with a Broadcast Lead

3.1.2 Introduce Lead-ins and Lead-outs

3.1.3 Remember to Wrap Up

3.1.4 Remember to Relate Words to Pictures

3.1.5 Avoid Clichés

3.2 Writing a Broadcast News Story

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 Summary

6.0 Tutor-Marked Assignment

7.0 References/Further Reading

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Writing a broadcast news story or copy to be read by a newscaster is different from writing it for a newspaper. Broadcast copies are written in a way that it would be easy for newscasters to read. The primary goal of the broadcast news story is to make the copy easy for the newscaster to read as well as easy for the audience to understand.

2.0 OBJECTIVE

At the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- write a typical radio and television news story or copy.

3.0 MAIN CONTENT

3.1 Steps to Writing News for the Broadcast Media

3.1.1 Start with a Broadcast Lead

The broadcast lead opens news stories. In writing the broadcast lead, immediacy is the key. Listeners and viewers must be made to understand that the news is current and the events are happening now. Because of this, broadcast leads are always written in the present tense. The broadcast lead should not attempt to answer the 5Ws and H like its print counterpart. Only the most important of all of these should be featured in the broadcast lead.

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Example:

- a. The First Lady of Lagos State, Mrs. Kemi Fashola, says maternal mortality is on the rise in the state.
- b. Two types of broadcast lead are commonly used in most broadcast stations. The first is the shot-gun lead which identifies a single development in the story and the second is the umbrella lead which is also called summary lead because of its tendency to highlight a series of developments in the story.

3.1.2 Introduce Lead-ins and Lead-outs

The lead-in is used to prepare the minds of listeners for correspondents' reports and inserts. It is regarded as a transition device that transports the listeners from the story into the correspondents' reports that has more detail.

On the other hand, the lead-out takes the listeners from the scene of the event back to the studio where the story is expected to be wrapped up. Lawrence (1983) cited in Kombol (2005) notes that while the lead-in prepares the audience for the video or audio report, the lead-out re-identifies the voice in the actuality or video segment.

Examples:

- a., State House Correspondent Yemi Adenuga now completes the report (Lead-in)
- b., from Lagos, Amaka Igwe now reports (Lead-in)
- c. that was Yemi Adenuga from the State House (Lead-out)

d.Amaka Igwe from Lagos (Lead-out).

3.1.3 Remember to Wrap Up

Wrap-up is simply a sign out by correspondents to indicate that they are through with their correspondents' reports. Upcoming reporters should note that it is proper for the correspondent to say his or her name and the name of the station before signing off on the reports.

Example:

- a. From Lagos, Amaka Igwe reporting for Channels Television.
- b. Amaka Igwe, Channels Television.

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3.1.4 Remember to Relate Words to Pictures

This aspect is applicable to visuals only. While relaying a videotaped report, it is important that the words must tally with the pictures. This requires good editing to ensure words and pictures are complementary.

3.1.5 Avoid Clichés (This section is adapted from Oloruntola Sunday's "News Reporting and Writing")

Eric Partridge, in his Dictionary of Clichés, defines a cliché as a phrase so hackneyed as to be knock-kneed and spavined. They not only fail to enliven dull copy, clichés make even the most significant item sound trite. Hyperboles and clichés are for hacks.

Examples of clichés that should not appear in broadcast news stories are given below.

- Absolute farce, got the message, painted a grim picture, all-out-effort, heated debate, picking up the pieces, anybody's guess, high-ranking official, pool of blood, at this point in time, how does it feel?, probe, beat a hasty retreat, in due course, put into perspective, bid (for attempt), iron out the problem, quiz (for questioning), bolt from the blue, jobless youngsters, rushed to the scene, a brutal reminder, last but not the least, selling like hot cakes, calm before the storm, last minute decision, shot himself in the foot, calm but tense, leaps and bound, show of force, chequered career, leave no stone unturned, sitting on the fence, clampdown, loud and clear, square peg in a round hole, daylight robbery, major new developments, desperate attempt/bid, up in arms, stuck to his/her guns, marked contrast, dramatic decisions, vanished into thin air, dug in their heels, new move, mindless vandals, nipped in the bud, virtual standstill, effortless victory, over and above, weighty matter, fell on deaf ears, a whole new

ball game, get under way, saw the writing on the wall, given the green light.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Identify 10 common clichés that should be avoided in a broadcast news copy and attempt to replace such with an acceptable word or phrase or statement.

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3.2 Writing a Broadcast News Story [This section is partly adapted from Obe (2005:36-38), "Reporting Diverse Areas: A Concise Text"]

Broadcast news writers must have a clear understanding that they require enough space and paper to write and that they do not have the economy of space associated with newspapers and newsmagazines. They must therefore be vast and knowledgeable in broadcast news writing to overcome any challenge encountered. Since broadcast news reports are written for easy delivery, the font size should be big, about 32 points, while the double line or sometimes triple line spacing should be applied.

When writing a broadcast news story, the writer should begin every new story from a different page. For television copies, they should be positioned on the right half of the page while the left side is used for instructions on video or audio. These instructions are meant for only the newscasters and are usually written in capital letters while the actual story is written in small letters. Television copy is written on the right half of the page in a 40-character line. Each line will contain average of six words, and the newscaster will use about 25 lines per minute. When the story continues on the next page, -MORE- is used to indicate this. This is usually written in parentheses at the bottom of the page. It is also advised that you end a typical broadcast news story with a complete sentence. Should the story continue on the next page, it should begin with a new paragraph.

Samples of broadcast news stories adapted from already cited authors are reproduced here to guide you in practice and writing:

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Sample Radio Copy [Adapted from Oloruntola Sunday (n.d.)]

West Broadway

12- 30

1 - 11 - 88

Flanagan

Members of Citizens for the Preservation of West Broadway plan to gear up their petition drive again this weekend. The group began circulating petitions last weekend.

The petitions request the city council to repeal all previous ordinances and resolutions on the widening of the West Broadway. Many residents of the West Broadway area complain that the proposed widening project will damage its residential nature.

Petition drive coordinator Vera Hanson says the group is pleased with the show of support from residents all over Springfield.... But it wouldn't know exactly how many signatures it has until next week.

- Key for Sample Radio Copy

"West Broadway" is the slug for the story

"12 - 30" is the time of the newscast

"1 - 11 - 88" is the date of the broadcast

"Flanagan" is the name of the reporter

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Sample TV Copy [Adapted from Oloruntola Sunday (n.d.)]

Six 6 - 17 art

Jorgenson

MOC JORGENSON A lesson in art and architecture paid off for some Buchanan High School Students today. Ribbons were the prizes for entries in a sketch exhibit of scenery and buildings in the capital city area.

SOF: 27

NAT SND UNDER

VOICE OVER

KEY: BUCHANAN The Springfield art club sponsored the show and called in Springfield College art Professor Bill Ruess to judge the artwork.

HIGH SCHOOL

:00-05 Ruess says he was impressed by the students' skills, especially those who tried their hands at the different media for the first time.

- Key For Sample TV Copy

"Six" is the time of the newscast

"6-17" is the day of the broadcast

“art” is the slug for the story

“Jorgenson” is the name of the reporter

“MOC” means the person is live on camera with audio from this microphone

“SOF: 27” means there is sound on the film lasting 27 seconds

“NAT SND UNDER” means the film sound should be kept at a low level

“VOICEOVER” means the voice is from the anchor person in the studio speaking over the film that is being shown.

“KEY: BUCHANAN HIGH SCHOOL” indicates the title that should be shown over the film.

“00-05” indicates that the title should be shown five seconds after the report of the news items begins.

Example of a Newspaper Lead Rewritten for Broadcast

Newspaper Lead (Adapted from Mencher 2010):

- As Gov. Alfred Caster neared the end of his seven-day working vacation aboard a riverboat today, his aides said that he was
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unconcerned about editorial criticism that he had become an absentee governor whose administration was adrift.

Broadcast Lead:

- Some newspaper editorials have criticized Governor Caster as an absentee governor. But officials aboard a riverboat with the governor say the criticisms don't bother him. The governor is nearing the end of his seven-day working vacation on the boat.

SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE

Copy out two newspaper stories from the Punch newspaper and rewrite them for broadcast use.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Writing for the broadcast media is both tedious and interesting. An upcoming reporter or writer should pay attention to the details of doing this and do a lot of practice to master the art.

5.0 SUMMARY

This is unit re-emphasised some of the points discussed in the preceding units of this module. It is expected that you can now write a good broadcast story following the style and rules discussed in this unit.

6.0 TUTOR-MARKED ASSIGNMENT

1. Discuss five of some of the things you need to know as you prepare to write a broadcast news story.
2. Get any daily newspaper in Nigeria and rewrite its five top news stories into a radio news copy.

7.0 REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

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The Film Industry Associations

Film industry associations play crucial roles in advocating for the interests of professionals working in various aspects of the film industry, promoting industry standards, providing resources and support, and fostering collaboration and networking. Here are some notable film industry associations:

1. Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences (AMPAS): AMPAS is best known for organizing the annual Academy Awards, also known as the Oscars. It is composed of industry professionals, and its activities include recognizing excellence in filmmaking through the Oscars and supporting various educational and outreach initiatives.
2. Independent Film & Television Alliance (IFTA): IFTA represents independent producers

and distributors of film and television content worldwide. It provides support, advocacy, and networking opportunities for independent filmmakers and companies.

3. Producers Guild of America (PGA): The PGA represents film and television producers in the United States. It promotes the interests of producers, provides educational resources, and hosts events to facilitate networking and collaboration within the industry.

4. European Film Academy (EFA): EFA is an organization that promotes European cinema and fosters collaboration and exchange among European filmmakers. It organizes the annual European Film Awards and supports various initiatives to promote European cinema worldwide.

5. National Association of Theatre Owners (NATO): NATO represents cinema operators in the United States. It advocates for the interests of the exhibition sector, provides resources and support for its members, and promotes the cultural and economic importance of cinemas.

These are just a few examples of film industry associations, each playing a vital role in supporting and advancing the interests of professionals within the film industry.

Film Industry Regulatory Bodies in Nigeria

The Nigerian entertainment industry consists of bodies that regulate its activities. It also consists of associations that an entertainment practitioner (or an intending one) can identify with. This list contains both regulatory and professional bodies.

REGULATORY BODIES

□ The Nigerian Copyright Commission (NCC)

This is a body entrusted with the power to regulate, advise and monitor matters of copyright law in Nigeria. It was first established in 1989 as the Nigerian Copyright Council. Later in 1996, it became known as the Nigerian Copyright Commission. The NCC is a body corporate with perpetual succession and a common seal. It may sue and be sued in its corporate name. Section 34(3) of the Copyright Act 1988 provides for the statutory function of the commission viz:

1. The Commission shall be responsible for all matters affecting copyright in Nigeria as provided for in the Act.
2. It shall also monitor and supervise Nigeria's position in relation to international conventions and advise the government thereon.
3. It shall advise and regulate conditions for the conclusion of bilateral and multilateral agreement between Nigeria and any other country.
4. Enlighten and inform the public on matters relating to copyright.
5. Maintain an effective data bank on authors and their works.
6. Be responsible for such other matters as relating to copyright in Nigeria as the Minister may from time to time direct

□ National Film & Video Censor's Board

The National Film & Video Censor's Board is the regulatory body set up by the Act of the same name (No 85 of 1993) to regulate films and video industry in Nigeria. The Board is empowered to classify all films and videos whether imported or produced locally. It is also the duty of the Board

to register all films and videos outlets across the country and to keep a register of such registered outlets among other functions.

It is also the role of the Board to interface with relevant guilds and associations in the film industry for an effective implementation of policies.

□ National Broadcasting Commission (NBC)

The NBC is established by section 1 of the NBC Act, laws of the federation of Nigeria, 2004 and is the main regulator of the broadcasting industry in Nigeria. The Commission in its advisory capacity to the Federal Government regularly adopts scientific research methods to gather data, analyse trends in line with the dynamism of the industry and advise government accordingly. The Commission has the responsibility to receive, process and consider applications for the establishment, ownership and operation of radio and TV stations including cable television service, direct satellite broadcast and any other medium of broadcasting; radio and TV stations owned, established or operated by the federal, state and local government and stations run under private ownership.

PROFESSIONAL BODIES

□ Musical Copyright Society of Nigeria (MCSN)

The MCSN is a collective body similar to the COSON. There have been uncertainties as to the status of the MCSN as an additional collecting society. However, they recently won a suit against COSON to be joined as an additional collecting society by the NCC.

□ Actors' Guild of Nigeria (AGN)

This is an umbrella body that regulates and represents the affairs of film actors in Nigeria and abroad.

□ Directors' Guild of Nigeria

This is an entertainment guild which serves as the umbrella body for film and TV directors in the Nigerian motion picture industry.

□ Screen Writers' Guild of Nigeria

This is an umbrella body made up of screen writers.

□ Nigerian Society of Cinematographers

□ Creative Designers' Guild of Nigeria

The Creative Designers' Guild of Nigeria is one of the guilds in Nollywood, Nigerian film industry. The guild is responsible for the creative arts department of the industry. It has four departments namely: Property managers, makeup artists, Costume designers and set designers.

□ Association of Nigerian Theatre Practitioners

This was formed by the Yoruba-genre filmmakers.

□ Motion Picture Association of Nigeria (MPAN)

MPAN is largely made up of filmmakers of the Hausa genre. It was incorporated in 2004 by the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC).

□ Performing Musicians' Association of Nigeria (PMAN)

It protects and promotes the interests of musicians in the West African nation of Nigeria. The

organization also has responsibility to regulate the practice of music profession in the country.

The PMAN is authorized by the Trade Union Congress Act.

Other relevant bodies are:

- Association of Movie practitioners (AMP)
- Association of Film Video Producers and Marketers Association of Nigeria.
- Association of Movie Producers
- National Association of Nigerian Theatre Arts Practitioners
- Television Producers' Association of Nigeria
- Advertising Practitioners Council of Nigeria
- Committee of National Guild Association
- Yoruba Film Video Producers and Marketers Association of Nigeria
- All Nigeria Conference of Evangelical Drama Ministers
- Conference of Motion Picture Practitioners of Nigeria
- United Film Rentals Association of Nigeria